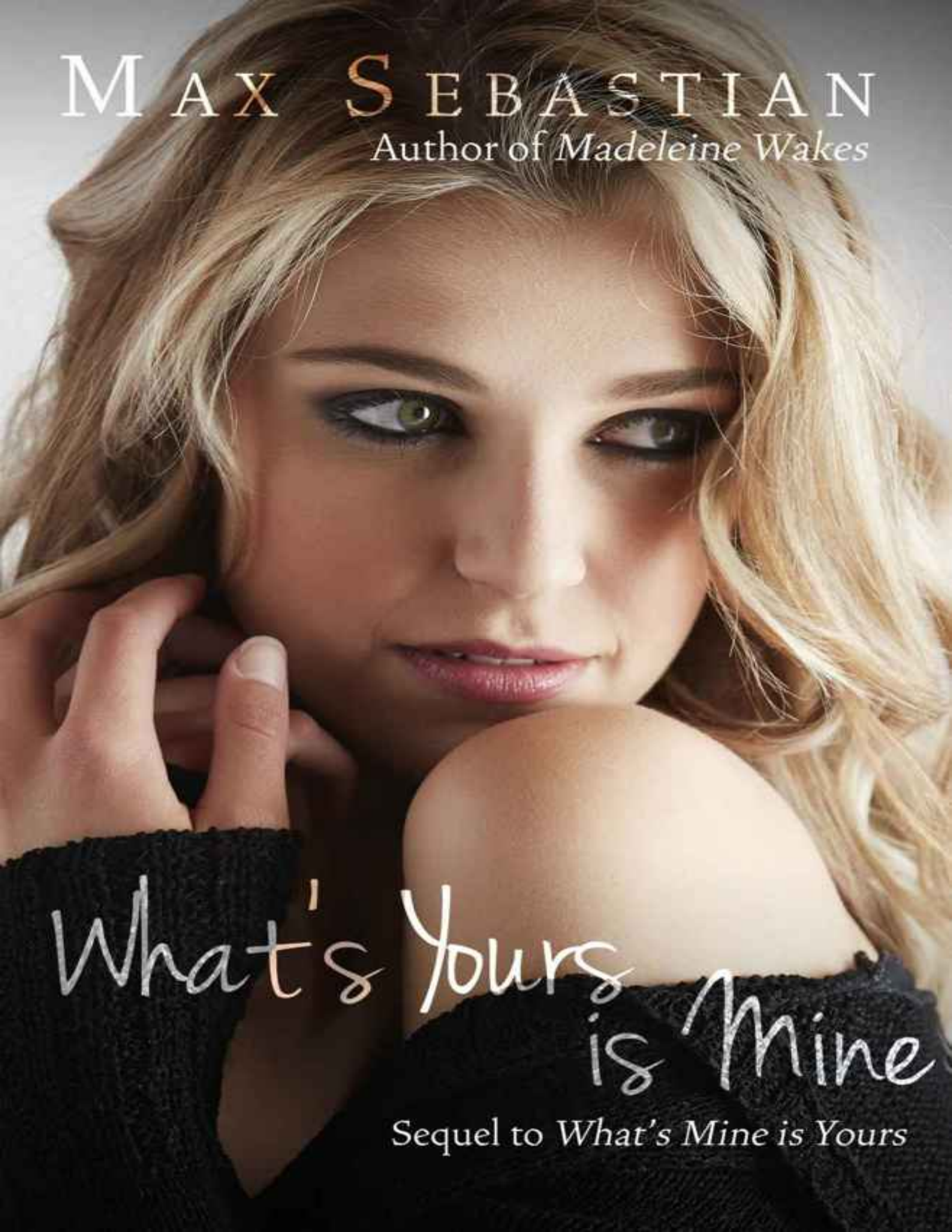




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What's Yours
is Mine

Sequel to *What's Mine is Yours*

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Prologue

Never sleep with your friend's girlfriend — even if he's no longer going out with her at the time.

That was a rule I learned in college. What was the worst that could happen if you followed that mantra? So you didn't get to date your friend's hot former squeeze. There are plenty of fish in the sea, et cetera, et cetera.

And maybe there's a good reason your friend ended it with her, anyway.

In school, when we were all experiencing our first crushes, there I was with a thing for Laura Rushmore. But my best friend at the time, Paulie Silversmith, had broadcast it around our little circle that he was targeting Laura for himself.

When Laura had ended up suggesting, via her stuttering BFF, Marcia Swinton, that I ask her to the school spring dance, I was put in a bit of a bind. I danced with Laura, sure. I enjoyed my first make-out session with her shortly afterwards. And that was it for my friendship with Paulie Silversmith.

The step up to university distracted me from the loss of that friendship, but it also probably meant I had lessons still to learn in the field of stealing girlfriends. I was going to learn that lesson with Magda Swietek.

Magda was a sweet little Polish girl who was dating my roommate Eddie Dorlen freshman year. I was a little surprised at developing a crush on her, particularly since I spent so much time with Eddie, and relied on our friendship to get through the shock of higher education.

In mitigation, I kept to myself until a few months after they broke up. Even so, with hindsight I should have simply lost all contact with her.

Magda was nice enough, of course, though looking back she wasn't worth the loss of an important friendship. I'd felt fairly safe going for her, too, because Eddie had dumped her, not the other way around. Only later did I come to understand that he didn't want to see his ex every time we met up for a drink.

The fact that Eddie was at the centre of my whole social circle at university by the time I came to ask Magda out hadn't even occurred to me

when I did it — so when I drifted away from him for understandable reasons, I was somewhat isolated.

At first the sex diverted my attention from the loss of my entire social circle. There was a reason the rest of us had called her “Magda Cum Laude” while she’d been dating Eddie.

“Sean, I blow-job you.” Her English was pretty good — so much better than any of my half-hearted attempts to learn another language — but it still raised a smile sometimes.

“You mean you want to give me a blow-job?”

“I want give you? No. I take.”

“You want me to give you a blow-job?”

“How you doing that?” She was sweet, that one.

Then long-term stability set in to our relationship, and the veneer came off Magda Swietek. Surprisingly, it became clear to me that my crush on her had been very much based on her being someone else’s girlfriend. When we were out in pubs and clubs, and she’d been on Eddie’s arm, she’d always been kind of flirty with me, and knowing she was off-limits had only enhanced her desirability in my eyes. When we were boyfriend and girlfriend, she lost that hint of mischief, that wicked flirtatiousness she’d had when she was dating my friend.

I felt pretty stupid, throwing away my friendship with Eddie only to realise Magda didn’t live up to my crush.

After Magda, though, I realized what I’d lost in getting her. I’d dated her for twice as long as Eddie had, but I think most of that time I spent trying to prove to myself that she was worth the loss of our friendship. But, the damage was done, and I came out of college without the usual collection of close friends. Even now, I don’t keep in touch with those guys.

I vowed never to go for any girl again if she had even vague links to a friend of mine.

*

But Katie Milton had been different. She came long after my vow.

She came after I left university, after I went to journalism school, after I arrived in London with big dreams of becoming a hotshot reporter on a national newspaper, and after the whole media industry seemed to crash into the doldrums of a massive recession — combined with a digital revolution that was killing print — leaving me scrabbling about for any job I could get.

I had met Katie Milton at a party thrown by an old friend of mine from high school, who had decided against a career in journalism in favor of an assault on the medical world. Grant Dixon.

I'd always kidded Grant at school for wanting to be a doctor when he fainted at the sight of blood. He was insistent that people would always need doctors, and doctors would always have a healthy salary. I was smug in my worthiness because I was destined for the creative arts, doing things for love and beauty rather than for money.

But when it came to it, he became a surgeon, while I found myself jumping between jobs on failing magazines, hopping from place to place just as everything was crumbling around me thanks to the popularity of online news. Grant had seen off his phobia and excelled in the pursuit of a healthy pay packet, while I had lost my footing and faltered.

I didn't begrudge Grant his success, and with a lack of college buddies to hang out with, I kept in regular, if not frequent, touch with him. I attended his parties, which was his way of showing the progress he was making — each year, a bigger apartment, more extravagant furniture and fittings, a more impressive car sitting outside on the street.

Grant seemed to like to have me at his parties as one of the few in attendance who did not hold the power over life or death.

"You've got to have some non-medic blood in the mix," he explained to me once, when I remarked how he kept inviting me to these damn things. "When you get too many medics together outside a hospital, they tend to try to drink their way back into the hospital."

When I rocked up to the party at which I met Katie Milton, I was actually in pretty good spirits having confirmed a gig doing the nightshift on a national newspaper.

Oh, it was only a subeditor role — essentially just correcting the spelling and grammar in the newspaper copy — but I could tell people I was a journalist on a national newspaper. In a room full of scalpel jockeys, I could

impress people with my creative air, invoking the ghosts of Graham Greene, Ernest Hemingway, Hunter S Thompson and so on.

Katie Milton was wise to my act — or at least cynical about the rose-tinted hue in which I was dressing up my life.

“You’re a hack, basically,” was how she put it. “One pay check away from unemployment?”

How could I possibly deny it?

“I’m a hack with half a million regular readers.”

“And shitty hours. Come on, hack, I need another drink.”

It didn’t seem to dissuade her from talking to me, though. In fact, I still had my non-medical status going for me, she seemed to take it as a breath of fresh air that I wasn’t in any way connected with surgery or any other part of her world, and decided to spend much of the rest of the evening with me.

For most of the night, I didn’t even think to hit on her. Her ability to see through my little Boho facade made me assume nothing was going to cut it with her, so I didn’t even try. Instead, I found myself propping up the bar, trying to figure out what my next strategy should be to find someone who might want to go home with a certain national newspaper journalist — and Katie decided to sit with me and pass cutting judgment on any female who might come near enough for me to consider.

Katie was bright — obviously, being another trainee surgeon — but also funny, achingly pretty with her green eyes, hint of freckles, honey-colored hair tied back in a pony tail, and a smile that was sweet on the surface yet hid a certain sardonic nature.

Close to midnight, however, when she came back from an extended visit to the restroom, there was a glint in her eye.

“I know something about you,” she said conspiratorially.

I gave a mock sigh, “Did Grant tell you about my third nipple?”

She raised an eyebrow, “Touch of polythelia, huh? No, this is about Grant trying to set you up with Victoria Basset.”

I felt my ears burn.

“Set me up?”

“She’s an anesthetist,” Katie said, and now seemed to be looking me over as though assessing my suitability for this girl from whom Grant had me in mind. “Or at least, I think she is judging from her level of conversation.”

Katie hammed up a yawn to add to her not-so-subtle warning.

“So she’s probably planning on knocking you out, dragging you off home.”

“Which one’s Victoria Basset?”

“Brunette. Skinny. Big breasts, long legs. High maintenance if you ask me — you’re better off avoiding.”

I looked across the room to where Katie’s gaze was pointed, to see that Victoria Basset was certainly pretty enough, but as far as I was concerned, not a patch on Katie herself. I remembered Grant introducing me to her earlier that evening, when I’d politely nodded and smiled but hadn’t dwelled to speak with her much, feeling that awkward lack of chemistry that suggested to me fairly clearly that we weren’t compatible.

Why had Grant felt it appropriate to set me up with her? It was flattering in a way — she was attractive, after all. At the time, I got the impression that my old friend was beginning to feel embarrassed that I never seemed to have a girlfriend when I attended his parties, I was always here to hit on drunken doctors.

Sure, there was a small part of me that regretted missing the chance for a one night fling with Victoria if it was guaranteed — and I was sure it would be no longer than one night. But that evening, the more interesting aspect of Grant trying to set me up with Victoria Basset was that it seemed to set Katie firmly onto my scent.

“Hey, you know what would be wild?” she asked.

“What would be wild?”

“You and me walking out of here right in front of Victoria Basset.”

I couldn’t resist her impish grin.

Making some kind of point as we walked out in front of the host and the anesthetist, I shared a slightly perplexed glance with Grant as I considered the fact that, for the first time, a woman had stolen me from the clutches of another woman.

Out on the street, Katie hailed a cab, and I fully expected our evening to be over — she’d had her little game stealing Victoria Basset’s intended date, so why go on with it? But the cab stayed where it was at the curb, Katie with the door wide open, looking out at me saying: “You coming?”

When we got back to her place, I waited politely behind her as she opened the front door, ready for a goodbye and even perhaps an attempt at a quiet peck on the cheek.

Door open, she turned to me and said: “You realize Grant’s going to ask you what happened with me after we left?”

“Probably,” I nodded.

She said: “And he’ll tell Victoria Basset, since he’ll need someone else to take the blame for his failure to set her up with a Hemingway-to-be.”

I wondered just what she had against Victoria Basset, and the first thing that came to my mind was that perhaps Victoria Basset had once stolen Katie’s boyfriend.

“I’m sure he will,” I said, while being sure of nothing of the sort, since I simply didn’t know Grant all that well these days. I was curious to see just where Katie was going with this.

“So you’re going to need a good story to tell Grant, aren’t you?” she said. “He was fairly set on the idea of you going out with Victoria Basset. Like it was a personal mission or something. He’ll need a good explanation for why you bailed.”

“He won’t care.”

“He’ll think you’re just a boring newspaper boy, not worth an invite to the next one of these.”

“I’m sure I can come up with some suitable story.”

She stared at me a moment, then shook her head. “No, I have to be more certain than that. These parties are so boring, if you don’t get an invite to the next one, I’ll have to find something else to do. Come on.”

I followed her up the stairs to her little apartment, insisting as we went: “Honestly, I’ll make something up — he’ll be fine.”

When we got to her front door, she said: “What will you say? Tell me.”

I was a little confused. I said: “I don’t know... I’ll say we went back to your place, fooled around a little.”

“Not a little. And if you say you went back to my place, he’ll ask you about it.”

She swung the door open, flicked on the lights, and bade me enter her apartment, the look on her face suggesting that I might as well see the inside of her place if I was going to be telling Grant I’d been here.

“What will you say we did?” she asked, dropping her keys in a bowl on the side table in the tiny little hallway inside her front door.

“Will he really want to know details?”

“He’s a surgeon, like me. His whole career is about details.”

I followed her through into a tiny little abode — one room that held a bed, a desk and a wardrobe, with doors leading off into a tiny bathroom and a tiny kitchen.

“You’re really worried he’s going to try to pick holes in my story?”

“I’m certain of it.”

“Okay,” I nodded as she removed her coat and draped it over the chair in front of her desk. “So what do you think my story should be?”

She turned to me, and stepped closer. She said: “I’m not sure. I’m a surgeon, not a writer. I don’t really have that kind of imagination.”

“So what do we do?”

“We do enough so you’ve got something to tell Grant about next time you see him,” she said, launching herself at me. “You’re not in need of sleep, are you?”

Whether or not Victoria Basset had once stolen a man from Katie Milton or not, I never found out, but that night I made the assumption she had, and that when women did this kind of thing to each other, the rage they felt was on a level far beyond that which men felt when they had their girlfriends or ex-girlfriends pinched.

She sat me down on her bed, as though it was merely a couch, while she went away to fetch something to drink. When she returned, her skirt was gone and she was wearing a sexy set of black lingerie, complete with thigh-high stockings.

“You think this is a good outfit for me to wear in your story?” she asked, a hint of mischief in her eyes. “I just bought these.”

Jesus, she looked like a high-class call girl.

“It’s perfect,” I said, feeling my heart pounding and my manhood bursting at the seams as she stepped over, placing a couple of empty wine glasses and a chilled bottle of Sauvignon Blanc on her desk before taking a seat on the edge of the bed beside me.

“Good,” she purred, swinging one leg over mine, and turning in to offer me a kiss.

It might have been some kind of revenge thing, but that didn’t take away from the chemistry we had from that first touch. Kissing Katie was soft, sensual, sweet, and despite her urgent need to give me an experience that would filter back to her rival, it was unhurried with no short cuts taken.

Having no idea where she was taking this, nor how far she would want to run with it, I allowed her to lead me. She was the one who encouraged my

hands to roam all over her body, to kiss down her neck and her chest, and slip her breasts out from the black lacy bra so I could tease her hard little nipples with my tongue.

She was the one who unfastened my shirt buttons, kissing my mouth tenderly as she swept her hand over the contours of my bare chest.

She was the one who guided my hands between her legs to feel the heat that lay under the thin black lace of her underwear.

She was the one who pulled down my pants and said my story should definitely include the fact that she had sucked my cock like a living goddess.

“And how does a living goddess suck cock?” I asked, the alcohol in my system lending me a little mischief.

“Like this,” she said, peeling my boxer shorts sufficiently down over my thighs to reveal my swollen manhood, which she now curled one hand around, her eyes lighting up with desire.

She stroked my shaft a few times before her tongue slipped out of her pretty mouth to dance around my tip.

I was more than a little surprised — honestly, I hadn’t seen this coming at all. At the party, I’d looked at Katie Milton as someone out of my league who had deemed to sit with me because I was a suitable foil for her to broadcast her cynical verdicts on the other women around us.

And here I was in her apartment with her lips stretching around my cock.

But who was I to object? I was happy enough to do whatever it took to provide this trainee surgeon with a revenge story suitable for her rival. Especially if it meant sitting there as the trainee surgeon in question bobbed up and down on my cock, swirling her tongue around my sensitive tip, licking me and sucking me as though I were her favorite dessert.

Was it made more filthy because at the party, she’d seemed like a respectable young woman, commanding a certain recognition and dignity because of her specialized profession? Perhaps.

Perhaps I had the feeling that this was a one-time-only deal, wreaking revenge on Victoria Basset.

Perhaps I did buy in to the need for us both to have a story to tell afterwards — not just for Grant’s ears, but any friend we might need to surprise with a little hitherto unknown anecdote to prove we were not merely the boring kind of people who left parties early.

I could certainly do with a new anecdote in my life. Hey, maybe with the new job, my life was finally turning around.

“Hold on, hold on, hold on.”

I was forced to stop her before our mutual anecdote came to a premature end.

“Huh?” she looked up at me, confused.

I said: “You want to make Victoria Basset jealous, right?”

“Of course.”

“So really, I should be the one making you come, right?”

I was a little surprised by my own boldness, though it was all nicely cushioned by the booze. She looked at me a moment, and then nodded.

“I have some condoms somewhere,” she said.

I shook my head, “Not yet.”

She looked a trifle confused as I turned the tables on her, urging her onto her back, crawling between her stocking-clad legs, kissing my way up her thighs. She smelled a little of cinnamon and sandalwood as I ventured up to the edge of her panties, where her flesh was so searingly hot.

Then as I nudged aside her underwear and slipped my tongue into her tender folds, I glanced up to see the confusion in her face melt into enlightenment, and then pure desire.

“Oh damn...” she said, collapsing back on the bed to give in to my hunger for her soaking sex, “you really aren’t a medical man...”

I dragged her panties down her thighs, seeing how she’d put her suspenders on underneath them, for easy removal. I think I was surprised at how she was shaved other than a tidy bush on her mound, something I’d never seen before among the girls I’d dated.

It seemed ultra sexy to me, and also a suggestion to me that this girl was far above my pay grade in the dating world.

This whole night had seemed slightly unworldly to me, and now I was with her like this, the fact we were both talking about this as a one night stand made me feel a strange sense of confidence — that I could really let go, and not worry about how this girl might see me afterwards.

She stroked my head as I french-kissed her pussy, sucking on her succulent savory lips, squeezing my tongue into her hot, wet hole, nudging her clit with my nose and top lip.

The way she tilted her head back and cried made me feel so powerful. The way she writhed under me, her chest heaving as she fought to draw in

enough breath, spurred me on.

And the sense that this was my one-and-only night with this creature, that I'd lucked out on such a beauty, that come the sober morning she might wonder why she took such a loser into her bed — it meant I didn't want any of this to end.

She was in no rush either, enjoying that I was obviously an aficionado about this, while perhaps other men she'd dated were not. So who knew how long I spent there, though I guess you could have measured the time in orgasms, since she went through three slow, pulsing climaxes as my tongue worked on her.

At last, she pulled me up, kissed me, hauled me over onto my back.

"You've done that before," she joked, though looking at me with surprise imprinted in her flushed face.

That I could surprise her seemed like a real achievement to me. That I could impress such an impressive young woman made me feel more accomplished than ever before.

"Not like that," I said.

Beaming at me as she tucked her hair behind her ear, she leaned over me to take my hardness in her delicate surgeon's hands, ensuring it was fully up to speed before she reached for her bedside table, and the box of condoms therein.

Fully protected, she lifted a stocking-clad leg to straddle me.

I felt her fingers fumble with my shaft, line me up, touch the tip of my hardness to her searing hot entrance.

Then she sank on me, and I could hardly believe that I was inside her, that the heavenly pussy of this gorgeous, accomplished woman was crushing my lowly manhood.

She was so wet as she rose and fell on my shaft, I could hear the slickness of the friction between us. I held her hips as she rocked on me, so graceful, so lewd in that black lingerie.

"You feel so good..." she moaned, her face strained by the pleasure flowing through her.

I touched her breasts as she rode me, fondled her, wedging her hard nipples between my fingers, making her gasp.

She looked at me, now, without that hint of humor in her eyes — this was no longer about creating a filthy story with which to taunt her rival, Victoria

Basset. Katie had very real desire in her gaze on me, as if I had accidentally stumbled upon the key to her inner self, the self that her humor shielded.

I manhandled her now, off me and onto the bed. Yet she did not lie on her back as I thought she would. She lay on her stomach, pushing her rear up as an invitation.

Glancing at me over her shoulder, she was no longer giggling about all this, she was biting her lip in anticipation, she was desperate for me to continue, to slide back inside her and make her pant, make her scream.

It felt so animalistic at first, but then she pushed herself up on her hands, and reached for a kiss, showing me real affection, not just feverish lust.

Ultimately we collapsed into a slow, leisurely conclusion, so that I lay by her side, my thick cock sliding inside her from behind in a kind of spoon position, though one in which she could turn her shoulders toward me, slip her hand around my neck and suck gently on my lips as we both came together, my cock throbbing and pulsing as I pumped my hot seed inside her, contained within a latex sheath.

Once spent, we remained there, enjoying our closeness, continuing to explore our slow sensual kiss.

And it felt to me that this was more than just a one night stand.

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Grant rang me a few days later to debrief me on the evening and reveal — as though I didn't know already — that he had actually been intending to set me up with someone else. I'd been all ready to divulge the agreed facts about my night with Katie to him, but as I was warming up to it, he came straight out and said he'd heard I had quite a night with her.

"She told you?" I asked him, wondering why she'd been so concerned about me telling him the tale.

"Couldn't stop her, filthy wench," Grant said. "You do realize you're now like some kind of sexual legend within the surgical community?"

I felt a little warm tingle between my legs. "Well, it was just one night," I said, playing it all down.

“I gave her your number — you don’t mind, do you? Seemed pretty keen on a repeat engagement.”

Suddenly, I was rock hard between the legs. Really? The sex goddess Katie Milton really wanted to see yours truly again?

“Sure... I mean, great, I’d love to,” I stammered, a trifle breathless.

And so a one night stand with the wrong girl turned into a string of carnal encounters with a trainee surgeon who was as sharp and witty as she was beautiful.

I was quickly hooked, and it seemed, just as quickly Katie became Mrs Sean Ruskin.

Surely, that was all the proof I needed that to succeed in a relationship, I simply had to keep away from friends’ girls, and make my own way among the fairer sex.

Only, one day five years later, I came home to find Katie wanting out of our marriage — our jobs had us leading separate lives, and the growing distance between us had proven too much for Katie. She needed more. At the time, I didn’t have much of an answer for her.

She let me stay in our home until I sorting out other arrangements, but it wasn’t long after we separated that I found her in bed with another man. The new man in her life was none other than Grant Dixon, the friend who had essentially brought us together. I later discovered that they’d enjoyed a ‘friends with benefits’ relationship since they were teenagers, and while I was told it had stopped while Katie and I were together, the quickness with which they began sleeping together after our separation left me with lingering doubts.

I did feel betrayed by my wife. Yet the anger I should have felt on losing Katie was tempered, and almost totally negated, by my deep-rooted feeling that what had happened was some kind of karma. I had spent my youth picking up women from my friends. Karma seemed to have brought me full circle, then, to lose my girl to a friend in return.

*

In my defense, I was totally set up to break my rule on friends’ girls.

When my marriage collapsed, I was fortunate to be taken in by my colleague and fellow night shifter Henry Robinson. He and his wife had a spare room, and it was available if I needed it. I gratefully accepted the offer, and soon became integrated into their little household, within a small apartment in the Chiswick area of West London.

It was Henry who subtly encouraged me to socialize with his young wife Michelle. At first it seemed to give her another buddy to take out on evenings when I had a night off, but her husband was working. Later, Michelle had revealed Henry's strange desire for her to seduce me — for he and I to share her.

If she'd been single, and had wanted me to take her to bed, I would have jumped at the chance. Michelle was such a pretty brunette, perhaps five years younger than Henry and I, and worked as a yoga and fitness instructor, giving her a divine physique to go with her dazzling smile.

But it took a while for me to get my head around the idea of her husband, my good friend Henry, actually wanting me to sleep with her. I mean, at that stage with Katie seeming to get all our friends after our marriage imploded, Henry had basically been the only remaining friend I had left in the world. I didn't want to lose him over something so obvious as sleeping with his wife.

I think what got me seeing things as Henry saw them was after I started forming a bond with Michelle, and knew that when she wasn't sleeping with me, she was sleeping with Henry. If I imagined her as mine, then I had to accept that I was also sharing her — she was by no means being exclusive with me as a lover.

The surprise, I think, was how arousing it seemed to me, the idea of sharing her.

It wasn't that I didn't care that my lover was seeing another man. It wasn't that I simply had no ability to feel jealousy or hurt from knowing she was in the arms of another. In fact, I did feel a crushing sensation in my stomach whenever she left me to slip into Henry's bed. I felt that burning sensation in my chest at the thought of someone else pleasuring her, someone else's cock penetrating her — and I loved it.

It might have seemed odd that Michelle was seeing another man, while Henry as husband was committed only to his wife. But I soon learned that this wasn't simply about seeing other people. This was about experiencing Michelle's sexuality in various forms — heavy on the voyeurism,

particularly as Henry and I became comfortable opening up about the woman we shared.

He had no interest in other women. He wanted only to experience his beloved wife, and how she might be pleased not only by himself, but by others as well. And when he did know that she was seeing other men, somehow that strengthened his bond with his wife. He trusted that she would share all the details of her encounters with me, thereby involving him. He knew that she would always come back to him after being with me — and on knowing she'd just been with another man, Henry was biologically driven to sleep with her himself, to reclaim her. His desire for her was enhanced by her infidelity.

Henry and Michelle showed me how different a marriage could be to the preconceived idea conventional society had given Katie and I. Here was a couple who avoided the trap of settling into an increasingly platonic relationship as their marriage progressed.

At the heart of it, I guessed, was a really strong ability to communicate. They shared everything between them — I soon had to accept that my time with Michelle was never going to be private between just us.

I envied them this closeness, and found myself wishing I had the same thing with Katie.

Increasingly as I accepted my role as the other man in this little threesome, I craved the role as husband, with Katie as my wife. I wanted to commit to her, I wanted to explore her sexuality, I wanted to play with that strange taboo of letting my beloved be pleased beyond belief by others as well as myself.

And yet I had the benefit of a close relationship with Henry. We'd talk about how he felt, and about how I felt, about what was happening between us.

But during this strange summer romance of mine with Michelle, and in a way, Henry, I had lost touch with Katie. I wanted to go back to her, tell her that I could change, that I could give her the attention she needed — and that other men might as well. Would she even entertain the possibility of reconciliation? She had left me, after all. I could only hope she would want to get to know the new man I'd become.

Chapter One | An unconventional relationship

I was out in a bar with Michelle in the middle of Soho when I ran into Laura Kitteridge.

Strange, but after so many months away from Katie, under the impression that our friends had sided with her after our separation, since they had for the most part always been her friends to begin with, it seemed a surprise to run into one of them and not have them blank me.

I'd left Michelle at the bar to duck out to the men's room, and then on my way back through the crowd in that darkened place, I felt a soft hand on my shoulder and my name called.

"Sean, it is you. I thought it was."

I turned to find Laura clutching a gin and tonic, her gray eyes saturated with pity and curiosity.

"Laura, how's things?"

She smiled, "Things are great, actually. Pete just got a big promotion, so we're finally in a place where maybe, you know, we can start on the next step."

"Big step. How many you think you'll want?"

"I don't know. Two, probably. I'm hoping for a little girl, Pete's hoping for a boy."

I nodded and looked interested, trying to encourage her to keep our brief conversation on the topic of herself, so that I might avoid an interrogation. I failed.

"Never mind me — how are things with you? You're looking fantastic."

"Thanks... I have a new fitness instructor. Very effective."

"I noticed you're with someone tonight..."

I shrugged, but then reconsidered downplaying the signs of my having moved on from Katie. I had to have some pride, and even if word did get back to Katie that I was seeing someone else, she had to expect that by now.

I smiled, “I guess you could say I get on very well with my fitness instructor.”

“Pretty cute,” Laura beamed, and seemed relieved that I was dating again, despite the fact that she was Katie’s friend more than mine.

“Michelle. She’s pretty great, actually.”

“She coming to the wedding?” Laura was referring to the upcoming nuptials of Alicia Milton, Katie’s little sister, which I was only too aware was coming up in just a few days. I was supposed to be an usher on Alicia’s request, but rather wished I’d been able to duck out and avoid seeing Katie’s family after our break-up.

I guessed that Laura’s question was more than just a polite inquiry — the question of whether my date would be my plus one at the wedding would confirm her exact status, at least in Laura’s eyes. I said, “Well, we’ve only been seeing each other a couple months...”

Laura nodded, then swallowed nervously. She had something bugging her, and was clearly in two minds about sharing it with me.

“So...” I said, hinting that this was only really going to be a brief conversation, and that both of us ought to be getting back to our own evenings.

It was enough to prompt Laura into coming out with it.

“I’m really sorry...” she said in a low voice, her eyes blazing with the shock of what she was trying to impart to me. “It’s just I did notice after you left to go to the restroom... well... she was kind of... well...”

“What was she doing?”

“I think she was chatting up another guy.”

“Oh,” I said.

“I’m sure it was nothing... I wouldn’t mention it, but... well, you’ve already been hurt, Sean...”

“It’s okay.”

“She was giving him her number,” Laura added.

I could have told Laura that the guy she’d been chatting up was simply a prospective customer, that she had been simply giving him a sales pitch for her yoga classes or her fitness classes. Only, the way Laura looked at me with such pity, marking me down silently as a failed husband and pitiful human being, I fancied startling her a little.

I gave a calm nod, attempting to look as though none of this was in the least bit surprising to me. It shouldn’t have been, really, except that

Michelle hadn't really made any moves to start seeing other guys beyond me and Henry yet. "Nothing wrong with that," I said. "She's polyamorous."

"Polyamorous?" Laura looked blankly at me.

"It's no big deal," I said, oozing nonchalance. "It's quite common over in the States, which is where she's originally from."

"Polyamorous, of course."

It sounded as though Laura was a little confused as to what the word meant, but was making as though she was okay with it because she was so polite. It wasn't exactly a common concept within the social circles through which she normally moved. She'd probably go home and Google the word, and even then she'd be wondering if I'd really been serious.

"Well, I'm glad that you're happy, anyway, Sean," she said, glancing over to the bar, where I could see Michelle clearly flirting away, looking up at a tall dark stranger with wide eyes and a broad smile — even touching his forearm gently as they chatted, offering him a clear signal though her wedding ring was actually visible on her finger.

"It was good seeing you, Laura."

"I guess I'll catch you at the wedding," she said.

"You certainly will," I nodded. "Looking forward to it."

As she scurried away, I just stood there with my drink, trying not to think about Alicia's wedding. I was dreading being submerged in Katie's family and friends so many months after she'd separated from me. And of course, Katie herself would be there, and I was dreading how that would feel.

I turned to watch Michelle having a lot of fun making eyes at the guy at the bar. Watching her, knowing how I'd felt about her in the early days when I'd come to live with her and her husband following the end of my marriage, made me feel that I'd definitely grown as a person over the past six months. I could appreciate her beauty, and the excitement she clearly felt in flirting with someone else. I had learned about this unconventional view on marriage and relationships that Michelle and Henry held, I had accepted it and even come to crave it myself.

But in this particular case, I knew my friend Henry might want to know what was going on during my night off, while he was stuck at work. I texted him.

>Just came out of the bathroom to find your sweet wife standing at the bar and hitting on somebody.

I didn't know how much he and Michelle had been planning for her to make the moves on somebody else, but I felt certain that whatever the case, Henry would get a kick out of knowing his wife was being naughty on her night out with me.

Henry's rapid reply to my text told me that he was probably sitting there at his desk at our newspaper, phone in front of him, monitoring the situation in case Michelle had felt like sending him any teasing texts. Ever since I'd taken Michelle for a dirty weekend in Paris, we knew how much Henry appreciated getting those little updates, keeping him in the loop, involving him in his wife's consensual infidelity, tweaking his jealousy muscle in the build-up to her ultimate debauchery.

>Fantastic. She like the look of him?

I replied:

>Seems to. He's a big guy, just her type ;-)

I took a few steps closer, but remained a healthy distance from the pretty brunette at the bar. I could see she had her own mobile phone sitting there on the bar next to her, and its screen briefly lit up to signal the arrival of a text message, no doubt from her husband.

Michelle glanced down at it, and then I saw her smile to herself before looking up at her new friend again, trying to look as though nothing had happened. As though her husband hadn't just sent her a text saying he knew she was flirting with a guy at the bar, and he approved unconditionally.

I had another text from him within a few moments.

>Told her she should go for it if she wants to. You want to see her being a bad girl, Sean? ;-)

My own reply:

>Absolutely ;-)

I saw her glance over her shoulder, trying to keep casual, as she looked for me in the gloom. Our eyes briefly connected, and I gave her a quiet nod and an amused smile that she should have found herself a new man so soon after I'd excused myself.

She grinned, and made it look as though she was responding to something the new guy had said, but I could see how buzzed she was at being cleared to misbehave if she wanted to. Then I watched as she excused herself to look at her phone and tap out a short text message even while their conversation at the bar continued.

Henry texted me:

>Okay, she says she likes him, she's going to see what happens. He's called Rick, by the way. Keep me updated.

>Will do.

Rick. She was so open towards him, touching him as they stood sipping their drinks, brushing his arm subtly but fairly clearly, leaning forward to offer him glimpses down her top, her eyes never leaving his.

It was amusing to notice just how much of her flirting I recognized from her doing it with me. Now, though, as I watched, I was detached from the process somehow — and therefore able to appreciate and even share in the excitement she felt, rather than being overwhelmed by the thrill of such a pretty girl coming on to me.

Rick seemed polite and clean-cut, and clearly couldn't quite believe his luck. To start with, he appeared to be expecting her to get up and leave at any point. Then he began to relax, the tension left his bearing.

The atmosphere for me was electric, so intense even though I was only a boyfriend, not the husband. Watching her sending signals to him, less and less subtle. Toying with her hair, licking her lips, arching her back to emphasize her cleavage.

The guy looked as though he'd won the lottery when she virtually dragged him out of the place, but Michelle did give a quick look around for me, to ensure I was on board regarding their move to the next place. I wasn't entirely sure where she was going, or what she was planning, but I knew for a fact she liked to go dancing.

Sure enough, she led him through the bustling Soho streets to a club nearby, close enough to make it easy for me to tail them.

*

I switched to soda while they were in the club. I didn't want to lose control, and I also felt a certain amount of responsibility for Michelle as her secret chaperone. But I could see Michelle knocking back shot after shot while they danced the night away, grinding up against each other, constantly gazing in each others' eyes, beaming smiles at each other.

It was a while before I even noticed that she'd removed her wedding ring.

I'd been keeping Henry updated all evening, and this little factoid was definitely worth sharing.

Henry's reply explained all:

>I told her to, in case she freaked him out.

It sent a shiver down my back for some reason. I think it was the sense that Henry really had offered his wife the freedom to decide what she wanted to do. If she wanted to go home with the guy, she could.

It wasn't long before her arms were around him, and a tentative little kiss on the lips descended into a forceful embrace between the two of them, Michelle going wild with her new man.

I could see the glow in her face as she made out with him, the slight sheen of perspiration over her forehead. She had to be tingling all over as his strong hands roamed all over her petite, trim body. And I was rock-hard just watching her.

Henry kept demanding to know what was going on, so I gave him as detailed a text commentary as I could.

But as the clock ticked over into the next day, I was startled by a firm hand clamping to my shoulder, and there was my friend standing right there next to me in the flesh.

"Henry!" I hissed. "What the hell are you doing here?"

He shrugged, "I think it's a touch of man-flu. Sue bought it, anyway. I'm off sick."

I rolled my eyes, then flicked my head to point him in the direction of his philandering wife, if he hadn't spotted her already.

"Magnificent, isn't she?" he said, then to me: "How are you feeling about it. I mean, you're with her, too."

I smiled, "It's pretty hot. But I can't help wishing I was watching Katie right now."

"Of course," he nodded, and said seriously: "And I think it's time you made a move in that direction, my friend."

"I guess it is."

They went deep into the night, until the club was winding down and the dance floor beginning to empty.

It was probably a good time for Michelle to make a move, one way or another, since the rapidly depleting club was making it more and more difficult for us to watch what was going on without looking obvious what we were up to.

We looked casually away as she grabbed Rick's hand and pulled him toward the exit. But Michelle made sure that as they went, their route proceeded past us — and even between us, so that she brushed past Henry.

I saw her subtly stuff something into her husband's hand as she went, leaving the big redheaded goof staring at her, open-mouthed. As we watched her go, he showed me what she'd given him: her panties.

"Come on," I yelled, "you want to see where they're going, right?"

We caught up with, and managed to follow the couple as Michelle led Rick away from the club.

"You think they're going to a hotel?" Henry asked me as we did our amateur espionage act. "They've passed various taxis..."

"I don't know. I guess she's free to do that, right?"

"Right."

Michelle led her new man quite a way. She seemed to take delight in it, and no doubt as well because she knew we were there, following behind. We went down to Shaftesbury Avenue, and then past Piccadilly Circus. We proceeded along Regent Street and down the stone steps to the Mall, before venturing across and in to St James Park. Rick had incentive enough to keep up with Michelle, the way her short dress rode up her thighs — and we knew for a fact she wasn't wearing any underwear.

"Jesus, what is she doing?" Henry was out of breath as we got into the park, and my muscles were burning a little despite the fact that I'd become a regular attendee at Michelle's fitness sessions.

"It's either going to happen in the park," I said, "or she just wants to get on the District Line over there."

There was the St James Park Underground station directly across the park from us, but if she'd wanted to take Rick home on the Tube, she could have got on at Piccadilly Circus.

We watched them walk through the park, their pace dropping a little as they proceeded along the central lake. In the darkness, there were a lot of shady bushes around if she wanted to try something with him. And as it turned out, we only had to wait a few minutes for her to decide on the right spot.

Henry and I circled around, and eventually found a place in the bushes from where we might observe.

*

We watched them kissing, taking up where they had left off at the nightclub, sucking on each others' lips with the wild abandon of alcohol, adrenaline and darkness. Henry was utterly transfixed.

"Don't we get hanged for treason if we get caught doing this in a Royal Park?" I whispered. Buckingham Palace was only a few hundred yards away, after all. This wasn't a huge park.

Henry said, "Are you kidding? Compared to what the Royals get up to, this is positively tame."

We watched as Rick's hand pulled gently on the hem of Michelle's dress, reminding us that she wasn't wearing anything underneath. How far was she going to take this? He pushed her back against a tree as he kissed her, those big hands spreading over her breasts, squeezing them through her thin dress.

"God, she's so dirty," Henry said, as we saw her hands fall down Rick's chest, to run over the bulge in his pants, checking out what he was carrying. "D'you really think you could handle Katie doing this kind of thing?"

I said, "I think so."

By the orange glow of the nearest streetlamp, which wasn't particularly close, we saw her unbuckle the man's belt, and then shove his pants down along with his underwear.

And there in her hands was Rick's formidable manhood, the swollen thing jutting straight out toward her pretty face, its tip glistening with pre-cum.

Henry quietly gasped as his wife took hold of that thing and started slowly pumping, looking up at Rick's face with an impish grin. She kissed around the man's abdomen, his upper thighs, circumventing his equipment as though to tease her watching husband.

Then she was focusing on the man's cock, touching the tip to her lips, rubbing the thing all over her soft face before taking it inside her mouth, bobbing down on his length as far as she was able. Henry was clearly loving the look of bliss on his wife's face as she took another man into her mouth.

In the relative quiet of the late night, with traffic around this part of the city almost nonexistent, we could hear the wet sounds of Michelle sucking on Rick's huge cock. We could hear his groans as she took him to Heaven and back, and hers, as she found sexual fulfillment in the act of misbehaving in public, right in front of her husband.

Rick was playing with her hair as she sucked on him, pulling it back out of her face, making ponytails in his hands, but Michelle controlled her pace on him. She was loving the act of being so wicked, of taking a stranger's cock in her mouth, rubbing it over her lips, her chin, her cheeks.

She sucked on him hands-free, stroking his thighs as she sank down on his shaft, then bobbed back up. She slipped the straps of her dress over her shoulders to reveal her bare breasts, and fondled herself while she swirled her tongue around his tip or compressed his full girth within her cheeks.

When her fingers curled back around his shaft, and she gently stroked the bulbous purple head of his cock over her velvet lips, a thick stream of creamy white suddenly spurted from his cock, taking her completely by surprise as it splashed over her face and in her hair.

It made her pull back and laugh, the man's remaining come dripping down over her mouth, her chin, her bare breasts.

Wiping it out of her eye, she said something to Rick that I didn't quite catch. The man seemed suddenly flustered, stuffing his softening cock back in his pants, but then barely managing to pull them fully up and clasp his belt together before he was off, fleeing the scene.

It left Michelle kneeling there chuckling, wiping some of the come from her face, licking her fingers then rubbing the rest into her breasts like it was skin cream.

"What did you have to go and laugh at him for?" Henry said as we approached her.

She was smiling, “No, I told him my husband would love hearing how I made him explode like that. That’s what scared him off.”

“Bad, bad girl.”

I watched as Henry knelt down to stroke the hair back out of his wife’s face, and she reached out to unbuckle his pants and retrieve his own hardness as some kind of replacement for her lost catch.

“He really got it everywhere,” he said, touching the stickiness on her face, her neck, her breasts.

I watched for a little while as Michelle took the second cock into her mouth within the matter of minutes, how she indulged in the wickedness of her actions — starting out by simply breathing in the smell of him, gently stroking his stiff shaft with her face, before lashing her tongue all over his length, kissing him softly, and slowly stretching her lips around that tip to sink down.

It wasn’t a chore for her, it was a naughty treat. But with Henry, it was like going back to a familiar favorite after her little taster of something different.

Then keeping him in her mouth, Michelle reached back to slip her dress a little further up her body, to expose the sweet roundness of her behind, which she now wiggled to signify her needs.

I hesitated, suddenly very conscious of our location, and just how much danger there was that we might be discovered. There were so many CCTV cameras around central London — surely there couldn’t be any that would cover this particular spot. The bushes gave us plenty of concealment except from one slight gap. Would there be a police patrol past this place? The area around Parliament, the government buildings and Buckingham Palace was among of the most secure in the country.

It made me a trifle nervous, but the temptation of Michelle’s offer was still too much.

I knelt by her, then leaned in to kiss the soft, warm flesh of her behind, inhaling the strong fragrance of her arousal. She was seriously wet from her evening’s encounter. I couldn’t help myself, and nudged in to snatch a taste of her sweet little pussy. Even with her mouth full, I heard her moan at my tongue pressing against her slippery folds, my hot mouth pressing against her as I sucked on her soaking lips.

I think I made her lose concentration in dealing with her husband, but he didn’t seem to mind that she’d withdrawn from his cock, and that she was

using it more as some kind of handle to hold on to while I lapped at her pussy. I could empathize strongly with him, because I envied his position. I knew he would be loving how much pleasure she was getting from another, exhilarated by the expression on her sweet face.

I wished I might be the husband in such a situation, but I was still more than happy to play the part of the lover on the side for a young woman as beautiful as Michelle. Fluttering the tip of my tongue over her moistened clit, pressing into her to drill my tongue as far inside her as it could reach, savoring her flavor as she stirred her hips slightly in response.

Feeling time was a little more scarce for us in this exposed place than we might be in private, I knelt up, and unbuttoned my fly to pull out my full length.

Michelle pushed her cute butt up in the air as I touched my hardness against her searing pussy, and wiggled it again to urge me inside her. I eased forward and slipped the tip of my cock into her wetness, looking up to find Henry watching intently.

She groaned, long and low as I thrust inside her, filling her completely. I was glad she was muffled by the big cock stuffed in her mouth, and it was as effective as any pillow in keeping her volume down while I began to move inside her.

At one point I paused, removing my cock to stroke her with it. Michelle looked round at me, urgency in her eyes as she demanded: "Do it. Take me now."

She was as aware as I had been of the risks we were facing doing this in one of the smaller of the Royal Parks, less than a quarter mile away from the Prime Minister's official residence, 10 Downing Street, and the Royal Family's main home, Buckingham Palace.

From that moment on, it seemed like a race. We had to do this and get out, quick. I pushed back inside her, gripping her tightly at the hips as I started up a forceful rhythm that seemed to take control of her movement on her husband's cock as she rocked back and forth between us.

It was Henry who came first, his face screwing up, his cheeks rosy red as his whole body tensed, and his cock throbbed as he hit his peak. Even from where I was, I could see her beaming up at him, knowing what was coming. Yet rather than swallow him, as she might ordinarily, Michelle consciously took him out of her mouth just at the last minute, so that his thick white come splashed over her face, just as the stranger's had before.

Her orgasm hit just as her husband's hot seed coated her, and her shivering, trembling body under me triggered my own end.

Feeling her apparent need to be simply filthy at the end of this public encounter, as I felt my climax taking hold, I pulled out of her, and allowed my own come to streak across the pale contours of her exposed behind.

*

On the way home on an almost empty night bus, Michelle was silently enjoying the lingering of the faint aroma of the three men she'd taken in the park. The glow of complete satisfaction about her was wonderful to behold. Would that I could make Katie feel that way.

The pretty brunette was tired, shattered by her grueling night on the dance floor, her last reserves of energy taken by the adrenalized adventures in the park, so it wasn't long before she simply slumped against Henry, and drifted off to sleep.

"You've got to call her, my friend. At least call her."

I looked up at Henry, and saw that he'd read my mind. I guess it wasn't too difficult a guess for him to imagine I was thinking about her.

"I don't know..." I said. "I think I'd freeze up. I wouldn't be able to say what I wanted to say."

"You just have to relax. You don't have to come straight out and tell her you rather like the idea of sharing her, you know."

"I suppose not."

"That might come in time, but baby steps, old man."

"You're right, I know you're right."

"To begin with, you just have to reconnect with her. Become part of her life again. Friends, if nothing else."

I nodded. "Friends," I sighed. "You think it sounds strange that I don't feel like I have much in common with her any more? Our lives are so different."

Henry smiled, "You were married to each other. Are married to each other, still, unless you've signed something I wasn't aware of. You've got

plenty in common. You love her — you just have to see how she feels about you. Maybe she's still got a soft spot for you."

I looked at Michelle, and the affectionate way in which she was curled up with Henry there on the back seat of the bus, and it did motivate me to change things up a little in my own love life.

"I'll try to see her tomorrow," I pledged, though the term 'tomorrow' wasn't a great one when you worked the night shift and days were nights, and nights were really days. "I'll be okay if it's face-to-face."

Henry said: "Are you tired?"

"Not especially."

The way our night shift schedule worked, normally we were out of the office at 6am, home for "dinner" around 8am, and after a leisurely winding-down period, we were asleep by about noon. So while that bus taking us home from our night out pulled up in Chiswick at an ungodly early hour for our sleepy Michelle, for Henry and I it was still too early for our regular sleeping period.

"So why don't I drive you round there, you can catch her just before she heads out to work."

"Well, I suppose..."

"She won't mind, I'm sure. And you can say you were just dropping by on your way home from work..." Henry had his determined expression and brutally confident tone, which always made it difficult to say 'no' to him. I couldn't, even if I did believe Katie would think it very odd for me to show up out of the blue, suddenly, at seven or eight o'clock in the morning. Even with me being a night shifter.

"I had thought maybe the evening might be a better..."

"Nonsense, no time like the present, eh?"

I sighed. With the force of Henry's optimism, I guess I was about to find out.

Chapter Two | Her secret

On the plus side, Henry's need to get my love life back on track meant that when it came time to "catch" Katie at home before she had to go to work, he was willing to drive me over there, back to a house I hadn't stepped foot in since the night I caught my wife in bed with another man all those months ago.

On the minus side, when we eventually turned onto that familiar street in Fulham, there was an unmissable "sold" sign outside the little terrace house Katie and I had called home, and from the unusually loud curtains in the front windows, I could tell that my wife would no longer be in there.

After a few moments of stunned silence, Henry cleared his throat.

"Let me guess: when you married, the house was left in her name," Henry said.

"Well neither of us saw any point in rushing into changing things..."

Henry nodded, and looked over at the houses flanking the place I'd called home for five years. "Your neighbors likely to know where she moved to?"

I shrugged. "Hate to say it, but they kept to themselves. I'd doubt they ever even spoke to Katie."

"Maybe she gave the new owners a forwarding address?"

"No, Katie was more efficient than that. She would have given Royal Mail a forwarding address instead."

We sat there in silence for a heartbeat or two, with me feeling like an idiot for not just picking up the phone and calling Katie to ask her out for coffee. I was about to bite the bullet and actually agree to do it — then Henry said,

"Well, you'll see her at the wedding."

That made me really want to pick up the phone. The idea of Alicia's wedding being the first meeting with Katie, the first talk since our break-up, scared me.

"I can't wait until the wedding," I said.

Then Henry stated firmly: "Then we'll catch her after she gets out from work. You'll be rested by then, so it'll be perfect." He said it in that

forthright way again, you just couldn't disagree.

*

I'd never waited like this for her at work before, in all the time we were married, not a single visit to her at the office. I guess at the time I felt belittled by it all, because my job at the paper probably had the equivalent rank in here as hospital janitor.

It was terribly gray.

We were sitting in a small otherwise empty waiting area offering ten institutional blue plastic chairs that were about as comfortable as the tools of the Spanish Inquisition. At least we had a good view up and down the long corridor which connected the two wards on which I was certain Katie must lurk during working hours.

God, I hated the smell of hospitals.

"And you're sure she'll come this way?" Henry seemed to be more on edge than I was.

"Of course. She has to come from over there, down here to the elevator to get to the parking lot in the basement."

"Right. Well, her car's down there, she couldn't have gotten by us."

"She doesn't leave before her shift is over."

The formidable woman on the small ward reception desk across from us kept glaring at me. It was quite unnerving. Was I a known face around here? Had they put wanted posters up or something when Katie had decided to leave me?

Or was there some law in hospitals that you had to keep quiet? Like libraries. I wasn't up to speed on the protocols.

"She doesn't do double-shifts?" Henry asked.

"I don't think she'd even be allowed to if she wanted to."

It was five-thirty in the evening, and I was a little surprised that Henry had accompanied me, since it was pretty early for us — on our schedule, we normally woke up at 7pm, 8pm or thereabouts. All the way here, he'd been insistent that I needed someone to talk to, either before or after meeting with Katie. I wasn't persuaded that I actively needed him there, though I'd

never turn down his company if I was on my own — and the ride in his car was an added perk.

“What are you going to say to her?” He’d kept asking me on the way over.

“I don’t know,” I’d kept replying.

“You don’t want her to think you’re an idiot.”

“I think... just saying hello... I don’t know. That maybe I forgive her, I understand her. I realize, now, that she needed more. That I should have given her more.”

“She does bear some of the responsibility, old man. Don’t take it all yourself.”

“Yeah, well. I might have stopped it on my own if I’d had my head on straight.”

Sitting there, feeling a little like a fraud for simply breathing the hospital air without being a patient, I couldn’t remember when I’d last felt this intensely nervous. It was like waiting for an exam to start.

The longer I waited, the more I started feeling certain there was little chance of Katie wanting to take me back. She had left me, after all, not the other way around. She had gone and gotten on with her life, while I was still pushing TV schedules around and sleeping with another man’s wife.

Still, I had to do something, I had to at least try and make a play.

“Hey, is that... there’s a blonde woman down there...” Henry was craning his neck forward to peer down the corridor, and as I looked in the direction he was, a powerful jolt shot through my chest.

Katie.

It was undoubtedly her.

God, she looked good. She was wearing a smart black skirt down to her knees and matching sleeveless black top — very smart, elegant. Her legs were clad in dark hose, while her black shoes were killer high-heeled. Her long golden hair was down, and her silver bracelet added a hint of style that made it so certain in my mind that she was going out with a guy. Her entire ensemble was somehow sensible and sophisticated as well as being sexy, cut to flatter her lean curves.

This was not what she wore to and from work on a normal night.

I burned inside to think of her dressing so well for another man — and yet she glanced over her shoulder before stepping into the elevator at the

other end of the long hallway from us, and the look of serene satisfaction on her face made me feel good.

“I hate to break it to you, my friend, but she’s not coming this way,” Henry said.

I was a little breathless, but now it turned from excitement at seeing her to some kind of panic. “Shit,” I said. “Where’s she going? Her car’s down this way.”

“She’s looking good,” Henry said as we rose to our feet, rather helplessly pursuing her even as she disappeared from view so very far away from us. “Maybe she’s meeting someone elsewhere in the building.”

A last glare from the reception desk nurse prevented us from running, or even speed-walking. I felt my hopes being dashed with every step.

I don’t know — it wasn’t as though it was do-or-die. I could have tried again the next evening, or the next. I guess that the thought she was about to go out on another date with someone made my subconscious caveman brain want to get to her before I lost her all over again.

We got to the elevator and saw that it was slowly descending through the building.

“Why’s she going this way?” I said, aghast at my plans being spoiled.

“Come on,” Henry hissed, and dragged me to the stairs.

We tracked the elevator down through the building, ducking our heads in at each floor to check it was still descending, then dashing back into the stairwell to leap down the stairs like lemmings. Thank God it was a standard public-sector elevator, slow as a tortoise. But it still left us both standing in the subterranean parking lot, bent over and gasping for oxygen.

“Jesus,” I cursed, probably more from the pain of so much lactic acid burning my less-than-fully-fit muscles than the fact that I’d have to come back another day if I wanted to see Katie.

“Come on!”

I looked round to see Henry legging it toward his car. “What the — ?”

I could see Katie nearing her own vehicle. She wasn’t in a particular rush, it seemed. But Henry was acting like a madman, sprinting to his car, throwing himself inside, pulling away with a screech of the tires.

“Hey, cool it, Bond,” I said as I climbed into the passenger seat. “If we’re following her, we need to be unobtrusive, right?”

“What’s she doing driving a Golf anyway?” he asked, slowing to give more of a safe distance between our two cars. “Thought a surgeon would

drive a Mercedes or something.”

It wasn't much of a car chase, not at that time of day. We could see Katie's car up ahead, maybe three or four vehicles in front of us, as jammed as we were, edging forward foot by foot.

I could almost have slipped out of the car, and walked up to hers to try to talk to her.

“So,” I said to Henry, both of us still trying to get our breaths back, “she's probably meeting someone for a date, looking like that. So what's she going to think about me pulling up, demanding to talk to her?”

Henry nodded, acknowledging the shortfalls of a plan concocted on the hoof. “We'll just see where she goes,” he said. “Maybe engineer a chance encounter.”

“A chance encounter?”

“We're on a night out, right? As far as she knows. We just happened to run into her...”

“I suppose.”

But we were driving south of the river, down towards Vauxhall and Battersea, and then onto Clapham, and this was not natural territory for Henry and I to be on a night out.

“You think she lives down this way? Clapham?”

“I have no idea,” I said.

“Might find out where she lives.”

“And approach her there? I'm not sure that would be much less stalkery than a chance encounter on a night out south of the river.”

“Maybe her new fella lives down this way.”

“Her new fella?” Got, he could stir up the butterflies in my stomach so easily — but then, Henry knew exactly how I felt.

He grinned, “Probably not. You crack me up, Seany old boy. You so want her back. I hope you're not going to get hurt again...”

I was about to insist he was wrong when we saw Katie's Golf pull off down a side street not far from Clapham Common, and Henry had to be quick to alert our driver, although our guy then protested that he had everything under control.

This was residential territory. It was a little confusing, and somehow a little frightening to me. Was she just going straight to someone's house looking like this? An intimate dinner at his house? Or was this where she

lived, down one of these rows of small but cute and prohibitively expensive red-bricked terraced houses?

After a few turns, though, her taxi pulled up outside a larger red-brick building that came complete with a small copper-roofed spire that suggested it was a church.

“Keep going,” I told Henry. “Just pull in up there, so we’re not seen.”

We managed to find a space and pull in with just enough time to spot Katie ducking into the building through a wrought iron gate. When we got there, there seemed to be a more modern extension to the church that declared itself to be St Luke’s Community Centre.

“Jesus,” Henry said appropriately. “She got religion?”

“It’s Church of England,” I said, pointing to the proof on the sign. “But she was brought up a Catholic.”

Henry shrugged, “Church of England’ll have anyone. Could’ve been brought up as a Satanist and they’d probably take you.”

“Assuming you hadn’t performed any human sacrifices or anything,” I said, feeling strangely happy that she might not be on a date that evening.

“Even so.” Henry quietly stepped past the gates, and I hissed at him to stop — he was really taking this too far. “Don’t you want to know what she’s up to?”

I felt the hairs rise on the back of my neck. We were really pushing it now. No possible excuse could explain our presence in this place, no matter how hard we tried to claim a sudden and devote inclination to rediscover the Christian faith.

But I had to follow him down the paved path to the wooden doors of the Community Centre if only to pull him back so we might start looking for a taxi to get us to work in time.

And then he was inside.

“Jesus,” I said, the blasphemy really coming easily on this consecrated ground.

Inside, it looked like a primary school with lots of artwork on the walls that had been produced by children, except that everything was subtly too touched by religion to be a secular school. This wasn’t a church, though. Various rooms seemed available for organized activities, with only a couple seemingly occupied and their doors closed.

One had a piece of paper sellotaped up signaling that a meeting of Cancer Survivors was going on.

The other room, a little further into the Centre, had a small piece of paper with an almost unreadably scrawled writing declaring it to be SAA UK.

“She’s in here,” Henry was peering at his smartphone, and when I was done peering at the note taped to this door, I could see that he was looking up “SAA UK” on Google.

The door had a central glass panel, and through it I could just about see the back of Katie’s head. The room was large, with row upon row of chairs seated forward toward a bald man who stood behind a small lectern to address the assembled dozen or so people.

“So,” Henry whispered, “It’s either South Asian Arts UK, Society for All Artists, the Sub-Aqua Association...”

“She really doesn’t like going underwater,” I said.

“Or Sex Addicts Anonymous.”

My heart seemed to miss a beat or two.

“What?” I grabbed his phone. Google wasn’t exactly the font of all human knowledge, but there it was, only the second item in the search list on Henry’s phone. ‘SAA is a group of men and women who share our experience, strength and hope with each other for the purpose of finding freedom from addictive sexual behavior...’

“Jesus,” I said. “But what if it isn’t? What if it’s...”

I clicked onto the next page in the Google search.

“...Scottish Archery Association?” Henry read for me.

“...Society for Abandoned Animals,” I suggested. “She likes animals. She had a rabbit when she was a kid.”

“A rabbit,” Henry said, dead-pan. “She’s probably got a rabbit right now, but it sure as hell needs batteries.”

Henry eased the handle on the door down, and to my absolute horror, ducked his head into the room to listen to what was being said.

That was too much for me. I was out of there, walking with long strides and softly-placed feet straight for the door, and then for the street. Shit, shit, shit. She was going to see Henry. And then what? She might not recognize him — I don’t think she’d even met him. It felt too risky even so.

And I wouldn’t get away with it if she saw me there. I started walking down the street toward the last main road we’d turned off in the hope of getting a taxi.

It was probably only a few minutes later that Henry came huffing and puffing down the street behind me.

“It is,” he said. “No doubt. Recovering sex addicts.”

“Jesus,” I said again. My whole body felt lighter than air, my stomach swimming with butterflies again.

Katie was a recovering sex addict?

*

By the time we got to work, I still didn’t know what to think about this new information. I shouldn’t have known it, it was none of my business. And yet now I did know it, it brought only added layers of confusion.

As was often the way when he wanted to discuss a particularly sensitive subject, Henry waited until past midnight to get into everything. The office was fairly empty when we arrived for our shift, of course, but in the small hours the people who were simply staying ridiculously late to hit deadlines tended to finally leave, so it was just us actual night workers remaining.

“So,” he said, and I could tell from the look in his eyes what he was about to bring up. “How are you feeling, Old Man?”

“Okay,” I nodded, though having managed to quell most of my thoughts and feelings for a couple of hours, now things began to stir again in my stomach.

“You want to talk about it?” I could tell Henry wanted to talk about it. He was itching to talk about it. Raring to go.

I glanced about us, to check that we were suitably out of earshot of anyone else. Sue Collins was thankfully engaged elsewhere on the floor, probably using the force to crush the windpipes of junior freelancers caught slacking on the job.

“I guess my big question,” I said cautiously, “is whether she cheated on me, you know, while we were together.”

“Of course,” Henry nodded. “But you don’t think she did, did you?”

I shrugged, “It wasn’t really like her to cheat. I mean, there was probably ample opportunity, the way our schedules were. But even so — “

“You trust her.”

I sighed, was I being a complete idiot here? I said: “I don’t know. When all is said and done, I didn’t fulfill her needs. Not even slightly. But I think

it makes me feel better to think that she recognized she needed a lot more sex, and ended things with me before pursuing it.”

“Course it does. But are you going to take that as closure?” Henry looked at me, gravely serious. “Because if you have any hint of hope that you’ll ever get back together with her, you have to be prepared that the truth may not be quite the cozy little scenario you’d want.”

A deep breath. What if Katie had cheated on me? I’d never found any evidence of such a thing, not while we were married, and not even after she’d split with me. But what if she had? Now she was attending a therapy group, she had recognized her problem. What if I had the chance to get back with her?

After everything I’d been through with Michelle and Henry, and the new way in which I saw Katie, a big part of me didn’t want her to think of her high libido as a problem. In my new form, I’d be her husband and celebrate it with her, embracing her need to see other men so long as she saw me as well.

But what about the possibility of cheating?

There was that dark little part inside me, that perhaps had been the first part of me to accept the fantasy of wife-sharing, that saw Katie as just a little bit more sexy if she’d had the occasional little illicit encounter during our marriage. The rest of me pulsed with a low throbbing pain at the thought that she might have lied to me, hid from me, perhaps even belittling me in her mind or her lovers’ for my complete inability to satisfy her.

“I think,” I said, “maybe it’s better if I don’t know. Or even if I find out, I ignore it. Start with a clean slate.”

Henry nodded, “Probably the healthy thing to do. Tabula rasa. Move on.”

Having made the decision to move forward, I realized I’d already forgiven Katie for leaving me. Whether she’d done it in some kind of attempt to protect me from the pain her addiction would cause me, or for a less noble reason, I was ready to look past it and do whatever it took to get her back in my life.

I felt better about Katie, I felt better about my own desire to be with her again.

I said, “I’ll see her at Alicia’s wedding. I’ll just try to get a moment with her there.”

Only, those butterflies in my stomach were fluttering ten times worse now, because I really, deeply wanted my wife again — but getting her back

was, by the very nature of our break-up, not up to me.

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Chapter Three | Wedding nerves

After that, I ran out of time before Alicia's wedding to engineer some kind of meeting with Katie. On the four-hour train journey up to rural Northumberland, the northern-most county in England, I had plenty of time to regret my decision.

I shouldn't have hesitated. It wasn't any of my business whether she was part of some addiction support group. I should have moved to meet up with her another day, or just gone ahead and called her.

But I didn't, I sat on my hands trying to figure out what this addiction of hers — assuming that was what she was attending for — might mean for our break-up and my chances of winning her back.

So I sat on that train on the trek up the East Coast Line dreading what would happen when I did see her. If she considered herself a sex addict, did that mean she regretted turning her back on our marriage? Or did it confirm her need for more than our marriage?

I was still hopeful that if we could finally talk — about what went wrong, about whether there was any chance of correcting whatever it was that finally made her push me out of the nest — I might be able to show her how I'd changed, that I recognized she needed more physical attention than I'd provided. That I was open to her exploring her sexuality outside our marriage, if she needed or wanted to.

Hopeful did not translate into confident, though. I'd played this whole thing so badly. And now the first time I was going to see her face to face was going to be in a church for the rehearsal, surrounded by her family and friends. Hardly the most conducive time for a heart-to-heart.

After changing at Newcastle for a branch line into the countryside, the train finally pulled into the village where I would find the wedding venue. A short taxi ride took me to the great house that had once been the stately pile of the local Lord of the Manor.

I had to hand it to Alicia, the place was something special, in rolling countryside that was as wild and unspoiled as it got, albeit a little windswept, perhaps. The Hall was a Victorian mansion house at which any

Downton Abbey aficionado would probably kill to set their big day. It made me think of some vague Agatha Christie murder mystery, or perhaps a popular board game — Professor Plum, in the study with the revolver.

At the reception desk I gave my name and received a warm smile.

“Oh yes, Mr Ruskin, your wife has already arrived. You’re staying in Pine Tree Cottage.”

My heart received a slight jolt at that. “My wife? Uh... right.”

“It’s a five minute walk through the estate, can’t miss it if you follow the signs...”

I didn’t really listen to the directions, just accepted the pamphlet she offered bearing a simplified little map, and felt my insides quietly fizzing. They’d put me in the same room as Katie?

After a moment or two and I came back to reality, I assumed some kind of glitch in the planning had happened, but I was already on my way to the cottage before I came to that conclusion. It would all get ironed out, I was sure. If Katie was here already, she might have already figured out what was going on.

The cottage was a pleasant little old stone building that might have once housed servants or groundskeepers or some other serf connected with the estate.

The front door opened, and there right in front of me was Katie, my Katie.

Jesus, she looked phenomenal.

“Hello, Sean.”

Her blonde hair was brushed straight, flowing down her back, her face perfectly made-up to highlight her pretty features, those green eyes and her full lips, without going over the top. She was wearing a lacy lilac top and pale gray woolen skirt that struck the right kind of balance between smart and casual for the rehearsal dinner, although the lace of her top was just about suggestive enough to hint at a matching lilac bra underneath, which added that little frisson of risqué glamour to draw the male gaze — and in the process, unnerve me more than a little.

She was looking at me with pity filling her big blue eyes. I’d never been comfortable with pity. How do you respond to that?

“Katie. Hi. How have you been?” I stuttered after an overly long pause, trying not to look shocked by her appearance.

She had made much more effort in her appearance than I felt she ever did with me. God, she looked so elegant, so sharp, so beautiful.

“Oh, so-so,” she said, and I could see she was reining in some kind of emotion, whatever it might be. “Laura said she saw you the other week.”

Laura. Laura Ketteridge, of course. Had to expect she’d fire off her gossip to all and sundry.

“Laura. That’s right — I bumped into her in a bar.”

Katie nodded. “She said you were... with someone?”

Of course she had.

In an attempt to shake the pity from her eyes, I said with put-upon confidence, “That’s right... Michelle. I guess it’s been... I don’t know, a couple of months or so.”

“Oh, right.” Katie sounded as though she hadn’t believed Laura Kettering when she’d shared the gossip. I pulled my phone out of my pocket, flipping on the screen and the photo app to offer a quick glimpse of Michelle and I. Thankfully I had a shot without Henry looking very obviously her husband.

Katie said, “She’s very pretty. I’m glad you’re... doing well.”

I suddenly sensed the huge mistake I’d just walked into. Stupid, stupid idiot. I wanted to get Katie back, not sell her the idea I was already engaged in some semblance of domestic bliss without her.

As some kind of mad attempt to rectify things, I blurted out, “And you’ve been seeing some more of Grant, I gather.”

It didn’t come out the way I wanted it to. In fact, with hindsight, I wasn’t even sure what point I’d wanted to make by saying such a thing. Most probably, I was attempting to remind her that she had been seeing other men, and so she had no right to disapprove of me seeing other women.

Still, the little shrug she gave me at once made me regret it, and how accusatory it had sounded.

“Alicia put you in my room,” she said now, “I guess she’s still trying to force things back to the way they were, huh? Grant’s got the room next door, though, so you can take that one.”

“Right,” I nodded, feeling a kick in the chest at her mention of Grant, and the insinuation that he did not need his own room because he could sleep with Katie.

“Don’t take too long — the rehearsal starts pretty soon in the chapel.”

With that, she was out the door, leaving me feeling a crushing sense of defeat and the dream of reconciling seemed to have moved further out of

my reach.

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I changed into a fairly smart, but still casual, shirt and pants combination as quickly as I could, and headed on over to the chapel, assisted by the little map the receptionist had given me. I hadn't missed much, thankfully. I was able to slip into one of the pews at the back as the happy couple went through the details of the ceremony with the wedding planner up at the altar.

A few people I recognized saw me come in, gave me nods or smiles. I didn't know many of Alicia's friends, and her parents were too deep in conversation with the priest to notice my arrival. Grant was nowhere to be seen.

It was half an hour before the wedding planner came to direct the ushers to where we were supposed to be. I was destined to be at the back, asking people whether they were with the bride or the groom, directing them to the seats on this or that side of the aisle. I felt I hardly needed to be part of the rehearsal to have this explained to me.

Katie stayed up in front with her sister and the core wedding party. Only a couple of times did I notice her sneaking little glances my way. Each time, her eyes sent shockwaves through my body. Was she relieved she'd left our marriage? I just couldn't read her.

It was a full hour before we were told we could head into the dining room in the main house for the rehearsal dinner, though most of that was spent waiting around, not really doing much.

As people milled out of the chapel, I shared a slightly awkward greeting with Katie's parents, who from the face of it appeared to be fully informed about the end of our marriage. Then I heard Alicia behind me.

"Sean!"

We hugged. She said, "I'm so glad you made it."

"It's a really beautiful place," I said, offering her a magnanimous smile. She did seem genuinely happy that I was here. It was the only compensation I had for making the trip.

“Your room is okay?”

I nodded, though I couldn't work out whether she realized that Katie had quietly transferred me into Grant's room.

“It's great. The whole place is really something.”

I did my duty, avoided any possibility of sullying her big day, and kept the conversation on her. It was the safest way. We made our way through to the main house chatting about the happy couple's planned honeymoon in the Maldives, and then she quietly excused herself to hurry over to the top table.

I was sat with Katie, of course, just in front of the top table, where I had to spend the meal politely chatting with those around me, though it seemed more difficult to talk to Katie than anyone. She was busy smiling and laughing with her old family friends, and she just seemed a little more unrestrained than I ever remembered her. Flirtatious, I suppose. Looking for social opportunities.

It burned inside as I recognized that she was, basically, open to new relationships, and this was what was different about her whole demeanor. It was strangely attractive in her, but for me this whole experience was tinged with sadness.

As the dinner got going, it seemed something of a relief to me that Grant, the man I knew for certain she'd been sleeping with, was not there. It made me feel that at least if Katie planned on trying to continue her dating life here at the wedding, she did not have plans to be with Grant. Perhaps she'd simply given me his room because he wasn't able to make it to the wedding.

As we adjourned to the bar afterwards, the older members of the rehearsal dinner slipped away to bed leaving the younger crowd, and I got the feeling that most of them knew about our break-up. At least, the way Katie remained distant from me seemed entirely natural to others, and the way Katie seemed to flaunt herself with the other guys in the room did nothing to attract critical looks.

I kept an eye on Katie as I chatted with one of the groom's cousins, Austin. He seemed a touch on the geeky side, talking about nothing much in particular. I got the impression he was comfortable latching onto another outsider, as an excuse not to have to strike up conversation with other strangers. It helped that he got the slightly wrong idea about what I did at the newspaper, and we could talk about celebrity gossip and movie news.

I guess I just wanted to stay there at the bar long enough that people wouldn't think me too much of a loser. When I noticed others starting to slip away for the night, I would have done the same — but Katie seemed to be more and more relaxed with the two guys standing next to her by the bar, and it made me want to stay. Initially I wasn't sure why. I did feel the jealousy squeezing my stomach as I saw her flashing her eyes and her smile at them, obviously trying to impress them. Perhaps unconsciously I wanted to punish myself for taking her for granted while we were together. It was exciting, though, the sense of possibility she exuded — that maybe one or other of these guys might take the bait, and go for her.

Later, my new friend Austin was talking about comic book movies, which I can witter on about on autopilot thanks to my frequent late-night discussions with Henry while we were supposed to be working. My eye was on Katie, who appeared to have chosen between the two men, one hand fairly unsubtly on the taller one's shoulder, her body lining up with his as though they were a new couple uncertain of each other but silently acknowledging their acceptance of one another.

It burned inside me, but I couldn't stop watching her. There was a strange thrill for me, even through the pain. Imagining that she was still mine, and that I was allowing her to flirt with other guys, even made me aroused, though I tried not to let it show. Fortunately no one was paying much attention to the way I kept shifting in my seat.

I'd felt this way before, though in a milder form. When I'd been with Michelle, and then she went to be with Henry, there was that sense of loss, of jealousy, and yet excitement as I knew she was about to receive the attentions of another man. Yet even simply watching Katie flirting in a bar, in public, the feelings it invoked in me were ten times stronger than watching Michelle ever had.

I wanted her to take this tall, blond guy back to her room. I wanted her seduction to succeed, though it pained me intensely. But most of all, I wanted her to do so knowing that it would be with my consent, and that I would be waiting for her afterwards.

"Well, I don't know about you, but I am bushed," Austin was saying, and I was attempting to persuade him to stay longer by telepathy. Sadly, it turns out I wasn't a member of the X-Men, I had no mutant powers.

"Probably time to turn, in, right?" I said, trying to think of something to get a last-minute conversation going again, to delay his departure. I really

didn't want to have to find another drinking buddy among people I'd managed to avoid since dinner — and if I was going to stay here longer, to observe Katie's progress, I would have to.

"I'm not much of a late-night kind of guy," Austin said.

"It's over-rated," I agreed, though all night I hadn't once mentioned that my work at the paper was a night shift thing.

In the end, he left, and I decided to throw in the towel for the night after heading to the bar to get a glass of iced water for the road. It kept me there long enough to see Katie's laughing and joking around with the tall blond guy turn into an impromptu hug, as though he was commiserating with her for something I couldn't decipher.

The hug lingered, and the two of them were suddenly looking at each other, serious-faced, both a little flustered, awkward like teenagers who'd wanted something to happen between them but were surprised when suddenly it did. God, I got the strongest sense that they wanted to make out, but felt the need to get away from the other eyes at the bar.

I felt this buzzing all over as I grabbed my iced water, and attempted to follow them as Katie led her new friend out of the bar. It was difficult, though, to keep tabs on them as they disappeared into the corridors of the great house, pretending that one or other of them felt like a late-night tour. I could follow them too close and be discovered, or hang back and lose them in the rabbit warren of a mansion.

In the end, I could only withdraw from the field of play, imagining that they'd found a shady corner somewhere in which to fool around. I returned to my room at the cottage, to read and pass the time awake, since my night shift schedule made it impossible for me to sleep. As it happens, sleep was the furthest thing from my mind at the moment.

*

Katie never returned to her room that night. My imagination ran riot, and the best way I found to cope with the rush of feelings that kept swamping me every time my mind returned to her, and what she might be up to, was to imagine we were in some kind of arrangement like Henry and Michelle.

That night I did some research about the sexual addiction group, through the shaky Internet connection available to me at that cottage. The whole thing just did not seem like Katie. Its Christian foundations went against her general leaning toward atheism. And if she was going through the 12 steps, wouldn't she have to make amends to all the people she felt her addiction had harmed?

I came to the conclusion that her visit to the sexual addiction group might have been related to her medical career, though I couldn't quite see how a heart surgeon might be interested in such a gathering.

At breakfast in the same dining room in which the rehearsal dinner was held, and where the reception would be later, Katie came in with her sister and the other bridesmaids as though nothing untoward had happened the night before. Yet I was certain she'd never made it back to her room.

They were all in their own little world, and I don't think Katie even noticed I was there. I slipped away to hang out in my room, and later went for a long walk around the picturesque village, before returning to shower and ready myself for the wedding. Getting dressed was the simple part — preparing to spend the next 5 hours with my separated wife within reach, but acting as if I were a stranger — that was another matter altogether.

*

As noon passed by, and the great house began to fill with Alicia's family and friends, Katie was suddenly there at my side, looking stunning in a pale peach satin dress that clung to her body to emphasize her femininity while still remaining very elegant.

"There you are," she said, "I wondered where you'd got to."

"Here all the time," I replied as she took my arm as though we were a married couple. "Listen... I wondered if we could talk..."

"Don't complicate matters, just nod and smile," she muttered under her breath as she led me around the great hall, nodding and smiling at all those distant relatives who were at our wedding five years before.

"Are you ever going to tell them?" I asked her, frustrated that we couldn't just go somewhere quiet for a moment or two, so I could tell her

how I felt.

“When I get round to it.” She seemed annoyed at me, and I couldn’t work out why. What had I said?

Her perfume was a trifle overpowering since she was so close to me — and Katie had never gone for overdoing the perfume. Sweet, exotic, designed to entice the single man. From where I was standing, too, I could see more of her cleavage than perhaps I should have. The whole effect was a little dazzling to me. I kept quiet and did as she told me.

We parted as I was supposed to proceed through to the chapel to make sure people knew which side of the chapel to sit, if they couldn’t work it out. The wedding itself kicked off without a hitch — it was, genuinely, a stylish affair.

Afterwards, I wondered if Katie would need to be seen in my company during the reception. But it appeared that she’d done enough of a show before the ceremony to keep concerned relatives from asking questions about our marriage.

The reception went well. A glass or two of Champagne helped me to relax and stop thinking quite so much about which men Katie might have her eye on tonight. It took until after the meal, when we were mixing out in the hall and the rest of the house, and I found myself once again keeping Cousin Austin company, that I caught sight of Grant.

He was here. Damn it. What was he doing here?

Seeing him there, casually chatting with some of the bridesmaids, made me feel a little stifled, hot around the collar. If he was here, where was he planning on sleeping that night, since I had his room? I felt the hairs rise on the back of my neck as I saw Katie glide up to greet him with a peck on the cheek, and join his little bridesmaid groupies.

I was aware that my conversation with my new friend had drifted into autopilot again as I watched my wife being so comfortable around my former friend, that her flirting was more than just a bit of fun. I was being awfully rude to poor Austin, but I couldn’t help it.

Then the guy shook me out of my drifting, said: “Someone told me she’s your wife, is that right? The blonde.”

Now both of us were surreptitiously watching Katie.

“Uh-huh,” I confirmed, not really knowing what to say.

He nodded. “She’s quite... an extrovert, isn’t she?”

“I suppose so.”

“You must have a great marriage — I mean, that she can just go off and be so... well, flirty with other guys.”

I felt a little shocked to be having this conversation with a stranger, to be honest. But Austin seemed to invite honesty.

“Exact opposite, unfortunately,” I told him. “She left me a few months ago.”

“Hmm, awkward.” He nodded again, sagely. “She’s pretty. It must hurt to see her like this.”

“I don’t know...” I sighed. “Part of me is happy for her. Truly. If she really wasn’t happy with me, maybe she’ll be happy with someone else.”

Austin caught a waiter carrying a tray of Champagne flutes around the hall, and put a fresh glass in my hand. “Maybe she’ll meet a complete bastard,” he said, tapping me on the shoulder. “Then when he treats her badly, she’ll come running back to you.”

I laughed, “Only in the movies, Austin.”

*

Hanging around with Austin as the sun went down and the drinks kept on flowing, I think it helped to be open with him about my marriage. He found me a trustworthy soul to whom he could share his own resentments about his family and its lack of appreciation for his position in it, and I seemed to be free to float around the reception subtly following Katie’s progress.

“You still love her, then,” he asked at one point, as it was getting late and the dancing was taking centre stage.

“Uh-huh.”

“You like watching her, even though she’s maybe interested in someone else.”

“I suppose so.”

Katie was on the edge of the dance floor, gin and tonic in hand, talking to another small clutch of guys in her newly flirtatious manner. Alcohol helping her to flaunt herself before them, and anyone she talked to, like she never did before while I’d known her.

“Are you one of those masochists?” Austin nearly made me spit out my Champagne. “I’ve read about people like you,” he added.

“That right?”

“You can’t let go. You love her so much, even having the pain of her rejection in your life is better than having nothing of her at all.”

“I’m not sure that sounds so great to me,” I insisted, though there might have been elements of truth in what he said.

He looked at me, and seemed genuinely impressed, for some reason.

“You’re lucky,” he said, making me look at him with one eyebrow raised. “She’s very beautiful. And you got to be with her.”

“I suppose I did.”

“Maybe you just can’t possess a woman like that. You just have to be grateful for the time you get, then let her go.”

*

Austin retired early, again — it was so dark, and the music so loud for the dancing, that he felt safe enough slipping away unnoticed. I wished him good night, genuinely feeling that his company that day had probably saved my sanity.

And what he’d said about possessing a woman like Katie... well, I felt another piece of my lingering resentment towards her melt away.

Once Austin had gone, I noticed that the atmosphere of this wedding had subtly changed, too. The remaining revellers were a younger crowd, with most of the older family and friends departing for their beds. It made me feel a flicker of trepidation, that this was the kind of opportunity for someone to make a move on Katie, and not have to worry too much about family witnesses.

I could linger around the dance floor, and surreptitiously take in the sight of Katie dancing close with another man, appreciating how she gazed into his eyes, smiled flirtatiously, held him close. I could sample the jealousy rippling under my skin like a connoisseur might sample a fine whisky, and I was able to dispel the negative aspects of it. She was so stunning. Austin

had been completely right, I had been fortunate to spend the time I had with her. Now, another man would get the thrill of being with her. Other men.

I thought Katie might spend some more time with the blond guy she'd been with the previous night, but although I saw them chatting briefly on that wedding night, it almost seemed as though they were done with each other. Had they slept together, and now it was on to other things for them both? Or was I reading too much into it, and nothing had happened between them the previous evening?

I also wondered if, now that Grant was here at the wedding, her attention would turn to him that night. Yet it didn't — they seemed to operate independently of each other, with Grant apparently pursuing some of the other bridesmaids, while Katie opened up her options on the dance floor.

There were a few of them she danced with, and they seemed to be taking the attitude that it was some kind of contest to win her hand. She clearly liked the attention. She was teasing them as much as she was teasing me, making some think they were getting further with her than they were, making some of the other suitors watching from the wings think they were losing the contest when they weren't.

I thought the two taller ones were the most likely to win her that night. One seemed a little younger, blond, confident in himself but with a slight sense of cockiness. The other was dark-haired, equally confident but a little more serious. She would dance with one for a number, then the other, then perhaps another of those waiting to get in on the action, though in reality she was only really playing these two off each other.

For me, it was a definite turn-on to see how desirable she was, and how her confidence radiated out from knowing that. But it was just so real watching their hands running all over her body. I'd seen Katie in bed with Grant, but this was something different. Sensual, erotic, beautiful — and yet at the same time frightening, touched with a slight hint of sorrow on my part.

As the night proceeded, I increasingly thought the dark-haired guy was the victor — she was using the blond only to tease him by now. When she was with the dark-haired man, things were serious, the two of them sharing palpable chemistry as they slowly moved together, and Katie dropped the playfulness that she had with the blond.

It felt hard to breathe in there, though the room's temperature had not changed. Watching them, thinking this could be the man she would take to

bed that night. Watching him melding to her body, touching his nose into her neck to breathe in her fragrance. These men were predators, and I was definitely feeling protective toward her, though I didn't want to interfere. Watching their eyes flicking over her cleavage, checking out her body in that tight peach satin dress, touching her when and as often as they felt they could get away with — which, as the night wore on, became more and more. They obviously had one thing on their minds — and Katie was loving it.

Again, the sensations I was feeling were stronger than I'd ever felt with Michelle. Concentrated. Powerful. I found myself wondering how I would feel if Katie and I were still together, in love, and I was allowing her out to dance or flirt with another man. Would it be like this? Perhaps it would be, but without the melancholy from knowing I'd never have her again.

A couple of times that evening, I think I caught Katie glancing in my direction. I'd done well to avoid her gaze each time, and in being a careful, subtle observer there were plenty of times she might have been looking my way and I had missed it. She certainly knew I was there, that I could probably see her. So was she playing up her flirtations for my benefit? Was she trying to taunt me, or even punish me for not being a worthy husband? Or was she simply hoping I'd leave, so she could continue her partying without distraction?

And then she was with her dark-haired suitor for around 20 minutes straight, and it was more touchy-feely than I'd seen so far, more intense. They were locked on each other's eyes, connected on a different level to anything seen earlier that night. Her hands ran up and down his back while they danced, while his clamped to her behind.

I watched her glance around the dance floor to see if they were noticed, and deciding that everyone around them was too drunk to care by now, she led her contest victor from the dance floor. Jesus, this just didn't seem like my Katie. So forthright, demanding. I had to stop to remember that during that party all those years ago, when she had dragged me home with her, she had very much been in charge, too. This was single Katie, and she was as unfamiliar to me as she was alluring.

She pulled her dark-haired lothario into the shadows at the back of the place, and suddenly he was leaning down, and they were kissing. I guess I should have been prepared for it, though I never thought she'd be so public,

so blatant. It was a long, deep, wet kiss, with both sets of hands pulling each other tight.

I was gasping for breath just watching them.

Then she led him away, and I felt suddenly so light-headed, I couldn't go after them.

I had to get back to my room, regroup, cope with my feelings away from other people. I was sweating, and yet cold, and I had the biggest hard-on ever at the knowledge at what Katie was about to do.

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Chapter Four | Wedding night

Back in my room, I felt better after a long, cold shower and some relaxation in bed in front of a movie — the Crow, which was suitably dark and troubled for my temperament, and something I'd seen before a few times, so I wouldn't need to concentrate on it too much.

It was a nice large room, with a nice large bed, but I couldn't help but start thinking that wherever Katie's dark-haired friend had taken her, there was probably a similarly large bed.

I tried to relax, tried to fall asleep, but my head was spinning after spending the night watching Katie on the dance floor. Did I regret not being able to see her take things further with that guy? I wasn't sure how I'd react. On the surface, the idea was attractive — but was I swayed by my safe experiences with Henry and Michelle? There was no safety net here, Katie was no longer mine. I could not stop her doing whatever she wanted with her new man if I found it too difficult to cope. I didn't get to reclaim her afterwards, to reassure myself she still loved me. She didn't still love me, as far as I knew.

Thinking about it all, I started to feel fortunate that Katie was sleeping elsewhere, and that I wouldn't have to deal with her being with someone else in the very next room.

I even managed to get a little sleep, despite my usual problems getting any shut-eye at night.

Then later, I found myself being roused from my light slumber by a rattling at the cottage front door — and the sound of voices. God, how late was it? Gone four, I guessed.

It was definitely Katie — I could hear her laughter. But she wasn't alone.

I heard them out in the living room, the sounds of their conversation filtering through without the details of what they were saying, but the clink of glasses and the unmistakable scent of marijuana more than hinting that the party was continuing in Katie's world.

I slipped out of bed, at first venturing to the door of my room. This door had a peephole that allowed me a wide-angled view of outside the room. It

wasn't a great view, there was a small hallway outside the two bedrooms, leading past the bathroom to the main living room area and the kitchen. I could only really see the wall on the far side of the hallway.

I waited, listening, trying to ascertain what might be going on out there, even from just the tone of the voices. My heart thumping. Had Katie brought her dark-haired friend back here, after all? What had they been up to all this time, if they were only just coming to find a bed now?

I felt so strange, hovering there at my door. Despite my earlier reticence, I felt suddenly hopeful that Katie was about to take her friend to bed — that I might at least hear them. It perhaps wasn't as simple as some kind of bizarre perversion. I think guilt had something to do with it: I felt guilty that I had neglected Katie during the latter half of our marriage. She was an amazing person, and I had overlooked her, I had made her miserable.

Right now, I wanted to know she was happy again, wanted to know that the sexual satisfaction she craved was now at hand — even if I wasn't providing it.

And under the surface, I guess there was a certain amount of flagellation going on: I wanted to punish myself for neglecting her so much. I embraced the shock of the pain stabbing through my chest as much as the thrill of knowing my Katie was about to experience the thrill of passion outside her marriage.

The conversation felt quiet, so that I could even hear my heart beating.

Someone passed by my door, and I was too late to get to the peephole to see who it was, only determining it from the dark shadow that brushed by, visible in the light creeping under my door. Was it just Katie? Or both of them?

I moved silently to the other door, the gateway between the adjoining rooms. My heart leaped to see the keyhole, and the light it was letting through hinted at the possibility that I might be able to see something through it. Kneeling slowly, trying to avoid any possible sound, even the crack of my joints as I found my place, I drew in a sharp breath at the fact that I could see into Katie's room, including the lower half of the bed.

And there was Katie, perching on the edge of the bed, on the half that was visible through my keyhole. She looked exquisite, her dress hiked up to reveal black nylon hold-ups, her blonde hair still perfectly brushed and flowing down either side of her pretty face.

Was she on her own in there?

My heart burned as she sat there, longing to go in there and beg for forgiveness and a second chance to please her. Part of me felt pleased she was in there on her own. Part of me felt sad that she wasn't in the mood, or felt that my proximity should limit her evening's engagement.

Then she turned toward me, and seemed to look directly at me, sending a jolt of severe shock straight through my chest.

Somehow, I managed to keep my calm — and my silence.

She was looking at me, but after a few moments I was certain she couldn't see me staring through the keyhole. What she was doing was gazing in my direction, perhaps thinking about me, about us. About what had happened to our strong bond. It warmed me inside that she might be thinking about us.

Was there any hope this weekend of talking to her, of enticing her back to me, to the slim chance that she might be willing to try it with me again?

Alicia had clearly hoped to engineer something by inviting me, asking me to be an usher, putting me in a two-bedroomed cottage with Katie. Had she done so as a last throw of the dice on our marriage? Or was there something more than just blind luck in what was happening here.

Then, I saw a familiar shape emerge slowly from the doorway into Katie's room. Grant.

My heart performed a somersault. Simultaneously I felt elated and crushed at the evidence that Katie was back with him, and that she was about to be excessively wicked in fucking another man just a whisper away from her husband.

I wanted Katie to be the sex goddess who needed sex so much that she'd had to leave me. I probably needed the pain as much as the logical explanation for the end of our marriage. Some weird kind of catharsis, perhaps, and a little prompt to move me on in my life.

Or perhaps I was just messed up, the strange fantasy of sharing my wife now forever attached to my psyche.

For a few moments, she kept looking at me. Was she hoping I knew what was going on? Hoping I might even hear her, see her? Was she trying to get a reaction out of me?

As Grant approached her, I felt suddenly awkward. Was I supposed to do something? Was I supposed to go there, act the enraged husband, fight off Grant and win her back?

She wouldn't be so manipulative, I was sure of it. She wouldn't demand a separation just to spur me into turning over a new leaf, would she? She hadn't really given me a second chance, had she? But perhaps I just hadn't given her the opportunity to do so — I hadn't fought for her enough.

No, Katie might be hoping that I was aware of what she was doing with Grant, but she wasn't the type to want rescuing.

She turned to Grant now, and her face broke into a smile as she looked up at him, expectant, hungry. She was no damsel in distress. She was a man-eater, sitting there with her high heels and her stocking tops showing.

"Your sister seemed disappointed that I showed up," Grant said.

"I don't think she likes you," Katie smiled.

Grant stood over her, dressed in the white shirt and black pants he'd been wearing for dinner, but without his jacket and tie. He stroked Katie's golden locks as she ran a hand daintily down his chest.

"I can't understand why."

"She thinks you broke up my marriage."

"And didn't I? I get transferred back to your hospital after years away, and a couple months later you kick your husband out the door?"

Watching them, I felt the burning inside at what Grant was saying.

"You just reminded me that it had been a while since I... well. That things weren't quite what they should have been between Sean and me."

"You knew you could have this any time you wanted, so you spiked your marriage," Grant said, unsubtly placing his hand on his crotch.

She was blushing, coy as she flirted with him. It seemed to reinforce the impression that they weren't an item, that he was an occasional friend-with-benefits. Alicia had been telling the truth, then. Grant leaned down and Katie tilted her head to meet his kiss. I felt acid sharp in my stomach as their lips came together, Katie's hand wrapped gently around the back of his head, and the two of them sucked on each others lips.

These were not just strangers getting it on, these were two people who had known each other intimately since their adolescence.

It wasn't cheating, if she'd been so upfront about leaving me first, but something about her misbehavior just seemed to enhance her desirability for me. I couldn't explain it. I was rock hard sitting there in the dark peering through that keyhole. I had to keep my hands away from my loins to avoid anything premature.

They broke apart from a kiss that had made the ground shake under me, and now Katie was slowly unfastening his shirt buttons.

“Is he asleep in there?” he asked, and I felt the hairs rise on the back of my neck, that they were talking about me.

“He’s a heavy sleeper,” she dismissed the concern. “Heavy enough to sleep through the day, right?”

“Right,” Grant smiled. He didn’t really care, he’d have fucked her anyway.

But Katie had to know me well enough to know that I was invariably awake during the night, even if I knew my day’s sleep shift would be disrupted by some must-attend event. She knew I was awake just then, I was suddenly sure of that.

She must have known I’d be able to hear them, clear as day. Did she know the keyhole allowed me to see them?

She had a mischievous smile on her face as she unfastened the final button on his shirt, parting it to reveal his tanned, smooth stomach that had to have seen the inside of a gym fairly regularly, along with a regular dose of wax.

Was Katie sending me a message, then? I had to believe so. What kind of message was it?

I had to think that in most normal situations, a separated wife put in a room next to her husband with another man would take him to bed, turn out the lights and if she needed sex, do it quietly with him under the bedcovers.

Katie was not only failing to keep the noise down — moaning, now, as she trailed her hand down over the bulge in his pants, tracing out the monster lurking there — she was also sitting on the part of the bed that was in prime view of my keyhole.

But was she hoping for me to get angry enough to storm in there and stop it, to snatch her back? Or was she simply punishing me for neglecting her so badly during our marriage?

Knowing Katie, it had to be the latter. She was teasing me for being awake, teasing me for eavesdropping, teasing me for being a peeping tom, if that was what she thought I was doing. She was exacting her revenge because I hadn’t stayed to fight for our relationship, I’d simply shrugged my shoulders and walked out of her life.

I could appreciate how much pain I must have caused her, that she would think I just didn’t care. I regretted that now. I’d taken the wrong strategy.

But beyond her anger at me, the way she now smiled up at Grant, the glow of freedom she exuded as she began to stroke his hardness through those pants, made me feel she was happier with this new liberation, she was getting the sexual attention she craved.

It was such a thrill to see how excited she was, and how tearing herself away from me had turned her back into the desirable, confident goddess I had first met and fallen for.

She was licking her lips as she unfastened his belt, kissing his abdomen as she peeled his pants and his underwear down his legs, revealing that beast of a cock, which was huge even semi-hard.

Grant had even waxed his crotch, it was all smooth.

I heard Katie gasp as she revealed it, even though she'd seen it so many times before.

"I never get used to it," she said in breathless awe, grinning as she looked up at his face, then wrapped her fingers around his girth.

"Even now?" he laughed.

She kissed his taut skin just above the base of his cock, "It's a surprise every time," she purred. "It hardly seems real."

I got a sense she was talking up for the audience, and maybe telling a little white lie for my benefit. Tweaking my jealousy. Thinking that praising Grant's enormity would somehow make me feel bad about my own assets.

In fact, it was hot to watch her with that thing. Playing with it, rolling it around in her hands, squeezing it, pumping it. To see how amazed she was at it, how ecstatic she was that she was going to get to take that inside her that night.

I loved that my Katie was going to have a special time, that this other man could do things with her that I couldn't.

"Oh, it's real, baby," Grant said, making me sure that this guy might make Katie's panties all wet, but he'd never be long-term relationship material for her.

I watched her place her nose softly to his shaft, breathing him in, and then open her mouth, her tongue slipping out to run gently down his length.

It looked so obscene, and yet it made me ripple all over with lust so see her, the tip of her tongue dancing circles around the tip of his cock, before her lips stretched around it, her head tilted forward and she sank down on him.

He gently held the back of her head as my pretty blonde wife sucked Grant's huge hard cock.

Katie seemed to be in her element, loving her depravity. Was she getting off on the possibility I was hearing her, or watching her? Or had she started to forget me, her attention focused on Grant?

I saw that she'd pushed her dress up, over her hips and her behind, so it was covered no more than a shirt. Her hand had sneaked in between her thighs, and into her panties.

Katie was touching herself while she was sucking on Grant's cock. Really getting off on having that thing inside her mouth, on having this different cock at all, very possibly, after the long drought of her marriage. I think part of me did hope she was so aroused because she thought I might know this was happening in the room next to mine.

She'd never masturbated in my presence before. That sort of thing had always been private between us. It was so hot to see, now that she was doing it for Grant, but though it was only a pretty girl tending to her own desire, it was a little startling to me that it was Katie doing this for him.

"It's so big," she moaned as she came up for air.

Then he was kissing her, kneeling before her, doing exactly what I wished I could do just then, running his hands over her panties to check out her wetness, the heat of her sex.

She spread her thighs wide on the bed, allowing him to kneel there beside her and stroke her, so that I could see perfectly as his fingers coursed little circles around her womanhood, tracing out the groove of her pussy.

"God that feels good," she said as he began kissing his way around her inner thighs.

I felt such envy in that moment, and yet I wanted him to do this in front of me. I wanted to see. I felt powerless and jealous and desperately regretful, but I found myself understanding something of the excitement Henry had to experience when he knew Michelle was being bad with another man — me. While I'd seen Grant and Katie together before, the occasion that had prompted me to leave our marital home after the separation, after what I'd been through with Michelle and Henry, this now seemed like a completely different experience.

Yet the only way I could really hang on to the good aspects of my jealousy, and keep away the darkness, was to imagine that some day I would have my Katie back. I would come to her and beg forgiveness, tell

her I'd learned my lessons. To persuade her that I knew how to be the perfect husband, tending to her need for comfortable, stable, loving support while also making certain all of her sexual needs and fantasies were fulfilled, whether by me or someone else.

I couldn't help feeling disappointed as Grant pressed his mouth to her panties, and then gently grazed his nose and lips around the damp material covering her mound. I'd wanted him to be the kind of guy who simply took a woman, used her, thrust his big hard cock inside her without any kind of affection or romance or gentle foreplay — the kind of man he was the last time I saw him fuck my wife.

But here was Grant, reaching forward to remove Katie's panties, making her giggle as he negotiated them around the complications of her high-heeled shoes, and then parting her legs again with clear intent.

I had to stifle a gasp to see Katie spread before him, her beautiful pussy completely bare, without any trace of hair. Shock wracked my frame as I was given the perfect view while Grant kissed his way back along her thighs toward that little pink flower that glistened with her morning dew.

Here was Grant, his head covering my view of my wife's shaven pussy, making her jaw drop and her head tilt momentarily back as he touched down over her sensitive petals.

Here was Grant making the unmistakable wet sounds of a man enjoying a woman's taste, sucking on her wet lips, sliding his tongue inside her.

"Oh God... I love it when you do that..." she said, propping herself up on her elbows to watch him, a man that was not her husband going down on her.

She turned her body slightly, so that she was at right angles to Grant as he continued to lick her — and with her thighs wide, I could see him running his tongue slowly up and down her slit, I could see him sucking her clit into his mouth, I could see him slide a finger or two inside her as he pleased her with his mouth.

"Oh God... Oh Jesus..."

Well of course he went down on her. Why else would she return to him again and again, all though her school years, during her training, and before I came along. Why else would she take him back for occasional romps now that she was free and single again?

Did she like a guy going down on her? I felt faintly stupid for feeling that I didn't know. We'd done that kind of thing in the beginning. I loved

making a girl writhe under me like that, with such an intimate connection to the centre of her sexuality, and Katie had been no exception.

Only, it had faded from our repertoire. It simply hadn't been part of the short-cut to orgasms that our sex life had become. The few times I'd attempted to go there, perhaps under the influence of a glass or two of wine, she'd fended me off, told me "you don't need to", or some such line. Or else she hadn't showered recently enough, or else she was feeling fat, or else she just plain wanted cock.

Had that all been my fault? As with most things, I hadn't fought it. I'd been brought up with the philosophy that a guy should not go against what a girl wants, shouldn't force himself on her in any way. He should accept only what she wants.

Perhaps Grant demanded a taste of her pussy, and she just had to give in to him. Or perhaps the fact that he was just Grant, and not someone she had to spend the rest of her life with, meant she could throw off the shackles of civilization and just go to town with the kind of filthy depravities she felt were too much to share with a husband.

It was kind of sexy to see her hands clutching his head, pulling him against her as she shook underneath him, to see her not only enjoying his devouring of her, but demanding it, ordering him to keep on going.

"Don't stop... don't stop... don't stop..."

Oh how I envied him, his face soaking with her juices.

How I wished it was me in there, making her come with my mouth.

Her kiss afterwards was a reward, but she also used it to pull him in, grab the lapels of his shirt, wrestle him onto the bed, though he was perfectly willing to go with it.

Giggling again, as I hadn't heard from Katie in so very long before this night, as he lay out before her on the bed, naked, that huge great thing lolling across his stomach.

She knelt over him, stroking his chest, sweeping her hands down his body as though to make sure he was really there in her bed. Kissing him as her hands felt out his hardness again, checking that it was really there.

I felt my already pounding heart begin to leap up into my throat as I watched my wife peeling a condom down his colossal erection.

My God, she really was going to do this right in front of me, knowing I was right next door.

Where had she been keeping that condom? In her bra? She'd pulled it out of nowhere, and now she was gazing at this other man's cock like it was the most incredible gift ever given to her.

Then Katie lifted her knee to straddle him. I felt a little light-headed.

A dark part of me deep inside was snickering that I'd ever had thoughts of sharing Katie like Henry had enjoyed sharing Michelle, if this was how I was going to react to the mere prospect of another man fucking my wife.

I guess I was just never expecting the feelings to be this overwhelming to watch my wife naked from the waist down, her knees either side of another man's thighs, the sublime roundness of her behind parted to expose her bare pussy so very explicitly to my gaze and the tumescent form of another man's rampant erection, just a couple of inches below.

My head was filled with the clamor of a thousand clashing cymbals.

A faintly ridiculous thought crossed my mind as I saw Grant's hands sprawl over her hips, how dare he put his great big paws all over her perfect body like that... And yet his big prick was now pressing up against her pussy.

I took a deep breath, trying to get a handle on the cacophony of feelings rushing through my body, and focus on the fact that I was extraordinarily aroused just then, my own erection as large as it had ever been, my body effervescing with energy at seeing the most wicked of sights.

I could see right between their legs. I could see them shuffle into position, the tip of Grant's huge cock touching the lips of Katie's sweet pussy, poised and ready to enter her.

And Katie sank slowly down, taking it into her body.

I nearly exploded, nearly gave myself away as their peeping tom.

I could see that enormous pole, half of it gone, half of it inside my wife. Splitting open her sexy ass, stretching her wonderfully tight pussy, violating her. Making her let out such a glorious groan that it caused an outbreak of goose bumps all over my skin.

Her soprano moans as she took him deep inside her sent shivers down my spine.

"Oh it feels so good..."

"Fuck me, baby. Fuck me."

"You completely fill me up..."

By then, I swear I could smell her arousal, I could certainly hear the wet friction of my wife's tight pussy sliding up and down his shaft. Along with

the constant whisper of her heavy breathing, and the incredible sight of her blitzing our marriage vows, the sensual feast washing over me was overwhelming.

My Katie was riding another man like a stallion.

As she gyrated over him, she reached behind her back and flipped the catch on her bra, before removing it through her dress. Then without removing the dress, she pulled it up to reveal her breasts to him. I couldn't see from that angle, but I could see the reaction in his eyes. I could imagine how hard her nipples were as he reached up to touch them.

Grant grabbed a hold of her, then pulled her over, making her giggle coyly as he manhandled her, steered her onto all fours.

She was side on to me as he lined up behind her, his hands holding her behind firmly as that enormous thing edged into her again. Once again, I got the impression she was thinking of the angles, imagining how best I might see her if I did happen to be watching.

From this direction, I could see her looking over her shoulder at him, and the way she beamed at every thrust he made.

Kneeling up while he was still inside her, she allowed him to fondle her breasts as he planted soft little kisses down her neck. As she turned her head to kiss his mouth, I felt another little surge of jealousy — the affection between them, not necessarily the penetration, was the worst for stirring all that.

When had Katie ever giggled like that while we made love? It was flirtatious, it was girlish, it was perhaps slightly submissive.

My guess was that when we'd first gotten together, we'd clicked as equals, or perhaps with her being slightly the more confident one. She hadn't much needed to impress me with her femininity. Grant was a wild beast she had often hunted, but never brought down.

Now he peeled off her dress. He was still wearing that white shirt, though it was hardly making much difference.

Katie dropped back down onto her hands and knees, and the two of them began to grind together in sync, with Katie's body rocking back and forth as he pushed into her, his motion and power stepping up, along with her efforts to draw in oxygen.

The strain was clear on her face, her mouth wide open as he pounded her, her moans having turned into little breathy cries as that great thing stretched her as it drilled into her.

“Take it all, baby, take it all,” Grant hissed.

“Oh God...” Katie’s cries broke out into blasphemy, “Oh God, Oh God, Oh Jesus...”

She’d never been that religious with me.

Katie dropped her head down into the bedsheets, pushing her butt up for him, letting him go to town on her.

Then she brushed her hair out of her face, and I saw her looking straight at me again, the most incredible smoldering energy in her dark eyes as Grant drove on to his formidable climax. Could she see me? Could she tell I was watching? Was she merely assuming I would be there on my knees, cock in hand, observing her every nuance?

Then she was trembling, and though I guess it hadn’t happened with me in quite a while, I recognized the flush in her face, the imploring note in her whimpering cries, the way her hips spasmed as Grant began pumping his hot oil deep inside her, saved only by that thin latex barrier. Katie was coming, and coming hard.

Somehow I managed to control myself and just appreciate this sensational sight. I’d never seen her come except from the extreme close-up of actually making love to her. And those times, I’d always been distracted by my own impending climax. It was so beautiful to see.

I was teasing myself, not allowing myself to ride the crest of my own wave, but I feared the sudden crash of desire that would follow an orgasm of my own. I might stop thinking of how arousing it was to watch my wife, and be swamped by the underlying negative feelings, the jealousy, the panic, the hurt.

So I just tried to focus on breathing as I watched them lie together, kissing affectionately stroking each other, murmuring sweet words I couldn’t make out.

He seemed to make her laugh a lot. I felt certain I never did that, either. I think that may have hurt more than the fact that he’d just completely possessed my wife right in front of me, fucking her to a powerful climax I had failed to do in months, maybe years.

But as they turned out the lights, and I returned to my own bed a quivering wreck, I felt happy she was getting what she wanted. Trying to dwell on the positives, I considered how fortunate I had been to have the good times with her, the early days of our dating and marriage. There had

been a time when she'd been unable to get enough of me, and I had made her come.

And how hot it had been to watch her in her element as the most incredible sexual being. Even if I had lost her, I still loved her with everything that I was, and to see someone I loved in such glorious passion had been the most erotic experience of my life, I was sure of it.

As I somehow drifted off to my own exhausted sleep, I had come to the conclusion that it was right for her to separate from me, if that had been the only way she could unlock her inner sex goddess.

That she had become such an exquisite force of sexuality in my absence made me feel a new kind of inner joy. Oh, I still craved her, I wanted nothing more than to barge in there right now and reclaim her from Grant. But I felt transcendent, somehow — I had moved beyond the old pain and regret, to a new phase in my life.

I loved that Katie was now out there, free to fuck other men.

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Chapter Five | Addicted

I felt slightly shell-shocked in the morning, just from fatigue and the intensity of the wedding night experience. I could have gone for a final breakfast in the venue dining room, but couldn't quite face all those people.

The cottage had its own little kitchen, though, and it stocked some mini cereal boxes as well as milk, so I was happy enough with that.

I was surprised to see that Katie's room was open, and that she and Grant appeared to have gone to breakfast in the main house. I suppose they were obligated as close family. Was I supposed to be there as Katie's husband? Nobody had said anything. I guess it would be easy enough for Katie to say I was still asleep.

Curious, I nudged open the door to Katie's room a little more. I had this strange feeling that I had crossed a barrier the previous night, that if Fate did not intend for us to get back together, I'd cope with it. But it didn't mean I'd lost that wicked little tickle of arousal at the thought of Katie being sexually promiscuous.

The room was in a real state, clothes everywhere, the bedclothes torn back. Katie had not been her usual tidy self. I noticed a distinctive musty aroma in the air — the scent of sex. It was intoxicating to me. Milling around, seeing the state of the sheets, Katie's expensive black lingerie lying around the floor, I was rock hard to perceive the evidence of my wife's sexual adventures.

Had they done it again this morning while I'd been napping?

I heard the rattle of the front door, and managed to slip out of Katie's room before I could be discovered, and throw myself onto the couch in the reception area of the cottage, where I'd eaten my cereal. They were back from breakfast. Damn. I could have done with avoiding them just long enough to get out of there, get to the station — why hadn't I dived back into my room?

Katie was wearing jeans and a t-shirt that was too short to hide her midriff. She looked kind of dazed, serene, deeply satisfied. A post-sex glow, essentially. I felt a slight shiver of excitement at the thought.

“Hey,” she said. “You get some breakfast?”

“I guess I slept through.”

I got an awkward half-smile and a salute from Grant, which slightly surprised me. I guess I assumed he’d want to rub it in my face that he’d slept with Katie. Perhaps he was hungover.

Katie asked, “So you did sleep last night?”

A smile at that, which she could have read as of course I didn’t sleep, with what you guys were up to in the next room, or could have interpreted as I had a cunning plan to actually sleep on my usual night shift.

I said: “I took a sleeping pill...”

“Oh, right,” she said, and actually seemed relieved. “Alicia said these rooms are not very soundproof. She was afraid you might have... heard something. Wanted me to apologize.”

Katie was actually looking at me with pity in her eyes again, with regret. She was thinking she and Grant might have gone too far the night before. If they’d been told off by her sister, that might have explained Grant’s quietness.

“Oh, I didn’t hear anything,” I said, but gave her the kind of half-smile that suggested I might be simply telling a white lie to make her feel better.

She gave a nod, not believing a word of it. Conflicted, I’d say. She wanted me to know she was being ploughed by a different tiller, as some strange response to the news I was seeing Michelle, and possibly to drive the message home that I had neglected her during our marriage. But she still cared enough about me to feel regret at hurting me.

“That’s good,” she said. “Grant was going to sleep on the sofa bed, but it was so uncomfortable...”

“Of course.”

There was a pause, I got that sense again that I was supposed to say something, that if I got it right, I might unlock the barrier between us, even persuade Katie to give us another go. I had no idea what I was supposed to say.

I opened my mouth and nothing came out.

“When’s your train back to London?” Grant asked me.

“Oh, pretty soon,” I said, pulling my mobile out of a pocket to check the time, as though I was running a tight schedule here. “I’d better get going. You’re all driving?”

“Can’t be doing with trains.”

“Grant just wanted to show off his new Merc,” Katie dug her elbow into his side, and it made me feel something of an outsider.

“Well, it was nice seeing you,” I said to her, pulling myself up from the couch as the two of them headed for their room, maybe even for another round of something before departing the venue.

“Give me a ring some time,” Katie said after Grant had disappeared into the room, and seemed genuine. “Maybe we’ll have dinner some time.”

“I’d like that,” I said, feeling like this was some kind of minor victory. Better than it could have been, anyway.

*

I was feeling very tired as the train deposited me back in London mid-afternoon. My sleep had been all over the place that weekend, leaving me almost with a kind of jet-lag.

A 40-minute taxi ride got me back home to Chiswick, with a little of that day’s sleep shift remaining, though Henry’s door was closed, indicating that he was sleeping as usual.

I actually felt a burning need to share with him everything that had happened at the wedding, at how I’d felt watching Katie being deliciously wicked. At the sense that I was feeling a little more prepared, whatever direction my life now took. Part of me was relieved that he was already asleep. I needed shut-eye myself, badly.

It felt slightly odd to be back here, in Henry and Michelle’s place, after the intensity of the wedding weekend. I felt changed. This place was the same as it had been when I had left, but it also seemed different to me, somehow.

Collapsing on my bed, I thought briefly about what Michelle might be doing, and whether I might see her again soon. I still had this next night off — having taken extra vacation days since I knew my sleep patterns would be off after the wedding. I did hope to be with her that night, and yet after seeing Katie as I had over the weekend, I felt differently about Michelle, too.

Michelle was still the same person, the cute brunette I'd had a crush on. Yet somehow, I could see now that it was just a physical thing — a little fun. A summer romance.

The feelings I had for Katie were so much more powerful. That was what I wanted out of life.

It was Katie I thought about as I drifted quickly off to sleep. I wanted Katie, and if I couldn't have Katie, I had to find some other sexual adventuress that I could love, and who would love me first and foremost.

Michelle would forever be Henry's. While I could think of no friends I'd want to spend time with more than them, I felt I needed to strike out on my own.

*

I'm sure life would be easier if you could just decide on a plan and follow through with it. But you come up with a sound, logical, reasonable strategy with your head, and often it seems the heart just isn't in it. At least, that's the case with me.

So your head starts to come up with semi-rational reasons why you should just go with your heart.

Well, I had told myself I had closure, I was ready to start again after Alicia's wedding, I had that nice clean slate to work from in my pursuit of emotional stability and happiness. I'd told Henry and Michelle, too, and they were very supportive of my stance.

Katie had her life, now, and I had mine. We both had to move on. I even found myself a cut-price divorce lawyer — or at least the top five firms I might call for a quote when I got round to it.

Sure, I took a break from the whole sleeping-with-Michelle thing. I think my friends understood that with this clean slate of mine, I just needed a little space to get my head sorted, to air out those cobwebs, to reset my inner relationship clock, and I might need a little time to myself to do so.

I went to watch movies in darkened cinemas by myself.

I took books to restaurants for nice meals for one.

I walked around Tate Modern peering at weird angles that purported to reveal the human condition.

But I could not let go of Katie. Everything I did to distract myself, I kept coming back to thoughts of her. Every time I signed up for a dating website with the very real intention of kick-starting my love life, I found myself peering through hundreds and hundreds of profiles looking, basically, for Katie.

And then I found myself rescheduling my day off so that it fell on a Monday night, and on the next night in question I stepped out of a taxi in Clapham, at about the same time Henry and I had been there before, and I walked into St Luke's Community Center, to find myself slipping into the back of a room whose door was labeled in paper and sellotape: SAA UK.

It was unforgivable stalking.

But I forgave myself. My curiosity got the blame.

*

I'd had a new haircut that afternoon — unusually short. Over the previous few days I'd let my stubble grow extra long, to the point at which Sue Collins, our office's resident Sith Lord, had started to seethe and consult office regulations with a view to handing me a warning. I'd bought myself new clothes that might throw anybody who knew me off the scent, a dark jacket and pale chinos.

I wore sunglasses despite the fact that the sun had gone down.

I wore a baseball cap that professed some sort of fandom for a team I'd never even seen pitch a ball.

I was quietly confident in my disguise, despite feeling like a computer hacker or an ironic 90s indie rock band member. Heading into the Community Center, I even caught my own reflection in the glass windows, and for a moment or two, didn't quite recognize myself.

"Hello, you," I said quietly, and slipped inside the building.

I actually felt fairly sure that Katie wouldn't even be there. After what had happened at the wedding, I'd been thinking there was a fair chance she'd feel she'd slipped off the wagon, or perhaps that the whole therapy

thing had failed, so there was no point in going back. My plan in that eventuality was to at least sit in on a meeting, so I might try to understand her condition.

But as I actually opened that door, and slipped inside, I felt my heart catch fire — she was in there, sitting quietly up toward the front, listening intently to an old podgy bank manager of a man drone on about his obsession with redheads and *How He Turned His Life Around*. I sat down toward the back, on the other side of the room to Katie so that if she ducked out early, she wouldn't walk past me.

I couldn't see her well, but she seemed to be paying attention. She was even gently nodding at some of the things Mr Bank Manager said, as though supporting him, or identifying with some of his points.

A small brunette, who had turned stalker thanks to her particular addiction was up next to offer a brief sketch of her backstory and perhaps more interestingly talk about her day to day existence avoiding temptation, controlling her urges, and in one case losing her battle not to sleep with any of her college students. She was, along with Katie, one of only two women in a sea of men.

I was listening to them, the speakers, but I was also trying to watch Katie for any sign that she might get up and turn around. I was also trying to figure her out.

So what had happened at the wedding — had that been a relapse? A slip-up?

Who was Katie? Was she the careless or slightly cruel sex goddess who would have loud rampant sex within earshot of her poor, rejected soon-to-be ex-husband? Or was she the repentant sinner trying to pull herself back from her self-destructive addiction, who had simply had too much to drink at a wedding and ended up making a spectacle of herself?

A youngish man, perhaps my own age, stepped up next, to talk about how finding religion had helped him to curb his addiction. He had a long history of excessive masturbation, and an addiction to Internet pornography, and it had ended up with his inability to function in a relationship.

I have to say, the whole meeting opened my eyes. The misunderstanding inside me that thought sex addicts must be very attractive people who get lucky an awful lot, maybe so much that it makes them feel guilty. These were people who found their form of sexual gratification — be it anonymous online dates, alcohol-driven bar pick-ups, casual encounters

with co-workers or simply too much time in front of a computer screen — and could not stop indulging in it.

These were people who used up all their spare time on their unhealthy obsessions if they did not watch themselves, caught STDs from the unsafe sex they had, drained their bank accounts to pay strippers or prostitutes.

I ended up feeling sorry for Katie. Whether or not she had cheated on me, if this was an addiction for her, it softened any kind of blame I felt I could attach to her.

That she was coming here to this therapy group suggested she recognized her problem. Whether or not she had slipped up during our marriage, it started seeming to me that she had at least some honorable intentions in splitting us up.

That particular meeting, I left after half an hour. I might have even heard enough to assuage my curiosity.

Only through the week, I couldn't stop thinking about it all. I returned the week later, sat in the same seat, looked over at Katie sitting in her same seat. I don't know, I guess to myself I was proving that she really was a regular attendee. I was listening to more of the other addicts tell their stories, their experiences, and it was filling in some of the gaps in my own story, or at least my perspective on Katie's story.

Week three, there I was, there Katie was.

Week four, a guy stood up and told us about his sexual anorexia. He had spent his whole life avoiding sex. So why was he an addict? Because while he avoided real sex with real women, it hadn't stopped his libido. His condition led to unhealthy practices, he explained. Like being a peeping tom, like spending hour after hour on the Internet looking for filthy videos, like exposing himself to women in the park once or twice before he found God and this therapy group.

By week five, I was sitting there thinking I might have an addicts therapy addiction problem.

But then Katie stood up in front of everyone and it was clear why I'd been coming to all these meetings, what I'd really been hoping for.

"Hi, I'm Julia. I'm a sex addict."

After a murmur from the crowd as we all welcomed her and her assumed name to the group and the podium, she said, “I guess I haven’t really spoken much at these meetings...”

She seemed nervous, eyes flicking between the faces staring back at her. I found myself ducking my head at times, hoping she couldn’t see through my half-witted disguise.

“...but seeing you being so brave... well. So this is me. I’m a doctor, I’m a professional. Never thought I’d have an addiction, but I think I do. I’ve always had a big sex drive. I’m pretty sure it’s more than that, though.”

Listening to her, I was proud of her. I couldn’t help feeling a little aroused to hear about her past, at least partly because she’d never told me about it. But maybe I was messed up, too.

“I started on romance novels, and graduated to erotic novels, and then as soon as I found my feet in the world of real sex, I couldn’t get enough. I couldn’t get enough men, either. I’d ruin any relationship I was in so very quickly — as soon as I saw another half-fanciable guy.”

She told us how ashamed she was sometimes, but that often it was just a wild adventure, and if she was careful — which she was — she didn’t see that any of it should be a problem.

“And then I met a special guy,” she said, “and I couldn’t believe how good it felt to be with him — not just the sex, the being together. I loved him — I love him. I married him. And for a long time I was able to suppress the desires I had for other men....”

I was blushing, my ears burning, my heart leaping up and down. The paranoid part of me was in there whispering that she’d married before me, that she couldn’t possibly be referring to me.

“...I saw so many benefits from that stable relationship, of committing to that wonderful man. I mean, I don’t think I would have been such a success at work without him in my life...”

Was she saying that having a boring husband had helped her achieve big things in the medical profession? I strongly suspected that was what she was saying. God, I felt almost valuable again as a human being.

“...Only, the old temptations didn’t really go away. They were there bubbling under the surface. I’d learned to ignore them, or imagine different faces while I was with my husband. But as our sex life fizzled out a little a

few years into marriage, the urges inside me became stronger and stronger, and I felt more and more at risk of falling for any temptation that came my way. I didn't cheat on him..."

There it was. And there was the accompanying tsunami of relief that my Katie had not really betrayed me, not under the rules of betrayal I was choosing to accept right now.

I felt an enormous load clear off my mind.

"...but a few times, I was really close. I couldn't say 'no' very easily, and it got to the point where I almost accepted a guy's invitation to stay at his place."

Okay, this was not adultery, I was assuring myself.

"I heard about sexual addiction from a patient I was treating," Katie said. "I've been coming here ever since — but fairly soon after I started, I ended my marriage. I mean, don't get me wrong, I feel like these meetings really help me. But I was so sure I was going to slip up. My husband and I... well, work pressures had pretty much killed any intimacy between us. I was certain at some point I was going to have one G&T too many and wake up in someone else's bed.

"I'd cheated on so many boyfriends before I got married, I knew how that was. I couldn't face all the lying, the deception, the mad panic when there was any risk of discovery — not with him. A guy I used to know ages ago... he came to work at my... well, at my office again. That was like the final straw, I wasn't sure I could fend him off.

She shrugged, sniffed back a tear, then composed herself again. "So I ended it. My marriage. And it was the worst thing I ever did."

Katie was beautiful, and as in all of these meetings, she was wearing stylish clothes that showed off her figure to impressive, if respectable, degrees. But just then, she appeared a wretched, dejected figure at the podium.

"I fell into almost instant sexual fulfillment, of course, which dulled my senses to the initial pain of losing him. I slept with exes, co-workers, strangers picked up in bars, and it felt good, sure," she looked at the faces in the crowd again, yet seemed to draw strength from them, that they were not judging her.

"But it felt empty. Soulless. I was just passing the time, I wasn't really appreciating it. I was distracting myself, but there wasn't any companionship, no emotional support. And God, I missed my husband.

“After that, I came back to the meetings, I understood what was happening. I controlled myself.”

A ripple of applause at that, some supportive murmuring again.

Katie smiled, but with sadness.

She said, “A few weeks ago, I saw my husband again at my sister’s wedding. I... I don’t know what happened. I froze up. I couldn’t say all the things I wanted to say to him. We were staying in adjoining rooms, and I was planning on telling him I still loved him, I really missed him, I really regretted doing what I did. I’m not sure he would have taken me back, but I think I might have been hoping for it — although I was certain I’d have to tell him about my problem, and equally certain that might make him think twice about wanting me again.

“I don’t know...” she shrugged, “I don’t know what happened. He seemed... I guess... he’d moved on. Had a new girlfriend... a beautiful girlfriend... He had his world and I had mine. I felt kind of crushed, I guess I had hoped he’d seem more... upset. More devastated that we weren’t together. I was being stupid — of course, he’d had months to get used to the idea.

“Only, I had a couple of drinks, and there were plenty of available men around, including the guy I’ve been sleeping with on and off since he took my virginity... I knew my husband was sleeping in the next room, and I felt the need to shake him out of his whole calm thing. So I had sex — loud and long.”

We all saw the tear trickle down her cheek. My heart was in shreds to see her in pain. I just wanted to leap up and say it was all right, I hadn’t taken offense, in fact I’d enjoyed the experience. But I couldn’t do that, of course.

“I was trying to hurt him — and why did he deserve to be hurt? I was the one who left him, not the other way around.”

She smiled, sniffed away the moisture from her eyes. “So, what can I say? I had another little relapse. But here I am, I’m grateful I can see that, I’m grateful to know I have another chance. I’m planning on really working on this — you know, 12 steps and everything. I figure I’ll have to talk to my husband about this at some point, explain myself, you know, make amends. He might hate me, but maybe... I don’t know... we could be friends or something.”

Another murmur of support from the audience at that. My heart did a little somersault.

“I guess I wish I could have him back as my husband... but at the same time, I know that if I did get him back — if he wanted me — I probably wouldn’t be able to guarantee that something bad wouldn’t happen. I mean, an addiction is not something that can be cured. Mine isn’t, anyway, I’m fairly sure about that. Anyway, got to take it one day at a time...”

By the time she retook her seat, I was feeling so melted, I might have just dripped off my chair.

So, Katie had a problem. Katie loved me. Katie had torpedoed our relationship so that her problem did not affect me. Sure, I wished she’d told me all about it at the time. I have no idea how I would have reacted, but I hope I would have at least tried to accept that she had a problem, and she wanted to do something about it.

Anyway, what was the point in looking back? What had happened had happened. Now, at the very least, I had a new appreciation for Katie — even, I’d say, trust. I knew her reasons.

Only, I’d violated her trust in order to discover it.

Chapter Six | Caught

Learning the truth about Katie suddenly put my whole fixation on relaxing the boundaries of marriage into sharp relief. I wandered back to Chiswick, and the world I had developed with Henry and Michelle, and felt a strange mixture of unbelievable hope and bleak melancholy. I wanted Katie back, badly. But I wanted a happy Katie, a fulfilled Katie. I didn't want her to see herself as ill, as having a condition that needed to be repressed and locked away.

I guess those close to people with addictions probably have similar wishes, that it not be a problem. That they could go out with their alcoholic loved one and just have a glass of wine or two over dinner.

If Katie was an addict, then so be it. I still wanted her back, and I thought the way things were now, I might even be in a better position to try to help her cope with the condition. I might have to curb my own sexual fantasizing, but it would be worth it, right?

I didn't reveal anything to Michelle about Katie or her condition, but Henry knew already, so I felt I could talk to him about it during our late-night work shifts at the newspaper. It wasn't as though he had the answer for what I should be doing, now that I was sure Katie wanted me back, other than the fact that she wanted to keep her addiction from affecting me.

"Ball's in her court," was Henry's view. "She's supposed to make amends at some point, right?"

"I think so."

"So give her the chance to talk to you about it all. Call her. Then you can forgive her and you won't seem like a hideous stalker."

"But I am a hideous stalker. Or, I have been."

Henry shrugged, "Some might just describe it as committed. Love has made you obsessive."

"I'm not sure a judge would dismiss it as lightly. God, I just feel like I can't sit around doing nothing... she is hurting about all this."

I sighed, my eyes flicking around the computer screen in front of me, not really focusing on any of the words I was supposed to be checking.

Henry said, "If it's meant to be, it's meant to be, my friend."

"Yeah, I know."

"Hang in there. In my eyes, you're still perfect for each other. She likes sleeping with other men, and you fantasize about her sleeping with other men."

"I'm not sure it's really that simple, if she's decided it's an addiction."

Henry shook his head, "Society calls it an addiction, and maybe she's just bought into all that. All that Christian malarky that's hidden under the surface in those meetings. Society can't handle an insatiable woman, and it can't handle the idea of a liberated wife. It's taboo."

"I can't tell her she's wrong, Henry. It's none of my business."

He wasn't giving in. "If it is an addiction, then it needs to be managed," he said. "And how better to manage it than with a loving husband who doesn't happen to mind it if she occasionally falls for temptation?"

"I'm not sure it works that way. It would be like a drug addict marrying her dealer, right?"

"If you're her dealer, you just need to make sure you're managing it properly. Feed her enough to keep the cravings at bay, but not so much that she loses control."

I laughed ironically. "I love that we're talking about it as though I can just have her back, any time that I like."

"You just have to talk to her, Sean. Give her the opportunity to come clean. Tell her how you feel about her — and how your ideas on marriage have changed."

I nodded. "But I probably need to wait until she's ready to talk about it all with me, right?"

"Just call her," he said. "Why did she act out like that at the wedding? Because she thought you didn't care any more. She thought you'd moved on, and she was upset by that."

"I suppose so."

"So just call her, and tell her you miss her. You wish you could at least be friends. You do want that, don't you? Even if you can't have her back?"

"I do."

"Just know that there is the possibility that you take her back and you can't handle her addiction."

"I can handle it," I insisted, but the flutter in my stomach suggested I knew there was some risk that I couldn't.

*

I hovered over that phone, unable to hit the dial button. Too anxious about what she was going to say, that she had decided she couldn't see me again, because to do so would be to hurt me. And worse, I found myself catching the Tube down to Clapham South on a Monday evening, heading for Katie's group therapy session.

It was a kind of relapse, I suppose. I was addicted to her. I told myself it would be okay — I just wanted a quick update on her current situation, before I made the ultimate effort to call her. To prepare myself, so that I wouldn't get my hopes up unnecessarily, so that I'd react the way she needed me to react.

Whatever. I was an addict. I justified it in my own head. I couldn't stop obsessing about her, couldn't stop wanting to find out about her.

On that occasion, what I didn't count on, was that Katie changed her routine. I was heading out of the Tube station with a little time to burn before the Sex Addicts session began over at St Luke's, so I stopped in the Costa Coffee place across the street from the station.

"Sean? Is that you?"

And there she was. Looking gorgeous as ever, even in a simple gray hooded sweatshirt and jeans, her blonde hair tied back in a ponytail, her make-up fairly minimal. She got up from a small table toward the rear of the coffee shop, and dropped the half-muffin she'd been eating.

"It is you!"

"Katie? What are you doing here?" I asked, managing to sound relatively innocent while my brain searched for some kind of excuse why I might be in Clapham just at this moment.

While I didn't have my usual dark glasses and baseball hat on in that coffee shop, I was a little nervous she'd recognize the dark jacket I usually wore to her meetings.

"I live here now," she said. "I... well, I moved. I would've told you, but..."

I nodded, "I haven't exactly been in touch."

She shrugged, “It takes two to tango. I should have called you. So what brings you here? This isn’t your usual part of London.”

“I don’t know, I thought I’d see what all the fuss was about,” I said vaguely as the barista handed over my caffè latte.

“You’re looking for a place here?” she seemed happy about that. It stoked those little flames of optimism deep in my chest, and the whole idea gave me the faintly credible excuse I needed for being here in Clapham.

“Well, you know. Probably time I had a fresh start.”

I stepped out of the way of some irate fifty something guy in a suit trying to get to his coffee order. Katie stepped away from her table — well, it was nearly time for her addiction meeting to begin — and the irate guy swooped into her seat.

“Are you taking that to go?” she said, pointing at my coffee, which I was carrying within a cardboard cup that was indeed intended for the road.

“You know, places to be,” I smiled, and she flicked her head slightly to suggest I walk her out.

“Are you looking at any other areas?” she asked. “For your new place.”

“Not really. It’s quite nice here.”

Outside, the daylight was rapidly fading and compared to the warm coffee shop, the air had a distinct chill about it.

“Which way you headed?” she asked me.

“Oh. The Tube station.”

I figured I might as well cut and run — there was no way I was going to get away with visiting her therapy session that particular evening.

She escorted me across the road to the station, since it was on the way to St Luke’s anyway, but as we walked, she was saying how nice it was living here, that if I could find somewhere affordable, it was nice as anywhere north of the river. Of course in reality, there was no way I’d be able to afford somewhere in Clapham. Not unless it was condemned. But Katie was more taken with the idea of me moving in somewhere close to her, I guess.

Just before we parted, she reached in to kiss my cheek. “Look, I know it would probably seem... I don’t know... a little insane, but why don’t you come stay with me a few days? You could spend some time looking around here, and you’d get a better idea of where you might want to be.”

Staying with Katie. My God.

“Uh... you really don’t have to... I wouldn’t want to put you out...”

“You wouldn’t be,” she insisted. “You still working the night shift?”

I nodded, a touch sheepishly.

“Well, I’d probably hardly see you then. But you’d be more than welcome, Sean. I have a spare room — it would be easy.”

“I... uh...” My heart was palpitating. I desperately wanted to take her up on her offer, but those demons deep within me were warning me about seeming too desperate. She’d think I was weak, she’d lose respect for me. I’ve never been too fond of those demons. I said, “That would be really great. I mean, if you’re sure...”

“Of course I’m sure,” she smiled, and it made me feel like St Peter just handed me the key to the gates of heaven.

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Chapter Seven | A celebration

By the time I got home, my feelings of hope had been tempered by my paranoid pessimism — essentially telling myself that while Katie seemed to be letting me back into her life, she might still feel the need to protect me from her addiction by not getting back together. Could I somehow persuade her not to try to protect me?

I also felt a little ashamed of myself for going back down there to Clapham in the first place, when I'd essentially admitted to Henry that it was tantamount to stalking her.

Henry was on the way out the door when I got back to the apartment in Chiswick — on his way to work. Thankfully he didn't ask me where I'd been all evening, but he must have figured I was back far too early to have attended one of Katie's meetings.

He did ask me what I was doing on my Monday night off. I guess I could have changed the day since I'd given up stalking my wife.

"Uh... not sure, actually," I said. "Maybe I'll check out that new Christopher Nolan movie."

"Interstellar? Michelle wanted to see that, I think."

"Oh, right. I guess I could see something else if she's busy..."

I noticed a little glint in Henry's eye. Something was going on.

Henry smiled, "She's busy. She's got a date."

That made me chuckle, "And you're going to work tonight?"

He shrugged, "Came up at the last minute, couldn't be helped."

"She's with him now?"

"They're still at dinner. He's quite well off. Treating her to The Ivy."

"The Ivy. Damn. And you're not worried she's going to fall for him and his wallet?" I joked. "She'll be moving out before I do."

Henry laughed, but I could see the hint of anxiety in his demeanor. He was enjoying the thought of his wife playing away, but there was always that hint of risk when you were fooling with emotions, with lust and romance.

"If anything happens," he said, "she's going to let me watch via Skype."

“If she goes back to his place?”

“She’ll do it through her smartphone app. Jesus, even if I only got to listen...”

I could share some of Henry’s excitement — Michelle was so close to me, I could appreciate the joy of her sexual liberation, too. But it still didn’t give me that kick from watching Katie misbehave.

“Hey, I’m sure we can patch you in, too, if you wanted to see,” he said.

Knowing what I knew about my progress with Katie, I suddenly felt that perhaps my days fooling around with Henry and Michelle — at least sexually — were now numbered.

“If it’s possible, I’m up for it,” I said. “What’re you going to do — watch it from the office bathroom?”

“If I have to, amigo!”

And with that, Henry was out the door.

*

Of course, neither Henry nor I had any guarantee that Michelle’s date would go successfully. After the last time, though, when she’d met that guy Rick at the night club, we were optimistic.

Although the feelings might not be quite as intense as anything I felt about anything involving Katie, I could at least enjoy the knowledge that she was out there going through those nervous moments on a first date, hoping that it would all turn into something hot by the end of the evening. I could enjoy it in part for knowing something of how my best friend Henry would be feeling about it at this time.

I could also, perhaps, imagine myself in Henry’s shoes.

Henry was detached from Michelle’s actual date, instead of watching every move as he’d been able to do when she’d met Rick. It meant she could take things at her own pace, not feel that she had her husband breathing down her neck while she was having dinner. And she was, at least, intending to keep him updated, and I would be updated too, since I was connected up to them both via the free Skype messaging and video phone app on my smartphone.

I sat in front of the television and relaxed, and via Skype was able to keep Henry company while he was at work.

>What's she wearing, anyway?

>A dress. Thinnest thing I ever saw.

>And it's almost winter?

>She has a warm coat. But she's not intending to be outside for much.

>What about underneath?

>Thong, black. Matching push-up bra.

>Nice — sexy in case something happens, without looking desperate if it doesn't.

I could imagine Michelle at dinner, her coat taken by the maitre d' at The Ivy, leaving her in the kind of dress that would show off her trim body wonderfully, her push-up bra emphasizing her cleavage.

>So who is he, anyway?

>Hector. Finance guy. Met him online — I did tell you about him, you don't remember?

I had to admit that I didn't. I guess I'd been party to a conversation where my focus had been lacking, my answering delegated to autopilot.

Henry seemed understanding.

>You've been in your own world since the wedding, huh. All that stuff with Katie.

I was apologetic. But I took the opportunity to confess to my meeting Katie down in Clapham, and what had come of it all. Henry being Henry, he didn't ride me about my apparent need to continue stalking my wife. He looked to the positive, the fact that she'd invited me to stay with her.

>That's terrific! Well done!

>I'm not saying it means anything. Maybe she really does just intend for me to stay there a few days, while I'm looking for a new place.

>I doubt it. Not considering what she said at those meetings. She still wants you, old man.

>I'm hoping.

>She wouldn't want to get your hopes up otherwise.

He had a point with that. If Katie was worried about protecting me from her addiction, and intended to keep me away, our relationship strictly platonic from here on, why was she inviting me to stay? She could have just offered dinner where we could talk about where I might find a decent place in Clapham.

Henry said:

>We must celebrate. A big night out, right? The three of us.

>Sounds wonderful.

>You going to try to talk to her about everything? About her addiction, about how you feel about marriage these days?

>No idea. Guess I'll try.

*

It was eleven o'clock by the time Michelle alerted us to the fact that she and Hector were going on to a bar after their dinner. Dinner had taken a while — but then it was The Ivy. They would have taken their time, appreciated the various courses, the wine and so on.

Henry was asking me:

>Good sign, isn't it? Must be possibilities, or she would have come home.

>She could just be trying to show her gratitude for an expensive meal, spend a little more time with him.

>I doubt it — if he's well-off, she's not going to feel guilty about having him pay for dinner. If he wanted to show off, then it's his look-out.

It was half an hour before Michelle was apparently able to get to the rest room to provide another update. I left it to Henry to chat with her.

>I think we'll stay for another drink, and then maybe go somewhere. ;-)

>You like him?

>He's very good-looking, very confident. Probably not relationship material for anyone, but he's hot.

>You definitely brought protection?

>I definitely bought protection ;-) Gotta go. xxx

After that, I could imagine how on fire Henry would be, waiting there at work. It seemed like a tense half hour or so for him, knowing that she was in the process of seducing another man.

>Did you feel like this when you were waiting for her to sleep with me the first time?

>Something like it. That was a little different since we both knew you so well already. She'd been getting interested in you for a while.

>And now you don't know what to expect?

>Seems like we're doing it without a safety net.

*

It was a tense half hour, and we didn't get further updates from Michelle until she was leaving the place, and waiting for her new friend to grab them a cab.

>We're going back to his place! Getting a taxi.

Henry and I knew she wouldn't have time for much texting, just waiting for a cab. Henry asked what he could:

>It's going well? You think this is it?

Michelle managed:

>Think so. He kissed me! He's a good kisser :-)

And then that was it, all we could do was wait.

*

It was quite a while later that she sent her next text message, and I could tell Henry had been wondering if the plan to eavesdrop on her had failed, for technological or other reasons.

But then late into the night, she got through to us:

>We've been making out like teenagers. He's got an amazing apartment near Canary Wharf. Pretty impressive. I'm just in the bathroom, freshening up.

Henry replied:

>Freshening up for what?

>For a little more adult fun I guess ;-)

I was lying in bed by this time, reading my Kindle to pass the time in between missives from Michelle or conversational messaging with Henry.

Now, though, I saw the Skype app inviting me to join a video conference call — and there, suddenly, was an image of Michelle, holding her phone up to the mirror to reveal herself standing there in a little black dress, looking gorgeous with her long chocolate brown hair flowing down either side of her pretty face to splash over her shoulders.

She waved a little “hello”, but there was no sound.

Hector, whoever he was, certainly had a very fine bathroom. Spacious, with quality white tiles on the floor, a dark marble counter around the sink, and what looked like an enormous shower over in the corner.

We saw Michelle give a little sexy shimmer of her hips, one hand lifting her dress to tease us with a glimpse of her underwear, and then the camera was directed toward the floor.

>Gonna leave the camera on, hope you guys can see xxx

*

And we could see. She positioned her phone well, goodness knew how she’d hidden it. We saw a great view of a large bedroom, floor-to-ceiling windows looking out over the lights of the night-time city, and dominating the room was a huge bed.

Watching on that Skype app, I was able to message Henry at the same time as viewing the video from Michelle.

>You doing okay over there?

>Good. On my mid-shift meal break.

>In the men’s room?

>In the men’s room.

After she positioned the phone, we had to wait a few minutes. Then we saw her walk out to the bed, and glance flirtatiously over her shoulder at Hector before bending over, as though to crawl onto the bed. She looked gorgeous in that dress, which rode up as she leaned over the bed, showing off her legs and thighs.

And there was Hector, a dark-haired guy, not particularly tall but seemingly in shape. He wore a smart dark suit over a white shirt, his clothes probably more expensive than anything I had ever owned.

The man sank to his knees, in worship at Michelle's altar, prompting her to pause before getting on to the bed, to allow him to appreciate her curves in that thin dress.

Henry had to be feeling the burn of jealousy and the buzz of excitement as we watched Hector place his hand on Michelle's behind, his fingers splayed, slowly taking in her beguiling shape.

I felt suddenly curious, asking him:

>You have any kind of signal to stop her if you need?

Henry replied:

>If I call her phone, that'll stop things.

>You okay right now?

>Never better.

Hector had both his hands on her behind now, and his face was the definition of reverence. Slowly, so very slowly, he pushed up her dress, revealing the smooth skin, the pert roundness of her buttocks, and the black thong she was wearing.

I held my breath as the man pushed Michelle's dress up to her waist, then just as slowly drew her panties down over her poised cheeks, to expose her bare, smooth pussy. The tension I felt was as much from imagining how Henry was feeling at this time, as from what I felt myself.

Hector's hands returned to her behind, gently squeezing her, parting her cheeks to allow a better view of her sex. He dipped his head slowly forward, breathing in her scent, then opened his mouth to touch the tip of his tongue to her little flower.

Michelle moaned as the man tasted her, and we could hear surprisingly well through the Skype connection.

Then the man pulled away from her, and drew her panties back up over her behind, to cover her again and leave them as he had found them.

He hauled himself up, and ushered Michelle forward onto the bed, where he leaned over her to unzip her dress, and, completely unhurried, slipped it down her body, over her hips, then down over her legs and off.

I messaged Henry:

>He seems respectful

He replied:

>She's done well.

The stranger crawled onto the bed himself, but Michelle remained on all fours, not moving before his say-so. Subservient. I'd never seen her like this — it was fascinating. Sexy, of course. Different.

He placed a hand in her hair, caressing her head but also luxuriating in the silky locks, and now ran his chin over the arch of her back, down and then up over her behind, grabbing her panties with a momentary force to demonstrate his power, before opening his mouth to kiss her cheek and inhale her scent once again.

I felt very detached to watch them. The high definition camera in Michelle's phone offered us a breathtaking quality of picture, even through the small screen of my own smartphone. How must Henry be feeling, leaving Michelle to her own devices like this, losing control.

Hector held her in his arms, kneeling behind her, one hand clutching her breast, squeezing it, as the other held her hair gently but firmly.

He pressed his face to her cheek, breathing her in, while Michelle tried to reach behind her, to feel out what he offered between his legs.

We watched as the man turned her, dropped her back onto the bed, saying: "Take them off."

Michelle complied without protest, reaching back to unhitch her bra, slipping off the straps, swinging it away from her body and over onto the floor. I emitted a little gasp as she slipped off her panties for this other man, who still wore his suit as he watched her. Suddenly, I was picturing Katie there on my smartphone screen.

The man leaned over her, ran his hand down her body, over her thighs, taking in the glorious smoothness of her skin.

Hector leaned down to her, again moving so very slowly, touching his nose to hers, his hand coming up to touch her neck, and curl around the back of her head. Michelle closed her eyes and tilted her head up to him, and they were kissing, gently, Hector easing her back and into the pillows, his hand sweeping down over her breast as they kissed.

Then Hector was slowly kissing his way down Michelle's chest, squeezing one of her bare breasts, then the other, and drawing her nipples into his mouth one by one. She was breathing heavily, closing her eyes as he sucked on her flesh, tilting her head back in the pillows.

He was moving steadily down Michelle's body now, planting kisses over her stomach, his hands taking in her curves, her velvet skin. He was a

sensual man, it seemed, exploring Michelle through all five of his senses. And now he was between her thighs, running his nose over the contours of her mound, between her thighs, up to the edge of her pussy, breathing her in.

Michelle let out a long, deep groan as the stranger drew over her mound and placed his mouth over her wet little pussy, and drew his tongue along her aching groove. We watched her tip her head back again, her mouth open and sucking in oxygen, her chest heaving as he feasted on her.

It was bewitching to see. Michelle was beginning to perspire a little, her face flushed as she writhed and thrashed about.

She cried out as she came. Henry must have been loving this. Hector was clearly very skilled in the bedroom. Henry was watching his wife have a fantastic experience, really indulging in her sexuality, taking the maximum pleasure from it. And it was Henry's gift to her, when all was said and done.

Michelle looked slightly dazed as she pushed herself up on her elbows, Hector rising with her to kiss her mouth. She didn't hold back from sucking on his lips, though they were wet with her own juices.

Her nipples were impossibly hard. Was she turned on as much by knowing the two of us were watching her, itching to have her back after her passionate one night stand, perhaps so that we might take her as well? Peering at this sensational picture of her in bed with another man, I did desire her myself. Though I hadn't been with her much since I'd watched Katie at the wedding, I craved Michelle now — even if it was to be for one last time.

Hector pulled off his jacket, and Michelle reached up to remove his tie.

She seemed on fire, and I had to believe it was because right now three men had their attentions on her at once. What would Katie think about such a situation? Katie was a sex addict — maybe she had a more open mind than I assumed about unconventional relationships. She'd been the archetypal monogamous wife as far as I'd known in our marriage — but I now knew she had at least been tempted to cheat, even if she'd ended our marriage before going through with it.

What would she say if I just came out with all this stuff? That I'd changed, that I now harbored the strange fantasy Henry had shared along with his wife.

I turned up the volume on my phone, so that I could hear both of the lovers moaning as they locked lips. Michelle pulled back to unfasten the

buttons on Hector's shirt and she was smiling, eager for more of him. I even caught her biting her lip. She was so hot for him, and it was so hot to watch.

He had an impressive physique. Slender, but ripped. Whatever part of the finance sector he was in, he could clearly afford a gym membership as well as his designer suit.

They were kissing again as she removed his belt, but then the brown-haired nymph leaned back to allow him to remove his own pants, her hands running seductively over her curves, her breasts, while he did so as though he might need tempting to return to her.

She was biting that lip again as one of her hands found his package, and began to stroke him through his black briefs. One of Hector's hand found its way between her thighs to touch her, but after a moment or two she pushed him away.

"Give it to me," I heard her say. "Please."

Hector smiled and peeled his underwear down to reveal himself fully. Impressive.

Michelle seemed desperate for it, grabbing him, kissing the tip of his cock but then quickly sucking it into her mouth. He stroked her hair out of her face as she sank onto him.

Hector must have imagined she was quite taken with his size. He was well enough endowed, though he was no Grant. But I got the sense from watching her that what was thrilling her most, what made her moan quietly as she bobbed up and down on his shaft, was the newness of it — the fact that once again she got to enjoy strange cock, when as a married woman she had long ago resigned herself to never having this experience again.

Henry had gifted her that. Even miles away from him, I felt the excitement in him that she was so enjoying her gift. I envied him that.

Michelle was smiling up at her new man as she broke off to lick the length of his shaft. But he wanted more. He pulled her up.

"Turn around," we heard him say.

She turned willingly, presenting her rear, tossing her hair over one shoulder so that her face might be visible to the camera.

Hector let her wait there, on all fours, as he slipped off the bed to fetch a condom from his jacket.

Then the man knelt up between her thighs, and held his staff aloft, easing forward to dip the head of his cock between her buttocks, and stroke her with the tip. I was holding my breath as this stranger now edged forward

again, to finally enter my best friend's wife from what seemed a slightly unusual angle.

The angle at which Michelle had set up the camera phone was pure genius. We could see Hector sinking into her, we could see her pussy lips clutching at his slick shaft when he moved out of her. He held the back of her neck and her waist as he plunged into her, but Michelle now sat up, her body moving in time with his to maximize the power of his thrusts.

Hector varied the speed of his thrusts — at times pounding into her, at times only stirring inside her, holding her, kissing her, fondling her breasts. Michelle seemed to like it, this kneeling position.

We watched Michelle straddle her stranger, cowgirl-style, riding him so that her breasts shook and her body thumped down on his. We saw him spoon around her, sliding his cock inside her for a more slow, deep penetration.

But he didn't make her come again. When the end came, she took him in her mouth, and she was touching herself in such a position that her audience would get the best view.

The way she finished herself, her moans turning to exquisite cries as she allowed him to spurt his cream in long strands over her breasts, made it seem to us that it was more than just Hector turning her on — it was us, it was being watched, it was being shared, it was the fact that she knew she was driving her husband crazy by doing this.

Chapter Eight | Done

“I’m going to go freshen up, real quick,” we heard Michelle say, with a light flirtatious giggle as she got up from the bed, the man’s come streaking all over her chest.

She grabbed her phone on the way to Hector’s en suite bathroom, very subtly done, as she also grabbed her clothes and her bag.

Shut inside the stylish bathroom, she held the phone with the camera pointing at the floor for a few minutes, and I assumed she was tapping in a message for Henry. Sure enough, it came through quickly on the Skype system:

>I’ll be heading home soon. Not feeling like staying the night. Hope you enjoyed the show xxx

Quickly afterwards, Henry sent a message back:

>Can’t wait to see you! Love you, sweetheart xxx

Michelle set the camera up so that we could watch her at the sink, looking so hot all freshly fucked, with that glow in her cheeks, the satisfied glint in her eye and the merest hint of perspiration in her hair — not to mention the confident way she stood. A desired, sexual goddess before our very eyes.

She reached for a small white towel and held it under the warm water at the sink a few moments, before using it to clean herself up. The way she did it seemed designed to further tease her husband — showing off her body, emphasizing what she had just done with another man.

Then she was pulling her dress on, stretching it over her curves, slipping the straps over her shoulder, brushing out her hair with her hands in front of the mirror, then crouching to put on her shoes. Her panties she simply dropped into her bag before picking up her phone.

As she left the bathroom, we saw Hector still lying there on the bed, admiring her as she emerged before him again, but not moving to get up.

“I should probably let you get some sleep,” she said, indicating her intentions to leave. The video display went black, as though she’d put her phone in her bag.

“Hey, you can stay if you want to,” I heard Hector faintly.

“I would, but I have a class tomorrow. Maybe another time?”

“Sure, that would be great... you’re so amazing...”

“Oh no, don’t get up. I can show myself out. There’s a taxi rank just down the street, right?”

“You’re sure?”

There was some movement, then the sound of Michelle kissing Hector, though only a farewell thing.

“God, I never met anyone like you before.”

“Thank you for a lovely evening,” she said, almost purring, laying it on for him.

“You have everything?”

“I do.”

Then my connection to Michelle’s phone dropped. I was about to ask Henry what was happening, but I saw that he had gone offline as well. I supposed that he had to get back to work, his mid-shift “lunch” break had run long enough. How must he have been feeling? And how would it be to sit through the rest of his agonizingly tedious night shift knowing what his wife had just done, and how she was waiting for him to get home and reclaim him?

I sent him a text message:

>You okay, Henry?

*

I needed a glass of wine to calm down. And the company of a comforting movie on demand. Something with enough thrills to keep my mind occupied. Back to the Future, no less.

It worked, up to a point. Then as Doc Brown first unveiled the time-traveling DeLorean to Marty McFly in the Hill Valley mall parking lot, I suddenly wondered what I was supposed to do when Michelle returned home, with Henry still at work.

My best guess was that since she wasn’t a night shift person, she’d probably want to go straight to sleep as soon as she got in. She might expect

to see Henry when he returned from work, but if she did have exercise classes to provide that day, she'd want to get her rest.

Still, I did wonder if she'd return home all horny and still raring to go, after a night spent being naughty in someone else's bed. She might have received some sexual satisfaction from Hector, but the whole experience of going outside her marriage was part of the turn-on, that wouldn't be entirely resolved until she was back in Henry's embrace.

So I did prepare myself to provide her with a little entertainment in the event that she didn't want to simply sleep until her husband came home.

I was even hoping it would come to something like that by the time I heard the scrabble of a key at the front door, and the door opening.

Only, it was Henry who arrived first.

"What the hell are you doing here?"

"Sick... couldn't... stay... at... work..." Henry was somewhat out of breath. He really, really wanted to be here when his wife got home.

"And they bought this excuse at the office?"

He did look quite pale and sweaty, but then Henry always looked quite pale, and exercise wasn't entirely common in his life, despite the fact that his wife was a yoga and fitness expert.

"She back?"

I shook my head. "Any minute, I should imagine. Fancy a glass of wine, settle your nerves?"

The wine helped us both to calm down while we waited.

Sitting there with him after the fact, I found myself envying Henry again, for the experience he'd had, for that look of pure contentment on his face.

"When I watched Katie, it seemed worst of all when she was kissing Grant," I was saying, by way of conversation to pass the time.

Henry shrugged, "Kissing's an expression of love — but we're hoping our wives will only love us, right? They can have the physical thing with the sex part, just not the love part."

"Our whole culture links kissing with romance, with love."

"But I trust her. Must have hurt seeing Katie like that. Because she's not with you any more."

"It did. But I couldn't not watch — and it was still a turn-on, above the pain."

"Some men like to feel that total loss of control, you know that?"

"Really?"

“There are some disturbing extremes in this little kink of ours. Men who really go for the pain, the humiliation of being upstaged by another.”

“I don’t think I’m like that.”

:You’ll get her back, sooner rather than later. You have to believe it. If not now, then when she’s realized that sex with as many guys as she likes doesn’t make her happy.”

“I think she’s realized that already, if she’s going to that group.”

“You just need to mention the fact that you could be a husband who lets her play with other guys.”

How, that was the big question.

We were both silenced as we heard Michelle return.

*

There was an odd moment where it seemed she didn’t know who to kiss first. Husband, or lover. Then Michelle grabbed both our hands and streamed past us, dragging us with her to her bedroom.

She handed her bag to Henry, and as he turned to drop it onto his desk chair, I pulled the pretty brunette to me, curling an arm around her waist as I snatched a kiss on her sweet lips.

She didn’t pull away, smiling as she allowed it, taking in my desire for her, perhaps even a little surprised that I still wanted her after seeing her with her stranger.

She did taste slightly different, smell slightly different than usual. It was hot to think that it might be because she’d just been with someone else. It only drove me to kiss her harder, to slip in my tongue as we sucked on each other’s lips.

Henry moved behind her as we kissed, tasting her neck, breathing her in, and I knew he was similarly affected by the lingering traces of cologne and perspiration and sex from her evening’s encounter.

She might not be my Katie, but she was a sexy little imp, a free spirit, and I wanted her badly.

“So I take it you guys enjoyed my date,” she said with a devilish note in her voice, turning to kiss her husband, slipping a hand around the back of

his head as she reached for him.

“Absolutely,” said Henry around their kiss. “He was a good find.”

“Wasn’t he? I was looking for someone special, someone a little different.”

My hands found her breasts through that thin black dress, and then she was kissing me again, in fact alternating between us, sandwiched, loving us surrounding her.

We each took one of her straps to peel the dress down her petite frame. She hadn’t bothered with a bra on her way home. Henry and I shared her breasts, those hard nipples, her trim body, that perfect smooth skin.

We both tasted the mild hint of something on her chest, despite her quick clean-up in Hector’s bathroom. It wasn’t strong, but it was sex, and brought back to mind with vivid clarity the sight of another man enjoying her. She was too delicious for either of us to be squeamish about any hints of another man’s touch. Besides, the wrongness of it just added to the frisson of taking her so soon after her one night stand.

“And you did see everything well enough?”

“Perfectly,” I said.

“It all worked out very nicely,” added Henry.

We were both kneeling as her dress slipped down over her hips to reveal her bare pussy in all its glory, which for a while we simply admired, both planting kisses around her waist, her hips, her thighs, her behind, hands sweeping over velvet skin as we inhaled her intoxicating scent.

“Must’ve been cold in that taxi,” I said.

“I was still burning hot all the way home,” she said, as I stood to claim another kiss while Henry began to stroke between her thighs, tentatively exploring just how wet she was after an evening with a stranger. “I think the taxi driver could tell. He kept flashing his eyes in the mirror, looking at me, like: I know what you’ve been doing.”

I felt for the taxi driver — in the close confines of a vehicle, he must have smelled the sex on her. And Michelle looked enchanting after her encounter. Hair slightly mussed, cheeks gently flushed, her sexy frame poised with the confidence of being adored.

Henry stood to take over her kiss, but his naked wife merely touched his lips before crouching between us, unfastening her husband’s belt and fly before my own, to take us both in her hands, and then in her mouth.

I held her hair out of her face as she alternated between us, stretching her lips around one while she gently pumped the other, glorying in the double portion of manhood, reconnecting with the two main men in her life, assuring herself of our desire for her after what she'd done that night.

Just plain reveling in all the cock.

Then she was up on her feet again, kissing our mouths one by one, indulging in us both before taking up position on the bed.

I lay beside her while Henry finished removing his pants from his ankles, kissing her breasts, her mouth, grazing my fingers over her mound to seek out the wetness between her legs.

"So I thought you'd still be at work," she said to her husband, and let out a soft groan as my fingers found the hot cleft of her pussy.

"I came down with something," he replied.

"I'm glad you did..."

It had always struck me how wet Michelle got, and I suppose I'd only ever been with her while she was pursuing the fantasy of consensual infidelity, so there was no telling whether she was like this every time, or because it was particularly exciting to be shared by her husband. Tonight her sweet little pussy was particularly soaked, and it made me think the prospect of three men in one night had her really fired up.

Henry was now lying between her legs, kissing her upright inner thighs, edging his way to that beautifully shaven pussy, while I continued to tease her stiff nipples, and coax the wonderful swell of her breasts, my tongue toying with hers.

I saw him close in on Michelle's little flower, his lips touching down on her so delicately, before he gave her a very slow, long lick from the bottom up, tasting that sweet adulterous pussy. He closed his eyes and breathed in the spice of her sex and sampled her nectar, appearing like a connoisseur presented with the finest of fine wines.

I couldn't take my eyes off him, at how awestruck he was at his wife, at how startingly arousing she was to him.

Michelle was watching him for a while, too. I think at first she was making sure he wasn't freaked out by everything, that he really was happy that she'd done what she had that night. It wasn't long before she was reassured, and then she just seemed to find it fascinating how Henry was reacting to her, the kind of fervent worship he gave to her in tending to her dripping wet pussy.

“Sean’s going to be staying with Katie a few days,” Henry mentioned, hardly missing a step in what he was doing.

She cooed, and it wasn’t just because of her husband’s hot tongue slipping between her pussy lips. “That’s wonderful, Sean!”

“It’s just a few days, I think,” I said. “Supposedly while I look for a new flat near her.”

“But you hope it might turn into something?”

“You never know.”

She grinned, “That’s so fantastic. I mean, we’ll miss you, of course. But you’ve never stopped thinking about her.”

“She might just want to be friends, but...”

Michelle urged me up, to kneel beside her head, to return my hardness to her mouth.

“She wouldn’t invite you to stay with her if she just wanted to be friends,” she said, and then her lips locked around my tip, and she slid the head of my cock inside her hot mouth, using her fingers to stroke my shaft. In that position, she couldn’t get a lot of purchase on my length, but as I fondled her breasts, I gently rocked back and forth, to take the full pleasure from her mouth.

“Tonight was the first time, though, right?” I asked her. “The first time you actually went all the way with a stranger?”

“Uh-huh,” she nodded, her mouth full of my prick.

Henry seemed in his element, and having become so close to Michelle during the summer, I did feel some of the fire that he did regarding Michelle’s adulterous coming of age.

But watching him ravish her made me think about Katie, about being like this with my wife.

Henry gave way, allowing me the chance to duck between Michelle’s thighs myself and sample her adventurous pussy, while he took up my position feeding his cock to his wife.

I’m afraid I wasn’t quite the sophisticate that Henry had been, subtly brushing his lips over the soft skin of her thighs, circling in towards her pussy before gently nudging into her heat. I was straight there, hungry, curious, powerfully turned on by this brunette as well as the lingering memories of that wedding weekend and my own adulterous wife.

Her scent was pungent, ripe, and oh-so-sexy, her flavor dark and tangy, laced with a hint of the latex that had covered the last cock to penetrate her

sex. Pressing my mouth to her, sliding my tongue out into her, making her begin to gyrate her hips — it was so decadent, so filthy, so thrilling. She'd just had sex with a complete stranger, and now I was gorging myself on her slippery folds.

What can I say? It wouldn't have been every man's cup of tea. But I now embraced this fantasy, embraced the reality, and it only made me envy Henry again, that he was married to her.

"So you think you'll tell Katie about all this? About what you think about marriage now?" Michelle asked me, breaking off from sucking her husband, but continuing to lick his cock as he stroked her hair, lovingly observing me having my way with her between her thighs.

"I don't know," I said. "I'd like to."

"I guess it isn't the easiest subject to bring up."

I sucked gently on her clit, and made her gasp. Henry smiled. "She knows about Michelle, right? You said you showed her a picture."

"Yeah, but she doesn't know anything about who she is, or what's been going on," I said. "I thought her friend Laura might tell her when I told her Michelle was polyamorous, but it seems like she didn't."

"You have to talk to her, old man. You can offer her the world."

"It just depends on how she really feels about her addiction. If she really feels it's a bad thing, and it harms her life, I'll have to accept that she might want... well, some kind of chastity."

"Chastity?" Michelle sighed. "She's going to those meetings because someone's making her believe a woman shouldn't enjoy too much sex. Society frowns on women sleeping around, like it doesn't usually with men."

Michelle stretched her legs open, and it seemed an invitation to me, to provide her with more than just my tongue. I withdrew, to pull off my jeans.

"I don't know anything for certain."

"You know she still has feelings for you, she misses you," Henry said, Michelle just gripping his shaft tightly now, as though she needed something to hold onto.

Kneeling between her thighs, I was about to unfurl the latex sheath down my shaft, but Michelle stopped me, a hand on mine.

"I think we trust you by now, Sean. We know you're not seeing anyone else," she said. "Yet, anyway."

I felt a little bloom of heat inside my chest. She wanted me inside her unprotected?

I looked up at Henry, and he nodded.

The two of them watched closely as I closed in on her, and laid my hardness down along the length of her pussy. I moved incredibly slowly, as though to give them time to change their minds about this. Stroking my little purple head, which was already glistening with precum, around her soft hairless mound, and along outside her lips.

Then I dipped the tip in between her lips, running it cautiously down her soaking slit, then up again.

Henry held his breath, and I pushed forward, at a glacial slowness, and sank inch by inch into my best friend's wife, bareback.

Michelle let out a long, low groan, closing her eyes as her mouth opened wide, and she squeezed Henry tight enough to make him flinch.

She felt incredible, so intensely hot and wet around me. Her whole body moved as I thrust inside her, losing my inhibitions as the certainty that Henry was into this took hold.

"Oh that feels so good," she said in between gasps for breath. "Oh fuck me... fuck me Sean..."

It took her a few moments to remember her husband was there. When she did, she looked up at him, and the two of them shared the kind of adoring look that once again made me envious of their marital bond. Then she took him back into her mouth, Henry holding the back of her head, this time, fucking her face.

We switched for a while, allowing Henry to take her, but it seemed more the case that he wanted to watch me fucking his wife for now, so he lay back on the bed, letting her go down on him once again, this time on all fours, so that I might enter her from behind.

I could penetrate her deeply from that angle, making her groans loud and long as my force accelerated. Before long I was pounding her into him.

And that was how she wanted it, crying out: "Come in me, come in me, come in me..." as her orgasm approached.

Even as far gone as I was, I looked up briefly, and into Henry's dark eyes. He gave me a single nod.

I gripped Michelle tightly with each hand at her waist, and she pushed herself up on her hands, pushing back at me with each thrust, her whole body shuddering with every impact as I slammed into her.

“Oh... yes...” Her cries were becoming yelps and gasps as she appeared to be moving towards climax along with me.

Henry just sat back and watched in awe as I fucked her hard, taking out every ounce of frustration that had built up over a weekend watching my wife being taken right in front of me by other men.

Another last-minute glance at my friend, feeling myself building to a crescendo, and it was clear he was overjoyed at this new line we were crossing. He looked at me and said: “Do it. Come inside her.”

Michelle was wailing, arriving at her moment in anticipation that I was arriving at mine. I squeezed her waist, plunged into her and just let myself go, the energy building inside me until it erupted out of me, my hardness pulsing and throbbing within her tight pussy as I pumped my thick cream inside her.

She yelled out as I came inside her, her body juddering through orgasm in response to the feeling of another man’s seed filling her, even while her husband looked on.

As I slowed, she turned to look back at me, her pretty, flushed face breaking out into a mischievous smile at feeling my come there inside her when I withdrew my cock.

She sat up and kissed me, breathless.

“My God,” I said, not really knowing what to say.

Michelle grinned, “It’s no big deal, is it? We know you’re safe.”

I chuckled, “But I’m not your husband.”

“So?”

“Doesn’t it feel extra... wrong... for me to finish inside you?”

Michelle laughed, “That was the point. Hey, hon?”

Henry moved forward, hard as a rock, seemingly possessed by his newly seasoned wife.

Once again I envied him for what he had with her, with his wife. He kissed her long and with a passion I’d rarely seen from Henry, usually such a relaxed, calm individual.

Then he wrestled her over onto her back, her seductive blue eyes flashing with surprise and unconcealed delight at his sudden vigor, before he knelt between her legs, touched the tip of his cock to her rose-red, used pussy, and sank into her.

“Oh Jesus...” he groaned.

I'll admit to a certain curiosity, but at that point I was done. I quietly vacated the room, leaving them to it. They seemed so completely into each other, there couldn't have been any point anyway.

I felt a certain warmth inside that this whole thing had seen their love strengthen. They both deserved it, they both deserved to be happy.

But I was very much the boyfriend, not the husband here. I couldn't help feeling isolated in that moment.

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Chapter Nine | A decision

I traded a few text messages with Katie to arrange my stay with her, and it all seemed a little surreal to me. I could have moved up my next day off, but Henry advised me to wait a little, take my time.

“Tell her when your next night off is, and see if it’s good for her,” he said over a bowl of cereal, once Michelle had gone out to work, somehow fresh as a daisy after only a few hours’ sleep.

“I don’t want to seem desperate, that it?”

He nodded. “As far as you’re both concerned, you have to go on the agreed cover story, that you’re only staying a limited time while you look for a new place.”

“But if we both stick to that cover story, nothing will happen.”

“You just need to take your time, and maybe throw in some suggestion at some point, once you’re all settled in there with her.”

“Some ‘suggestion’. What, I should hypnotize her?”

“What I’m saying is, if you guys are getting on great, maybe you can drop in the question: have you ever thought about ‘us’, about trying again. Only, this time doing it right?”

“You think she’ll tell me about her addiction?”

“If you give her enough time, let her do it when she feels comfortable.”

“And if she doesn’t?”

“I don’t know. But you have to consider the possibility that she’s waiting to tell you until you’re back together, or maybe even that she feels she has it under control now, she doesn’t need to tell you.”

“But then it’s like this big secret between us.”

Henry smiled, “You’re the one that was stalking her, amigo. You gonna tell her that? People keep secrets from each other, until they’re ready to open up. Doesn’t mean they’re bad people.”

“I suppose not.”

Henry waved a cereal-laden spoon in my direction, “And if you ever do manage to tell her that you’d be okay if she wanted to date other guys from

time to time, you might consider the fact that she decides she no longer has an addiction, and never did.”

“Right.”

“So she might not tell you about it for that reason.”

As the time came for me to turn up at Katie’s new house in Clapham, I was feeling pretty nervous. I was increasingly dreading the possibility that I would stay there for a few days, as agreed, and then find myself obliged to return to Chiswick, having achieved no progress towards a reconciliation with my wife.

I even started telling myself that Katie might take the opportunity of having me there at her house to serve me with divorce papers, and really talk about the formal end of our whole relationship.

As it was, Henry dropped me off with a single suitcase packed modestly for a few days’ worth of provisions, and Katie was there at the door to greet me with the kind of relieved smile that made me certain she was feeling similar nerves for similar reasons — which somehow reassured me.

Katie had moved to another street of row houses, but unlike the house in Fulham, this was slightly larger, on a wider street lined with small trees. It seemed a calmer place than our old marital home.

Standing there wearing a pink button-down shirt and white skirt, Katie looked calmer than I’d ever seen her, too. Her outfit was unusually bright, unusually girly, and made me wonder what message she was trying to present. Relaxed, confident in her own femininity, I guessed. She was trying to attract me, but not frighten me off — that’s what I hoped.

“Hey!” she said as I waved Henry away, and turned to her.

“Hey — thanks again for having me. How’s things?”

“Good — I made you some dinner. I wasn’t sure if you had to get to work tonight or — “

I guess I’d suggested a date for my move-in, without actually telling her it would be my night off. Would she think I’d come over to stay with her, having not really spent any time with her since our separation, and I’d be immediately out the door and off to the office? I supposed that she was trying to keep things casual, not presume anything about what all this was.

“No, it’s my night off tonight.”

She kissed me briefly on the cheek. I breathed in her perfume — something new. Fresh, sweet.

“Great. Come in, come in.”

She gave me a quick tour of the house, and showed me up to the spare room, which was a pleasant enough little room across from the master bedroom, overlooking the street. Then, we sat down to dinner at a small table in the kitchen, tucking into roast chicken with vegetables. It was impressive, not least because Katie hadn't been one to cook too often while we'd been married.

Our small-talk started off a little nervously, not least because as a married couple we just weren't really used to talking to each other about trivial things like the weather, how work was going, and how we each were generally.

And I think we both sat there knowing we had heavier things we needed to talk about. But I wasn't sure I wanted to get into the fact that I wanted her back, and that I had a new philosophy about relationships, until she opened up about her addiction, and its current status.

But what if she never did open up?

I decided that if I was staying a few days, I could at least leave the heavy stuff until another day.

Then as it got much later in the evening, and the trivialities had been poured over in depth, things just started getting heavier on their own. Katie asked me about my friend Henry, about how that had all come about, and I said how great it had been that he'd had a room for me to rent while I sorted myself out.

And then Katie asked, "You're still seeing someone? Michelle, wasn't it?"

"I don't know... I think it may have run its course," I said, and thought I detected a slight brightening in Katie's demeanor. "She's still a good friend, I just think... well, it was never going to be a long-term thing."

She nodded, took a drink of water.

"When you showed me her picture at the wedding, I was so... I don't know... I didn't react well," she said, candidly.

"Oh well..." I stumbled for words, "all of this is... well, a bit of a mess, isn't it?"

"I'd been angry, frustrated, I suppose," she said. "That you could just go off and find someone, and someone so pretty. And it was basically all my fault because I'd ended things like that."

"I'm sorry," I said, feeling forgiving without any particular reason other than Katie was bewitching to me. Even after being married for years.

Absence made the heart grow fonder, but so did the fact that my beautiful Katie had been seeing other men — and on two occasions, I'd watched. My whole body craved her.

I added, "It was always going to be difficult, having me attend Alicia's wedding."

Katie looked at me, "I guess it must have been pretty awkward for you, what with all the family there and everything. I think... I think I just hoped you might have been miserable without me. And you seemed so... at peace. I just felt like a complete idiot..."

"I just didn't want to spoil the big day for you," I said. "So I tried to keep calm and not... you know, infringe."

She nodded, and I saw a few tears welling up in her eyes.

"I... I have to tell you something..." she said.

I felt a sudden quickening of my heart rate. Was she really going to tell me everything, here, now? I suddenly felt for her, for how difficult this must be for her. To come out and talk about her addiction.

"You can tell me anything," I said. "If you need to."

"I've had this thing... all my life..." she said quietly, as though we might have been overheard. "I have an addiction problem."

"An addiction?"

I felt a little guilt about feigning ignorance, but it had to be easier for her if I just let her open up about this herself, keeping things as simple as they could be.

She said: "Before you met me, a while before... I had a bit of a high... libido... you might say."

"Okay..."

"I know," she blushed, "it seems absurd, doesn't it? When I was at school... when I was at college..." she glanced around, checking on our privacy status. "I suppose it was at med school things got out of control. I nearly had to drop out."

"But you didn't."

She shook her head. "I was incredibly fortunate. I got help in time to salvage things, you know, go on with my career. But I guess when we got married... I should have told you about it."

"Well, you had it under control by then?"

"I don't know. I was so ashamed of it all. God, it was so embarrassing. So I stopped going to therapy, I just tried to ignore it all — buried myself in

work, stifled any cravings I felt. Having you in my life, though... that was really what held me together long-term,” she said.

“But then I wasn’t there for you enough,” I said. This was all my fault too, after all. Any confession would be incomplete without my input.

“Our schedules didn’t help. But it was difficult to talk about — and I think after a while, I felt those same feelings coming back, the need for sex, and it made me angry. I guess some of that anger went your way. I was actively trying to avoid you after that.”

“I should have made more of an effort,” I said.

“I don’t know,” she sighed. “Maybe even if you had been there for me, the addiction would still be there, I would still have found myself getting weaker and weaker every time I had any temptation.”

“But you didn’t, did you?” I asked, knowing I wasn’t supposed to know for certain, wasn’t supposed to have witnessed her confession at the addiction group. “While we were together, I mean?”

She shook her head. “I thought about it, but no. Going back to the therapy group was helpful. Then towards the end, it seemed like celibacy wasn’t really the answer. I was angry at what was happening to us, and that our sex life had just... well, disappeared. But I still loved you. I couldn’t do that to you. Only, the longer I went on like that, the more I felt certain that if I didn’t do something soon, I would be cheating on you.”

“So you ended things between us before you could.”

“Do you hate me?”

“How could I hate you? You thought it would be the least hurtful way.”

A tear trickled down her cheek. “We drifted apart... I guess we saw each other so rarely, I thought we’d hardly notice the difference to actually end it. Only, I guess immediately after we did split, you were still living there...”

“And you started seeing Grant again,” I said.

She nodded, “I asked him out for a drink fairly soon after we ended it. We stayed at his place quite a bit while you were still around. I couldn’t face you finding out, somehow.”

“And it was just Grant?”

“No. There were others. I saw a couple of guys from work. Another I met in a bar.”

I didn’t react to the confirmation of what had been happening, just felt calm somehow. Like that was all in the past, happening to other people. I

wonder what I would have felt if I'd known at the time she was sleeping around. I guess I'd probably have felt much like I did when I saw her in bed with Grant.

I breathed, I sipped my water. I let it go.

"So what now?" I asked. "You're still seeing Grant? Or one of the others?"

"I haven't seen anyone since the wedding. Grant is always suggesting drinks, of course, but I've avoided him lately. I've been going to therapy group again."

I nodded, and subtly examined her face for any hint that she suspected me of attending her group, that I might be the odd stubbly guy in the baseball cap who came after the start and left before the end of each meeting. I don't think she had any idea.

"That's partly what this is," she said. "I finally got into the whole 12 steps thing."

"You have to make peace with all the people you hurt with your addiction, that it?"

She smiled regretfully, "But it was really only you I hurt."

I shrugged, "Oh, well, you don't have to worry about that..."

"No, I do. I think I've been really awful to you, and what happened at the wedding... I guess I deserve to feel guilty... but maybe that helped me get back to therapy group..."

"Well, I'm pleased."

"I think now... well, maybe I just need to accept that I have a choice to make. Either I try go cold turkey and hope I can have the support of a committed relationship again... or I give in to my temptations."

"And is it so bad? Giving into your temptations?"

She sighed. "It seems like fun to begin with. Then it starts to seem empty, somehow. And the fun you have comes with a certain... loneliness. You don't have anyone special in your life. No one you can share your successes with, no one you can plan for the future with... it's just kind of... cold. The guys you see... well, they only really want you for the sex, which is okay in small doses, but..."

I looked at her, and felt my heart thumping in my throat. "You need to make the choice, or you think you have made the choice?" I asked her.

She gazed deeply into my eyes and said, "I don't think it's just my choice to make."

“I would think it’s all your decision,” I said, floundering a little, but trying to appear supportive rather than panicky. “But you don’t have to make it until you’re ready.”

Katie laughed, but without an ounce of humor. “I told myself I wouldn’t dump all my heavy baggage on you the first night you got here,” she said, flicking a finger under her eye to dab away a little moisture.

“Dump away, I don’t mind.”

She said, “I really am glad you’ve been okay. That you’re... you know... moving forward and everything.”

“I’m not sure I’d entirely call it that...”

She took a deep breath, said: “If I told you I think I made the biggest mistake of my life... that I’ve regretted what I did every single day since I left you... would you ever think you could like me again?”

Her voice was so small, so full of anguish. I had to hold back the tears just to hear her like that. God, I wish I had a double whisky in front of me — and I don’t even like whisky.

I breathed, and frankly couldn’t believe I hadn’t dreamed up some kind of response to Katie saying something like this, since it had been all I’d been hoping for ever since she’d decided our marriage was over.

Then I just tried to be honest, said: “I could like you, I do like you, Katie. I love you. I always did, I always will. Nothing will ever change that.”

I saw a tear escape her left eye, and trickle down her cheek. “And if I told you... my choice depended on whether you might... want me back?”

I felt my insides blossoming, my chest filled with a heat that was almost overwhelming for a moment or two.

“Of course I want you back,” I said. “Why else do you really think I’m here?”

That torpedoed the whole cover story about my looking for a place in Clapham. Ah well.

She nodded, but didn’t seem to quite accept my assertions just yet. “But now you know... the baggage I have.”

“I don’t care about that.”

She looked at me, deadly serious. “You know you can never entirely cure an addiction,” she said. “I mean, I can make you all the promises in the world — and do my utmost to keep them, but...”

“An addict will always bear the risk of falling off the wagon,” I said, accepting.

Jesus. I wish I could tell her it didn't matter — that I wanted her to embrace her sexuality. That if she wanted to see other men, she could, gladly. But suddenly I just felt blocked. Calling it an addiction meant immediately labeling it wrong, unacceptable. And I felt uncomfortable even bringing it up. Maybe she'd suddenly think I was unacceptable if I considered her infidelity acceptable, because she saw it as a negative thing.

"I wouldn't want to hurt you," she said. "But there would always be that possibility..."

"You wouldn't hurt me. Even if something happened... I'd be okay. We'd be okay."

She looked up at the clock on the kitchen wall — a clock that was so awfully familiar to me, but wasn't now really my clock. It was late already, or at least for a day-walker like Katie it was.

"I think you probably need time to think about all this," she said with a smile that attempted to downplay her tears. "It's all a bit much for this time of night, don't you think?"

I felt frustrated with my inability to open up about my own secrets, but I could appreciate that if Katie had work in the morning — and surgery, no less — it wasn't right to get into more heavy stuff just now.

"You need to get some sleep," I said.

She nodded, and pulled herself up to her feet. "We have a triple bypass tomorrow."

I rose to my feet, and leaned forward to take the plate from her. "I'll clear all this away, just leave it."

"You've got everything you need for tonight?"

I nodded, then found her arms circling me, and she pulled me in for a warm embrace.

It was like some kind of drug to me. Breathing her in, holding her tight, my face pressed gently to her soft hair.

"You must think I'm awful, everything I've done since I ended things," she said.

"Not at all."

"I'm surprised you can even bear to touch me."

"We were separated," I said, giving her a little reassuring squeeze.

She looked at me. "You'll think about this? Properly?"

"Of course."

She kissed me on the cheek, “I mean it, Sean. Think of the worst case scenario before you decide.”

“I will.”

I wasn’t just saying that. But as she disappeared upstairs, that wicked part of me couldn’t help but think that what Katie might imagine to be a worst case scenario — her being tempted to sleep with other men while we were still together — didn’t seem all that bad to me. In fact, it had become my top sexual fantasy, twisted or not.

*

The rest of that night, I relaxed, I read my Kindle — or attempted to, while my mind happily wandered off to thoughts of Katie, of the beautiful woman sleeping in the next room, hoping soon that I might be in bed with her again.

Then at breakfast we were both all smiles, somehow managing to talk about nothing much in particular while delighting in each others’ company. It was like early dating again.

It seemed to me that if Katie wanted me to think properly about what I wanted, given her apparent addiction, I couldn’t just blurt out over breakfast that I’d decided I wanted her back, potential infidelity or not. She wanted me to take the time over this decision, so I would take the time.

So she went to the hospital, I went to sleep. In the evening, we had dinner together, then I left for the Daily News while she slept. It was like the old routine — except that this time, we consciously made the effort to spend every possible minute with each other between our working hours.

We refrained from physical contact, though every brush of our hands sent sparks shooting up my arms, and every hug goodbye felt charged with all the things we wanted to happen, but weren’t yet permitting ourselves. It was as though we were teenagers, unsure about whether to proceed to the next step in a fledgling relationship, intimidated by the immense significance of sex. And yet there was an undoubtable chemistry between us, a craving, a lust so powerful I couldn’t remember anything like it.

While we kept up a cordial distance between us physically, Katie wasn't shy about walking around the house wearing just a pair of tiny panties and a T-shirt that barely covered her midriff, her nipples straining at the thin cotton. Sometimes, as she got ready for work, she'd be wandering around in just her panties, fetching laundry from the washing machine, her lipstick from her handbag, a slice of toast or two from the kitchen. It wasn't like Katie to be disorganized, so I knew early on she was teasing me, and the occasional naughty glance I got from her when I was caught staring confirmed my suspicions.

On the other hand, it seemed to me that I could tease her by simply being around. I noticed after the second or third night that the bed in my little spare room began to smell faintly of her perfume — evidence that while I was away working, and she was sleeping, she had taken to sleeping in my bed. It gave me a warm fuzzy feeling inside.

Naturally I kept Henry updated on what was going on each evening at work. He was happy for us, pleased with the way things were turning out, and clearly amused that this strange stand-off had materialized between Katie and I.

"Why don't you just go home after work and just tell her you've decided," he said.

"I... I don't know, it's still only been a few days."

"It's been a week. That's long enough to make a big decision."

"I suppose so. It's just..." To be honest, I didn't quite know what was keeping me from telling Katie my decision.

Henry nailed it. He said, "You know how the best thing about Christmas, when you're a kid, is the anticipation in the moments before you get to open your presents?"

"Uh-huh."

"That's what you're hooked on, Sean, my boy."

He was right. I was indulging in the joy of potential reconciliation and sex. I knew it was coming, and I loved the fact that Katie was so very obviously getting more and more desperate to do wicked things with me in bed.

She was a damn fine tease. The way she flaunted herself and gave me little wicked glimpses here and there. It made me shake all over, my blood racing around my veins. She'd leave sexy underwear casually strewn in the bathroom — and Katie was otherwise so very house-proud.

What can I say? I enjoyed her teasing.

She had changed during our separation — gained so much self-assurance. She might have felt the loss of our commitment and our companionship during the split, but her dating had given her serious confidence in her desirability as a woman. It was breathtaking. And Katie had rarely worn fancy underwear during our marriage, particularly in the latter years, but she had certainly refreshed her lingerie drawer during our separation. I had to approve.

Once, I even tried giving her a show just for a joke — walking by her in nothing but a pair of Calvin Kleins, bulging for her visual appreciation. It made her giggle, but she stared — and I'm fairly sure she enjoyed it.

It felt comfortable being with her again, and simply making sure that we made time for each other, even when we were in a rush to get to work, brought the warmth back into our relationship — while the serious heat had to simmer below the surface.

Katie seemed happy, and totally in control.

On the Sunday evening just before I headed off to work, she reminded me that she'd be attending her therapy group again the following evening, so I might not see her much. I had the night off, so I assured her she might well do, and she seemed pleased at that. But as I went away to work, I felt fairly strongly that I ought to tell her that as far as I was concerned, I was fully committed to taking her back if she would have me.

I don't know, I guess I felt a hint of danger, that she might go to her addiction group and receive some kind of revelation that made her come back to me and decide definitively that we could not reconcile. That she would always be an addict, and that she would never be able to face the possibility of hurting me.

Only, did I tell her my dark little secret before I gave her my decision about our marriage? Or did I wait until we were safely back together?

At work, Henry said, "If it was me, I'd probably want to tell her before. But you've left it so late... I don't know, I can see that it would be difficult."

I sighed. "I guess the important thing is getting Katie back, making sure."

"Probably is. You do that, you'll have time to start opening up with her, trying to communicate more about what you're thinking, what turns you on."

"And drop in the fact that I fantasize about her seeing other people?"

“Something like that.”

“What are you up to on your night off?” Henry asked.

I hadn’t even thought about it. Katie would be sleeping, no doubt. But the fact I wouldn’t have to go off to work would provide the breathing space for me to work up to telling her how I felt.

“I guess I’m telling her my decision,” I said.

*

Monday evening, I woke up feeling an odd mixture of dread and excitement, anticipating my fervent intention to take things to the next level with Katie.

I was surprised, then, to stroll out of my spare room and descend the stairs to the ground floor to find Katie lounging in the living room with none other than Henry and Michelle.

“Well hello, stranger,” Michelle was beaming.

I felt a little self-conscious, all of a sudden, standing there in a t-shirt and boxer shorts. And I’d slept with these guys, without a shred of clothing between us. I also felt the strong concern that Katie might be sitting there furious that I had apparently planned an evening out with Michelle — who, in her eyes, was simply my ex — while she was due to head off to her therapy group.

But Katie looked entirely comfortable sitting there with Henry and Michelle, as though they’d been gossiping for hours before I’d woken up.

“You forgot, didn’t you?” Henry said with mock scorn. “You’re so obsessed by your lovely wife, you totally forgot our little cinema trip.”

His expression told me fairly clearly just to go with this, whatever it was.

“Uh... God, yeah. I’m so sorry,” I said. “Interstellar, right? I have been a little distracted lately.”

Katie laughed, “I think you can probably blame me for some of that.”

“You’re okay with it?” I asked her — checking, quite obviously, that she was all right with me socializing with an ex.

“Of course! Have fun! It’s your night off, after all.”

I said, “You could come you know. Miss your meeting for one night...”

Katie shook her head regretfully. “I need to be there this time.”

“Maybe next time,” Michelle said, and it really did seem that there was no bad blood between them — they could have been best buddies.

More than a little confused, and even slightly disappointed that Henry and Michelle had spiked my opportunity to tell Katie my decision before she went off to her therapy meeting, I darted back upstairs to throw on some clothes so that the three of us could head out to the cinema.

There was no point being annoyed, though. I knew myself too well to guarantee that I’d have been able to say exactly what I wanted to say to Katie in the limited time before she had to get to St Luke’s Community Center for her meeting. I even entertained the idea that I had actually agreed to go to the movies with Henry and Michelle, and been too distracted to notice, so none of this was their fault.

But after a brief hug and a peck on the cheek from Katie, the three of us left the house bound for the Clapham Picturehouse, and I put the obvious question to them, “Did we really agree to go tonight?”

Henry clapped a hand on my shoulder, and said: “Not until just now.”

“I thought I was going crazy or something. So what’s the deal? You know you guys could’ve just asked to go see this movie.”

Walking between us, Michelle hooked her arm in mine, tightly, saying, “It was Henry’s idea. Trying to meddle.”

“Trying to meddle?”

Henry said, “I just wanted to help you — you know — introduce a few certain ideas to Katie. Help with the whole process.”

“A few certain ideas? What are you going on about?” I asked.

“Well...” Henry searched for the right way to explain. “Katie knew I was your friend, right?”

“Uh-huh.”

“And she knew you’d been dating Michelle for a while during the summer.”

“I suppose so.”

“So now... she knows that Michelle and I are married to each other.”

The ball dropped. I suddenly felt a stab of pure fear, that my friends in their altruistic attempt to help me with my communications problem with Katie, might just have given her the impression that I was the kind of guy who would cheat on my best friend with his wife.

“Did you tell her you knew about the fact I was dating Michelle?” I asked Henry.

“We strongly hinted at the fact,” he said. “Just enough to make it clear you aren’t the kind of person who would sleep with another man’s wife behind his back.”

There was some relief to hear that, if that was how Katie had taken their strongly hinted message.

“I’m sure she’ll want to talk to you about it when you get home,” Michelle said. “And you know it’s probably for the best.”

I looked at her, and saw in her eyes that she had probably objected to Henry’s great idea to “meddle” in my love life, but ended up believing it might be a good thing.

“You guys do still have a spare room for me, if this all goes wrong?” I joked, but deep down felt the strong pang of fear, that I might truly need their spare room again.

*

During the movie, as good as it was, I did still find myself replaying that whole scene in my head — of Henry and Michelle sitting with Katie on the living room couch and armchair, chin-wagging like old friends. Trying to picture the thing in as much detail as I could recall — examining every little nuance of the conversation I’d interrupted.

How long had they been there waiting for me to wake up?

Through the movie, I actually found myself settling, calming down. I remembered how easy the atmosphere had been in there between the three of them. The clear absence of any awkwardness, particularly between the women.

Katie’s relaxed attitude about sending me off to the movies with Henry and Michelle. She couldn’t have acted that way if she’d had concerns about what I might get up to with Michelle, or if she felt angry that I had been seeing Michelle behind Henry’s back.

Yet there had been a certain tone in her voice, a kind of subtle questioning lilt. It made me feel she was happy for me to go out to the

movie, but that Henry and Michelle had revealed a few interesting things about me — and she had questions that needed answering.

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Chapter Ten | Enlightenment

When we came out of the movie, based on past experience I assumed Henry and Michelle would want to go out to get a drink at a nearby pub. But Henry cheerily flagged down a cab, and practically ordered me to take it straight home.

“She’ll have some questions for you,” he said.

Michelle was smiling as though we’d just watched some kind of feel-good romance instead of a science fiction movie.

“Say hello to her from us,” she said, and blew me a kiss as I climbed into the vehicle and sat back to allow her to close the door on me.

“Good night, you two,” I said with a roll of the eyes that chided them for their meddling, while approving of their underlying motives.

The taxi ride was short, thankfully, though it still left some time for my nerves to start jangling. Yet I told myself not to expect anything — for one, it was now after midnight, since the movie had been a long one. Very probably, Katie was already in bed and asleep.

Only, as I stepped out onto the street again, paid off the taxi, and fished out my keys for the front door, I could feel a quiet confidence that the questions Katie might have for me would be suitably interesting to keep her from sleeping. Sure enough, there she was as I got in, lounging on the sofa in a sexy nightshirt that rode up to show me her legs and a pair of teasing white panties.

“You’re still up?” I asked, acting the innocent as I fetched a glass of red wine from the kitchen, trusting that I might need a little support.

“Good movie?”

“Very good. You could have come, you know. Especially if you weren’t going to go to sleep...”

She smiled as I came through to the living room, and coyly drew her knees up under her chin, as though to conceal her breasts, though it simply gave me an even more tantalizing view of those white panties. “I didn’t want to intrude. You have fun?”

“Uh-huh.”

“They’re very nice, your friends.”

“They certainly are.”

I took a seat on the opposite end of the couch, and saw that she’d been watching nothing more than Friends re-runs.

“So tell me,” she said, and I could feel it coming. “You were dating Michelle, right? For a while.”

“Uh-huh.”

“And she is married to your friend Henry.”

“She is.”

“And I got the strangest sense that he was okay about it all — that it was something he knew about.”

“He was.”

I looked at her, and the puzzlement that creased her brow without her smile dropping. I was teasing her, now, and there was nothing quite as teasing for someone like Katie than keeping juicy gossip from her.

“Okay, explain,” she said.

I took a sip of wine. “Henry and Michelle... have an unconventional view on marriage, I guess you’d say.”

“Unconventional. What, they’re swingers?”

“I don’t think they’d call it that.” The wine warmed my insides, and I appreciated it greatly. Another sip gave me time to figure out how to explain all this. I decided to start at a suitable beginning. “When Michelle was in college, she decided she was polyamorous — “

“Polyamorous — ?”

“She didn’t believe she should limit herself to seeing just one guy. She didn’t believe you could only love one person.”

“But you can just decide something like that?”

I shrugged. “Anyway, when she married Henry, all that was forgotten, and she says she was perfectly happy to be monogamous with him — she really adores him. Only, I guess when she eventually told him how she was at college, it made him curious.”

Katie laughed, but out of confusion. “Curious? He wasn’t upset about it? I thought guys liked to think the women they married were all virgins...”

“Henry’s not like other guys. And anyway, he figured what was in the past was in the past, right? Only, the way Michelle said she was polyamorous, didn’t quite seem like it was something you could entirely switch off. It made Henry wonder if being married to him was somehow...

restricting her. He started getting curious about what life might be like if she'd never given up the polyamorous thing. And he wondered if some day, she might be unable to curb her polyamorous nature."

"So wait, he wanted to see what it would be like?" Katie asked.

"Exactly."

"She didn't come to him asking him to let her try it again?"

"No, it was Henry that wanted to see what it would be like. How she would be if he wasn't... limiting her."

"He actually wanted her to sleep with someone else? I don't get it. He thought she'd let him see other women if he did that?" Katie got up from the couch, and now she went out into the kitchen, and I could tell she was going for the wine bottle herself.

"No, not at all — Henry wasn't interested in seeing other women. He always was totally obsessed with Michelle. He just wanted to see what it would be like to... you know... set her free."

"And he wasn't jealous? Jesus."

"He was, a little. It's... hard to explain. Some guys just get turned on, the thought of their wife sleeping with someone else. The jealousy's still there, but somehow... it just becomes part of the whole excitement for them. Like the fear you experience while you're on a roller coaster — it all adds to the rush."

"I... I guess I could understand that," she said, standing at the doorway into the little kitchen, taking a sip from her wine glass. "But if he's not getting to sleep with other women, what does he get out of the whole deal? From letting her sleep with other guys?"

"He gets to see his beloved wife in a totally different way, getting in touch with her sexuality, experiencing the buzz of an encounter with a new man. Ultimately, he's taking pleasure in her pleasure."

"Sounds like he's some kind of saint."

I shook my head, "It's not quite that selfless. He gets to make her happy by letting her date someone else, and then she comes back to him afterwards all fired up, and the two of them have killer sex. And while she's off dating someone else, he's waiting in anticipation of that killer sex when she gets back."

"Okay. But there's got to be better ways to get your wife all fired up, right?"

“I don’t think you can entirely understand the... the thrill... when you’re not the husband,” I said, and Katie looked at me in a slightly funny way — as though suddenly she had started suspecting that my explanation of Henry’s particular fantasy might not be inspired only by what he’d told me about it. But she didn’t want to ask me directly, yet, whether this whole fantasy was now something I shared.

I said, “You know, there is a theory that this is all just a biological reaction in males, to improve their chances of spreading their genes.”

“And how is that?”

“Guys see their woman mating with someone else, it turns them on so that they are motivated to sleep with her afterwards, to dislodge the rival male’s sperm with their own.”

“Charming,” Katie giggled, and took her seat opposite me again on the couch. This seemed to amuse her, and she was certainly fascinated by it, but what heartened me was that she wasn’t freaked out by it, she wasn’t horrified at how Henry saw his wife. “So what, Henry decided to let you date Michelle?”

“He wanted to try, at least. See what it might be like if she went out and... you know... had adventures. I guess I was a friendly face they could trust to try it out.”

“Wow,” Katie took a big sip of her drink. I couldn’t quite read what was going on inside her head. How did this concept fit with the way she perceived her own condition, her own “addiction”?

“I thought it was all pretty strange at first myself,” I said, “particularly after how I felt watching you in our bed with Grant...”

Katie gasped, and I realized that though she’d had her suspicions I’d overheard her that night in our old home all those months ago, she didn’t know that I’d actually seen her with Grant that night before I moved out.

“You saw me with him... ?” she seemed horrified.

“I had to hide out in the spare room. I didn’t want to scare off your guy, if this was something important for you.”

“I’m so sorry,” she put her hands over her face.

I shrugged. Water under the bridge. “I knew you needed your space, it wasn’t fair me sticking around after we ended things. I had to get my own life.”

“I didn’t mind you staying.”

“Anyway, after all that... well, it was nice flirting with Michelle. Kind of shocking when Henry started saying I could take her out on dates... but...”

“She’s cute,” Katie nodded, “you weren’t going to say no, huh?”

“It was all new for them, too. This was their first time actually doing something like this, so we went fairly cautiously.”

Katie sipped her drink. “I still don’t get what Henry gets out of it all. I mean, he doesn’t see other women. But she gets to see other men?”

“It’s... complicated,” I said. “I think I only really understood it when... well... I was forming this exciting new relationship with Michelle, and then I had to deal with the fact that the next night she’d be going out with Henry, sleeping with her husband...”

Katie’s eyes widened. “What’re you saying? You felt the same way?”

“You have to understand,” I said, “it’s a fairly common feeling apparently. You care about someone, you find them attractive, you’re curious to watch them.. you know... have sex. What can I say? Guys like watching people having sex. And if it’s involving someone you care about... it’s pretty intense.”

“But aren’t you jealous?” she asked. “I mean, I realize she’s married to Henry and everything, but when she’s with him and not you...”

“It’s weird. I was jealous — and I guess I still am. Only, somehow it’s part of the fun. It just makes it all more of a turn-on. It’s... hard to explain.”

I took a huge swig of wine. It felt kind of exciting, telling Katie about all this. Owning up to the strange fantasy I’d inherited from Henry. I found myself shivering slightly, giddy, buzzed with adrenaline. And it made me feel certain I wanted to tell her that my feelings for Michelle were dwarfed by the fantasy I’d developed about sharing her, my beautiful and insatiable wife. I just had to find the courage.

Katie just sat there waiting until I put my glass down again, on tenterhooks for me to explain.

I said, “I guess you see the woman as a more free-spirited, sexual being, and when she gets to flirt with other guys, and seduce them... she gets this kind of confidence that makes her more attractive to the husband, too. And I suppose the fact that you know other men want her too... just validates how attractive she is to you.”

“I can see that.”

“And then the pure biology of it all... we know she’s with someone else, we feel this rush of testosterone, and we’re physically craving her more

than ever before. It's like our bodies are setting ourselves up so that as soon as she comes back to us, we can reclaim her, stake our claim over her. Kind of primitive, I guess, but you can't deny the feelings."

Katie was just sitting there, open-mouthed. Fascinated, perhaps a little shocked.

She said, "So it turns you on, too, that she's with another man?"

"It seems strange, I suppose. While you're waiting for her to come back to you, even if you're not there watching, your head is full of all these images of her making love to someone else, and it's so beautiful and terrible and exciting and terrifying... a whole mix of emotions, but on the whole it's a real buzz."

"But sometimes you watch her... with Henry? And he watches you?"

"Didn't start off that way, but after a while... I guess the boundaries just got thinner and thinner." I felt a little sheepish — I suppose there was that old fear that she'd think I was a freak, or I was bisexual or something like that because I watched Michelle with Henry, or that Henry and I had slept with her together. But she didn't seem too — she seemed captivated by what I was saying. So I added: "We all got fairly comfortable with it, both being with her at the same time."

That provoked a quiet little gasp from her, but I don't think it was from the thought of a threesome. It was more from her surprise that someone she knew as well as me might be so startlingly unpredictable as to get involved in a threesome.

"And does Michelle see other guys, other than you two?"

"She just started to."

"And how does that make you feel?" she asked, sipping her drink as though she was watching a thrilling movie — her eyes riveted on mine, her body poised on the edge of her seat.

"I don't know... I guess I've moved on a little... it was pretty hot, but from my point of view... well, it kind of made me see that Michelle's not my wife."

"Right."

"What I'm saying is... when it was just Henry and me, if Michelle was with him, I knew that the next time she'd come back to me. I suppose I started imagining she was mine, and I was sharing her with Henry. When we went out to a bar and watched her chatting up another guy... and then she brought him home... well, it kind of made it obvious that I wasn't her

husband. She'd go back to Henry, and they'd have their thing, but I was just another boyfriend."

"Do you love her? Michelle?"

"Not really. I mean, we're good friends. I find her attractive. But I think that's part of the reason things cooled. With this sharing fantasy, I think being deeply in love with the woman you're sharing is paramount to really appreciating the whole thing."

Suddenly, it felt as though I was really laying my cards down on the table. I did want to explore this with Katie, if she was on board with the idea. And now the concept was out there in front of us, I had to at least propose it to her.

"I guess I need a wife I can explore these kind of feelings with, huh?" I said, trying to make it seem a little less heavy than it was.

I didn't even particularly mean to infer that I wanted Katie back merely so I could pursue this whole sharing thing. I was trying to suggest that it could be anyone, whoever it was that I felt was special enough to be the next Mrs Sean Ruskin. But the alcohol both emboldened me and loosened my tongue to the point where I probably wasn't quite saying what I wanted to say in the right way.

"So you're saying you think of me that way?" she asked. I couldn't tell if she was incredulous in a good way, or if she was starting to become horrified by all this, by my increasingly clear threat to the careful monogamy or chastity espoused by her addiction support group.

"I guess I can't really help it."

"Like how?" she was intrigued, and it both reassured me and perhaps surprised me a little, though with hindsight I can see that she only surprised me because I still saw her as the old Katie in many respects, the professional surgeon, the dutiful wife.

I finished my wine, trying not to seem as though I was using it as some kind of courage pill.

"When I was with her, I imagined it was you. When he was with her, I suppose I also imagined it was you," I said. I swear, she blushed when I said that. Then I added, "When we were with her together, I still imagined it was you."

She gasped and then giggled, "And you liked that?"

"It was fun."

Then she looked at me seriously, and said: “You think if we got back together, you’d want to... you know... pursue this kind of thing?”

“I don’t know,” I said. “It’s just a fantasy. Just because I’ve had these experiences, just because I fantasize about you... like that... doesn’t mean we have to make it real.”

She laughed, but again without humor. “Somehow, it seems too good to be true. I just worry about... you know... my problem. I mean going to my group, they’re fairly clear that eventually the feelings resurface... but I don’t know how that would affect us, if you were actively allowing me to... date... other people.”

“I’ve seen Henry and Michelle doing this for a while,” I said earnestly. “And it’s made them stronger and stronger as a couple. He always did adore her, but now... he worships her. It’s the best thing that’s ever happened to them.”

She nodded, and bit her lip. “I guess we’d have to be sure,” she said. “Wouldn’t we? I mean, I don’t think I could handle hurting you again. What would happen if I went out on a date and you found out that the reality wasn’t quite what you thought it would be? If it really hurt you that I was with another man?”

I shrugged, “You’ve been with other men. Recently. And I’ve known that, I’ve seen it. I’ve been handling it — in many ways, I’ve been enjoying it.”

“Enjoying it?”

“You’re still my wife. We haven’t signed any papers yet. I guess it just comforted me at times to imagine that I was just sharing you. That you’d come back to me, and that we’d continue this adventure together, without me in exile.”

“Wow,” she said, letting out a long, slow breath. Staggered at what she was hearing, what I was saying, what we were even considering here.

Then she said, “I think I’d need to think about it. I’d need to be careful.”

“Of course.”

“I don’t know... it does seem exciting... but... would you have to... watch me. When I was seeing other guys, I mean?”

I shrugged, “I wouldn’t have to. I’d want to. I’m pretty sure I’d really want to. But it would depend on how you felt about it — and, of course, how the other guy felt about being watched.”

“And if I didn’t want you to watch?”

God, I looked at Katie in front of me — so beautiful, more beautiful for some reason than when we'd been together, I'm not sure what she'd been doing since the split — and I couldn't help but feel those huge doubts, those huge fears about what it would be like to have her and to give her up. Grant her her freedom, so that she could go off on her date alone, maybe even spend the night with someone else.

Well, it had to be better than losing her, right? And it had to be better than having her become miserable because she craved the thrill of other men.

I said: "I think the point of the fantasy, at least from the husband's perspective — from my perspective — is that you'd come back to me at the earliest opportunity and share the details of your experience."

"You'd want me to tell you all about it? It wouldn't make you feel jealous?"

"It would, a little. But it would be part of the excitement."

She smiled, "It might be weird. Telling you all about it."

I said, "You don't have to tell me everything. Just a few things, if you like. That you enjoyed it, that you had a great time — that would be the most important. Other things that happened..."

"I guess if I did keep it a secret... it really would be like cheating, right?" she said. "I mean, the whole point of this is that knowing about it... hearing the details... that turns you on, right?"

"You think I'm crazy?"

She paused for a moment, then shook her head.

"I'd wonder if it was some kind of mental defense mechanism..."

I couldn't argue with that theory, though I wasn't sure if that meant it was healthy to pursue my new little kink or not. As far as I was concerned, if that was the real reason why I felt the way I did about being married to Katie and embracing her need to see other men, what did it matter?

We both sat there for a long moment, looking at each other, and I could tell she was thinking the same thing as me: could it really be that simple? We just get back together, and each of us enjoys the fact that Katie would continue to see other men?

I was sitting there, my pulse so quick I was probably at risk of some kind of embolism, thinking that if only she would have me back, it would be hotter than hell to know she would keep her sexual freedom, a fully liberated wife.

God, she'd be so confident in herself, so damn sexy.

"The question is, would you still want me, physically, if you could have any other man who took your fancy?" I asked.

She looked me square in the eye and said: "Of course I would. I'm in love with you, Sean. I always was — you don't know how hard it was to end things. But seriously, do you really think you could handle being married to me, if I was going out to see another guy? Or bringing someone home after a night out? It's not just some kind of... fiction... you make up to make yourself feel better about our break-up? Something you feel you need to make up to entice me back to our marriage?"

"I wouldn't do that," I said. "There wouldn't be any point in being married to you if I had to do that."

Bom-bom-bom. My heart was trying to escape from my chest cavity as we sat there for a few more beats, silent.

Big thoughts scrolling through our minds: were we really getting back together?

I was hard as a rock.

But Katie looked at her watch, and said, "Jesus it's late. I'm sorry, I really need to get some sleep."

"Of course," I nodded. Well, it was probably best for both of us to sleep on this, to take the time to consider what might be. "We can talk about this tomorrow. Or whenever."

She nodded, and we left it at that for the night.

I could hardly complain, it seemed only right that she would need time to digest all this.

Chapter Eleven | No holds barred

After the intensity of our conversation, I was exhausted, and ended up sleeping much earlier than usual — with the result that I missed Katie as she woke up and readied herself for work. Then when I finally emerged from a long sleep myself, hoping she might be home from work soon, I found a text message from her waiting on my phone.

>Out for some drinks after work. Just some girlfriends, nothing to worry about ;-)

The mischievous emoticon she'd included on the end of her message intrigued me, along with her advice not to worry about her going out with friends. Was she hinting that I might have something to worry about if she was out with male friends?

It made me smile, but it also got my heart beating a little more quickly, at the suggestion that she was teasing me about my little fantasy — and that she might perhaps be in the early stages of accepting it, if so.

I felt mildly frustrated that I wouldn't be able to talk to her about everything, to try to move things on. But at the same time, I was pleased she could be out enjoying herself with friends.

I sent her a text message saying:

>I'm going to miss you this evening. Have a great time, can't wait to see you again. Xxx

Then all I could do was the usual routine of dinner, and then the journey into work. The commute into the newspaper offices in Victoria wasn't too bad from Clapham, and quicker than the slow District Line from Chiswick.

Henry was there, and keen to hear how I'd got on after I'd returned from our little impromptu movie excursion.

"She had questions," I admitted with a sheepish smile.

"And you told her?"

"Pretty much everything. So she's said she's going to have a think about it — "

"But she is interested? Potentially?"

“I think so. Intrigued, I’d say. Needs to get her head around it all. Figure out what it means considering her... well, her addiction.”

“But she’s positive about it on the whole?”

I nodded. “She said it seems too good to be true.”

Henry beamed, “That is a great sign. So basically, she’s saying she has to make sure it isn’t too good to be true — she has to assuage her pessimism, her doubts. She home right now?”

“Out with her girlfriends.”

“Uh-huh, uh-huh. Well, I think you’re on to a sure thing.”

“I hope so.”

Work seemed more tedious than ever, and perhaps spurred on by my progress with Katie, I spent more time than usual searching for job vacancies, hoping to find something that might finally get me off the night shift, where I could spend more time with Katie.

Then I received another text message from Katie — presumably while she was still out on the town — and it suddenly made the night shift perk up a bit:

>I did some Internet research, and it looks like your fantasy is a lot more common than I thought. I guess it was just a surprise for me :-)

It seemed somehow unlike Katie to need the verification of Internet research to figure something out like my particular fantasy. But I supposed that she was a surgeon, and surgeons had to be constantly up to speed with the latest research — and accepting the views of others regarding a certain condition.

I suppose, also, that she’d been finding comfort in the shared experiences of a therapy group for so long, it was probably natural that she would want to validate my behavior as part of a collective group — and see how other couples responded to husbands’ fantasies about sharing their wives.

Her emoticon did suggest she was pleased with what she’d found out. I felt a little burn of hope spark up inside my chest.

I wasn’t entirely sure how to respond to her text, so I kept things light-hearted:

>Since when have you ever worried about me being common ;-)

Henry saw me tapping the message into my phone, and said, “Everything okay, Squire?”

I nodded, said, “She’s done some research about it all.”

“That’s great — surgeons are pretty good at all that research malarky. Have to be. She’ll probably be more of an expert than you.”

I smiled, “Hopefully at least, she might see the benefits of all this.”

I had to wait a full 20 minutes for Katie’s next message. It was a little more serious, but continued to stir my hopes.

>From what I’ve been reading, it looks like the important thing is that we communicate often and never keep secrets.

Sitting there, it seemed this whole thing would be better off discussed face-to-face. But I was so impatient, and my work was so very dull. Messaging with Katie could really help pass the time.

>You’re right. Michelle tells Henry everything, if she’s spending time with me or whoever. Makes him feel included, allows him to enjoy her experience.

Then Katie wrote back:

>I can see how it would bring us closer together, though. I like that idea.

I felt the slight throbbing between my thighs each time she hinted at a positive view on the concept of a semi-open relationship.

I texted back:

>And you like the idea of seeing other guys?

I guess I was subtly inquiring about how she saw that aspect of it, considering her belief that she had an addiction.

>Of course ;-) I spoke to a friend of mine who used to go to my group in Fulham. She said you were probably some kind of unicorn.

That made me laugh.

>Hardly. Although I do have the horn whenever I think about you ;-)

Was that a little too smutty? A little too rude for a text when I was trying to get my wife interested in coming back to me?

I added another text:

>You having a good night out? All this texting probably won’t win you friends.

She replied:

>Having a blast. Old friends. Victoria Basset is one of them — remember her? Grant nearly set you up with her that night we first met.

Then a few moments later, she sent another text:

>You really saw me with Grant, that night in Fulham?

I replied:

>I did.

>And that must have hurt, right? So how do you think it will be if we do this, and I'm going out with another guy again.

She was feeling guilty, still. I suppose if I'd been any other husband, any "normal" husband without the weird kink I had, it would have been a heart-breaking, horrific experience. And maybe if I'd been that "normal" husband still desperate to get his wife back, I would lie and cover up the fact that I'd been awake to experience it.

But we were being honest now, weren't we?

Honesty. Now that was an interesting idea. I texted back:

>But I'm a different person now. I guess I've changed. I wasn't asleep when you were with him at Alicia's wedding. I felt differently about that.

I had to wait a while as Katie chewed over that particular nugget of information. I'd told her after the night in question that I'd been asleep, that I'd taken a sleeping pill. Was she angry that I'd told her a little white lie to make her feel better?

Then she texted:

>You heard us? And did that make you angry?

I sighed, and figured I might as well tell the truth.

>I could see you through the keyhole. You were so beautiful.

>And you weren't jealous? It didn't hurt to watch us?

>Not angry. Jealous, maybe. It only hurt because it seemed I would never have you back, I'd lost you. But all that was overwhelmed by how turned on I was watching you.

In reply, she sent me a smiley face, and it's funny how such a tiny thing provoked such an emotional response in me — the unsurpassed warmth to know that she was pleased that I watched her at the wedding, that it turned me on. That perhaps she didn't think I was just a pervert, a freak.

I waited a few moments more, and when no more texts came from her, I assumed was doing something with her friends, or that someone had told her off for texting instead of engaging in their night out.

I think what made me happiest was that she was thinking about all this stuff. Figuring it out, working out what my new fantasy said about me and about our chances for happiness together.

"It all sounds promising," Henry said as I brought him up to speed with our little conversation. "Just don't feel bad if she doesn't go for it entirely."

"Of course not."

“Or if she just wants to keep things simple, maybe keep it as a fantasy only.”

“Right.”

“And if she does that, you always have the possibility that later on, she might start realizing you’re serious about it all, and maybe she could have a little fun on the side, and see how it impacts on your relationship.”

I nodded, and we had to suddenly look as though we were doing some work, since our supervisor Sue Collins was drifting around the office a little too near us. Then I said, “I just wonder what she’s thinking about her addiction, how that all fits in.”

“This does go against the group ethos, I suppose,” Henry said.

“I mean, if I’m here telling her we can strengthen this marriage and let her indulge her urges for a little fooling around on the side, maybe she’ll think she doesn’t need to go to that therapy group any more. But maybe she’ll think I’m a threat to her recovery. My way might just make her fall off the wagon, and then I might just as well turn round and tell her I’m not comfortable with her infidelity after all.”

“There’s always risks,” he said. “Things might not work out as you hope. But I’m sure she sees the possibility, right? If you’re careful, you can try things out, steadily, and if you’re not on board, you can step back.”

“I suppose so.”

I recalled how Michelle had deliberately slowed down the process of seducing me, when we had first got together. We had taken things one tiny step at a time to ensure that Henry really did want it that way, that he really was comfortable with the idea of his wife sleeping with his best friend.

*

It was about one o’clock when I received Katie’s next text message:

>Tell me what you saw that night.

I felt myself flush, my chest ignited by the certainty that she was referring to that night at Amelia’s wedding.

I looked at Henry, who was merrily hacking into the delights of a double-page spread on the secret to getting your garden through the winter, and I

decided I might need a little more focus and privacy if Katie was going to grill me about what I'd seen at the wedding.

I retreated to the gentleman's powder room, and locked myself safely in a stall.

I spent a long moment trying to put together some kind of reply to her text. What did she expect? Some great long filthy list of everything I saw through that keyhole? I started small.

>I saw you and Grant when you came back from the reception.

Perhaps she was looking for me to be more explicit, perhaps not. I felt that knowing Katie, she was still trying to figure out the gaps in her knowledge, and just how my head was wired. I suppose I'd just shown her an aspect of my personality that she never knew was there, after years of being together. She had to be sure how it all worked.

I sent another text to her:

>What happened to your night out? You still at a bar somewhere?

I think I needed to lighten the mood, somehow. I could cope with big conversations so long as it didn't get too heavy.

She replied:

>Back home now. Can't sleep, can't stop thinking about all this :-)

Then she sent another text:

>Did it hurt you, watching me with him?

I could have told her a little white lie, said it hadn't hurt at all, it had just been the most wonderful experience — but it had hurt, a little. Not from the fact she was having sex with someone else, though.

I replied:

>It only hurt because watching you, I wanted you so badly, I wanted to be with you after your great experience, but knew I couldn't have you.

She responded:

>I'm sorry

Then I had to lighten the mood again.

>Once I put that out of my mind, though, I could just embrace how hot it was to watch you. You were so sexual, so beautiful, so excited, so satisfied.

>And that turned you on?

>It was exciting to think you got to experience what I can't give you. You were so obviously having a wonderful time, and that made me feel good.

> Really? :-) And did you... help yourself while you watched? ;-)

>Of course ;-)

She sent me a single smiley face at that, and that made me feel strangely wonderful. I never really shared the whole masturbation thing with my wife before, it's so innately shameful in our society, I suppose. It all seems so embarrassing and awkward. We see female masturbation as something naughty but beautiful, while male masturbation is ugly and humiliating, formed around the idea that it happens because there's something missing from our lives. Katie had never seemed to want to know about it as far as I was aware, but I could see now that it was an outward sign of how watching her had turned me on.

I was curious about her, though, and sent her a question:

>How did you feel at the time, thinking that I might be able to hear?

Her text came back fairly quickly:

>Started doing it thinking you weren't interested in me any more, so I was a little upset, angry maybe. Then thinking you might hear me and even that you might want me because of it, made it all pretty wild. Afterwards, I was pretty guilty. To do that because I was in the mood to be vindictive wasn't nice.

>It was okay, I enjoyed the show :-P

>I was probably a little on the loud side ;-)

>I loved that you were. That you get properly seen to now.

There in the stall, I was hard as I typed this into the phone, and after hitting the send button, I wondered if I'd gone too far, if she'd think I was being offensive.

But she texted back:

>Why do you think I saw him again after we split up? ;-) It certainly wasn't for his winning personality.

Then, a few moments later:

>If we were back together, and I was dating other guys, would you be upset if I saw him again?

I thought for a moment, recalling not only how she'd been with him at the wedding, but how I'd felt the first time I saw her in bed with him. I'd felt some anger toward Grant back then, I think. But that anger was no longer there. I'm sure it reassured me that they weren't in love, that they were just fuck buddies. But was it Grant's fault that she went back to him and he decided to sleep with her? She'd split up with me.

I texted back:

>I don't think so.

>But you'd prefer it was someone else?

>I don't know. I think it would probably be up to you. If you really wanted to see Grant, I wouldn't have a problem with it.

>Got to go get some sleep. Love you

>Love you too.

I returned to the newsroom and a bemused Henry. I guess I'd been gone a while. I showed him my smartphone, and he already knew what I'd been doing.

"Darth Vader has sent a few death stares our way," he warned. "Better make sure you look like you're hard at it for a while."

I faced the monitor in front of me, and did just that.

Henry, I noticed, was doing exactly the same. If Sue Collins was in a bad mood, it wasn't worth provoking her.

As I got stuck into page 47 of the next day's paper once again, Henry said: "So she still thinking about it?"

I looked at him, and it was as though he was ignoring me, he was concentrating so hard on his work. That was a complete ruse, of course. Sue Collins was on the warpath.

I faced my computer screen and spoke in a similarly covert fashion, "Says she can't stop thinking about it, actually."

Henry nodded. "That is terrific, my friend. Terrific."

I was feeling so strange — my whole body fizzing, tingling, a wonderful heat flowing through me, my heart thumping along merrily.

The rest of my shift passed by in a blur, my work done virtually on autopilot, and once again I spent more time than usual looking at the job ads.

"Find anything?" Henry asked me at one point, since like me he was always vaguely hoping to escape the night shift, though nothing perfect enough ever seemed to catch his interest, either.

"Not much. Staff reporter job at Pensions Today is available again."

We smiled at each other. It was a job vacancy that often seemed to crop up. Nobody could stomach it for long.

"There's some kind of new movie mag launching online. Looking for reviews," I said, and knew Henry's ears would prick up, although the instant one of us ever mentioned an opportunity like that, we always got the feeling it would prove too good to be true.

"Independent?" He asked.

“Independent,” I nodded. Always better if something’s started up by a recognizable publishing house, in terms of job stability. You can’t ever be sure, though.

“Presumably they’re not paying for reviews, then.”

“Doesn’t look like it.”

He nodded, and I knew this particular opportunity had lost Henry’s attention.

“I think I might do it,” I said, surprising him.

“How are they funding this... what is it, a website?”

“Not sure.”

“Might want to find out,” Henry said.

“Yeah. I might see if I can do it anyway,” I shrugged. With what was going on with Katie, I felt as though I had a new burst of energy. I was motivated, for the first time in ages. “Might be good to get into some writing again, you know? Even if it doesn’t come to anything.”

“I suppose it can’t hurt. And you watch plenty of movies anyway...”

I spent the rest of my shift at the paper fashioning a response to the job advert, volunteering my services. Well, I’d been sitting back hoping for the perfect job vacancy to come my way, and it was quite clear that my expectations had always been somewhat on the high side. This was the journalism industry, and jobs were scarce and in demand. You had to be willing to get in from the bottom, and craft your own career. If you came to a dead end — as my particular role within the Daily News seemed to be — you had to back out and start again down a different street.

It made me feel even better, making a fresh attempt to do something different. I might not share the news with Katie until something came of it, but I knew she would be pleased I was making the effort to get out of the night shift.

Then first thing in the morning, as Henry and I were walking to Victoria station, where we would take separate routes home, I received another text from my wife:

>If I wanted to get back together with you, but try to remain celibate, would you want me back?

I felt my heart sink like a stone. So it was a possibility, then. That she would want to keep committed to her addiction group, her 12 steps. Return to our marriage, but keep it chaste and pure.

But I didn’t hesitate in replying to her text.

>Absolutely, no question.

What could I say? I wanted her back, with or without the sex. If she wanted to battle her addiction, resist her sexual impulses, I would do my best to help her. I loved her, and I'd rather be with her than not. If she fell off the wagon, I'd also be there to support her. But it had to be her choice what she did about her addiction, if that was what she believed it to be.

Then she sent another text:

>I think you should move in, make it permanent.

My heart leapt, and in the middle of a public street, I cried out with joy. Henry, naturally, wanted to see Katie's text message just before we parted so that he could return to Chiswick, while I took the overground train down to Clapham Junction.

I replied to Katie:

>Nothing I'd like more! You're sure?

And then Katie sent me a last little text before I hopped on the train:

>Totally sure. Oh, and if you were wondering, I'm not staying celibate. I'm not totally sure about the whole sleeping around thing, though.

Things weren't totally resolved between the two of us, but that didn't stop me from grinning like a Cheshire cat the whole way home, and garnering quite a few strange looks from the morning commuters because of it. Not only did I now have a home to go to, shared with the woman I loved, but far more importantly, I was getting my second chance with Katie — I was getting my wife back.

Chapter Twelve | Seriously

On the way home, I was in good spirits, and my thoughts were turning to Katie's final text — in which she had stated fairly clearly that she wasn't going to stick to any chastity pledge — and what it might mean for our developing reconciliation. It meant I was naturally wondering if and when she might be thinking we would rekindle our passion in a physical way.

Katie was already gone as I got home, and I wondered how she'd manage at work after her late night. I fixed myself some dinner, or what would be breakfast for day-walkers, and settled down to watch some movies before my usual bed time of around 12 noon. I found myself crafting a review of the movie I was watching — the latest X-Men movie, which wasn't the most interesting choice, perhaps, but if the people at the online magazine wanted examples of my writing, I ought to have a range of examples to share. I was only halfway through the movie when I must have passed out there on the sofa, exhausted.

The next thing, I woke to hear the floorboards creak, and looked up to find Katie approaching, a big smile spread over her pretty face.

"Hey," she said, and seemed to be trying to curb her excitement to keep from startling me.

"Home from work already?," I asked, getting up from the couch.

"It is seven o'clock," she said, surprising me with the time. I stepped towards her, and suddenly she threw herself at me, her arms wrapping around my shoulders, her lips pressed to mine.

Her kiss was so sweet, so soft, and yet so passionate. At the same time it was familiar, while somehow being completely different to what I remembered. Her golden hair was down, her face made up with subtle make-up, and her perfume was all honey and peaches and not her usual scent.

"I'm done waiting," she said, her hands sprawling around my neck as she sucked on my lips.

She was wearing a sleeveless white top and pale blue jeans, and I was ready to tear them off — but not if this was just part of her teasing.

“Your therapy group would be okay with all this,” I said, my pulse racing as I kissed her back, silently marveling at what a complete turn-on simply kissing Katie was — how had we come to neglect this while we were together? “I mean, I guess they’d have to be since we’re married.”

“I’m done with therapy for now,” she said, breathing hard.

“Is that right?”

My hand slipped over her chest and pulled down her top a little — she wasn’t wearing a bra. Her nipples were pebbles. I kissed her mouth again, then down her soft neck, , my hands cupping her breasts, fondling her, teasing those stiff little buds of hers. I took her nipples inside my hot mouth one by one, breathing in her sweet fragrance. My thoughts kept coming back to the fact that other men had enjoyed this sensational body while we’d been separated — but this defiled beauty was now mine again.

“Your fantasy...” she sighed, “... I can’t stop thinking about it...”

“Well, nothing wrong with that,” I said.

She unfastened the fly button on her own jeans, and took hold of my hand to slip it down her pants.

She was not wearing panties.

“I just... don’t want you to think I only want you back because of it,” she said.

There was nowhere else for my hand to go but over the smooth curve of her mound, my fingers finding their way to the slippery folds of her already-soaking pussy. I felt a sudden bloom of heat inside me at feeling her completely shaved now, like she had never been while we were married — and so very, very wet.

“I know,” I said, finding it difficult to think about deeper things while I was touching her like this. “If I didn’t, you’d want me back anyway, and we’d just deal with your addiction if you ever felt the need to... slip...”

“Only this way, if I ever felt the need to... slip...” she said, pulling her jeans down to her thighs to grant my fingers better access, “... it might actually be a turn-on for you, right?”

“You could safely assume that.”

I slipped my finger into her dripping pussy, and as we continued to kiss, I stirred her sensitive sex, nudging up against her clit as I thrust my finger into her.

“You really think you’d be able to handle it?” she said, panting.

“I’d be able to handle it.”

Slowly, I sank down to my knees again, craving a closer look at that incredible smooth pussy of hers.

I pulled her down to sit on the couch, and then kissed my way down her stomach, pulling her jeans off the rest of the way. I could smell her arousal, that exquisite spice thick in the air.

Breathing her in, I kissed her smooth mound, in awe at her, at how gorgeous she was. Then I opened my mouth and ran my tongue along her slit, tasting her, connecting with her, indulging in her.

“Oh God...” she moaned as my tongue flickered over her clit.

I was completely obsessed with her pussy — somehow it had a draw on me I’d never had with any other woman, not even Michelle. This was my wife’s pussy, and we were talking about bringing in other men to enjoy it. It seemed so wicked, so intensely wrong — and somehow, that made me crave it all the more.

Her gasps and sighs only spurred me on, and with a finger slipping back inside her, my hot mouth enveloping her clit, I struck up a rhythm that seemed perfect for coaxing her up to a powerful climax.

“Oh that feels so good...” she said, desperate for oxygen as her orgasm approached.

I loved how she was looking down on me in pure shock — as though she’d forgotten how it used to be when we first got together, and was wondering where this aspect of her husband had come from.

I was moaning too, the vibrations of my voice seeming to add to her experience — it was intensely arousing for me, tasting her, wedging my face into her pussy, giving her pleasure that way.

I took pleasure in her pleasure, after all. It was why I wanted her to see other men as well as myself — I wanted her to have the thrill of new, strange cock. To have those butterflies in her stomach as she agreed to a date, and went out for the evening with another guy. To have those butterflies turn to fireflies in her chest as she seduced him, as he made love to her.

“I suppose we would probably be okay if it was just us,” Katie said in between soft moans.

“We would,” I said, snatching a breath.

“I don’t need anyone but you.”

I looked into her eyes, and could see what she was doing. She was testing me. Giving me an out. It made me feel all melty inside: she was stressing

the fact that she wanted me, even if I couldn't handle the promise of my fantasy. She was also suggesting that if I'd been making up this whole thing about wanting her to date other men just to entice her back to me, I didn't need to.

I stood, and pulled her up to me, thinking that we ought to go find a bed, but then finding her temptations too much to resist just now.

She didn't resist as I turned her, kissing her neck as my hands slipped around her body to cup her breasts, my hard cock pressing up against her through my pants.

"You might not need anyone but me," I said in her ear, "but I know you'll want other guys. And you know what? If you do, that will only make me want you more."

I pulled down my pants, my boxer shorts falling to the ground with them, then I positioned her leaning over the kitchen table, and pressed my hard cock up between her cheeks. She whimpered with need. She must have built up some serious tension in recent weeks, without any release.

"I want you to be free," I said, gripping her hips and thrusting inside her, making her squeal. "I want you to flirt with whoever you want. I want you to seduce whoever you want. I want you to fuck whoever you want. And then come back and tell me." Each sentence was punctuated by a hard thrust.

She was tight, despite her recent brushes with the enormous Grant. And so wet. Her body shook as I slammed into her.

"Oh Jesus..."

I guess this was reclaiming her from all those guys she'd been with in the months that we'd been separated. I felt like some kind of animal — a stallion or even a dog — mating with a female after fending off my rivals. It was base, it was instinct, it was biological — my body taking on superhuman form to make certain it was my genes being passed on, and not those of her lovers.

But I didn't give in to my body's full yearning, not just yet. I wanted more, more time to get my head around this whole reclaiming thing, and to appreciate it. I wanted to show her how much I loved her, how much I valued her. How different I was to the big pricks she just rutted with.

I stopped, and withdrew, stealing a brief taste of her pussy while I was down there.

“The bedroom,” I said as I stood up again, and she turned to me, pressing herself against me, kissing my lips.

“What time do you need to get to sleep?”

“It doesn’t matter.”

She led me upstairs, my eyes running all over her divine body as I followed her up the narrow staircase, and she swayed her hips a little more than usual for my benefit, even reaching behind at one point to give one of her cheeks a mischievous squeeze.

As soon as we reached the bedroom she was clambering onto the bed, tearing off her top to leave her completely bare, giggling as she presented herself on all fours, and I was right behind her, so hungry for her.

If I was feeling animalistic about my reclaiming of her, then to see her go down on all fours, her beautifully round ass tilted up for me, only enhanced that feeling. Crawling between her legs, I placed an upturned palm on her shaven mound, and tilted her dewy flower further up so I could devour her.

She gasped, and then almost mewed as I ate her like I would a juicy peach, her body gently rocking back and forth as she panted for breath.

I was feeling pretty pleased with myself, as well as with my stunning wife. I guess one of the things on my mind in recent weeks had been that if I got Katie back, I might find the reality of being with her again did not match the fantasy — and at worst, that I might be turned off by being with her when I knew she’d been with other men.

But here I was, and I’d never been as aroused as I was now. I loved that my beautiful, astoundingly smart wife had a naughty streak a mile wide, and in a somewhat self-aware moment, I was loving the fact that I was so thrilled by her wicked nature, and the prospect that it might continue with us back together.

All pumped up, I kissed my way up the curve of her lower back, and moved over her, Katie pushing herself up on her hands as I covered her, allowing me to push my nose into her hair and breathe in the clean scent.

My hard cock lodged against her behind, and I felt her stir her hips, desperate for it inside her.

“Fuck me,” she breathed, “please, I need it so badly.”

I sat up to guide my cock in between her thighs, and up to the searing heat of her dripping pussy. She moaned long and low as I squeezed into her, the tip of my cock slipping inside her, then the rest of my full length.

“My God, you’re so hard...” she said in awe.

“I’ve wanted you back for a very long time.”

“That’s not all it is, though.”

“Not all.”

My movement inside her was accelerating, I just needed to fuck her, as she needed to be fucked. I grabbed her hips and pounded into her, her whole body shaking and rocking under my assault, her breasts swinging under her, her hair swaying. It was all red faces and perspiration, physical exertion with one goal in sight, and no time to stop and appreciate the scenery.

She came, hard, screaming and shuddering under me, and I think ordinarily I would have gone with her — only, at the last minute, I held back.

As she slowed, breathless, I pushed her gently but firmly down against the mattress, and still inside her, rolled with her so that we lay side-by-side, spooning against each other.

“You’re still going?” she asked after a few moments of recovery.

“You’re having that affect on me.”

“You’re thinking about what I’ve done while we were separated? Or what we might do now we’re back together?”

“A little of both.”

She was a little flushed, perspiration just lightly mussing up her hair, and it only drove me wild to think that this was how other guys might have seen her, as she had given in to her vices.

“Aren’t you freaked out that I was with other men?” she asked, genuinely curious though she knew she was teasing me.

“Nope,” I said, loving how hard her nipples were on her breasts as they jiggled each time I entered her.

“You don’t hate it that I was such a bad girl?” she smiled, her curiosity bowing to her need to tease me.

“Oh, definitely not.”

“I drowned my sorrows by tracking down the first big cock I could find to come home with me, to fuck me ’til I was sore...”

She had to feel my cock swelling inside her at the sound of those filthy words coming out of her pretty mouth. Had to feel me throbbing with every mental image of her as a wicked temptress inviting co-workers or friends or random strangers from bars back to slip on a condom and slide deep inside her.

“You know I fucked a woman, once?”

“Seriously?”

“It was... interesting. I’m not sure I need to do it again in a rush, but I guess it was... nice. Different.”

“It was just you and her, or was she part of a couple?” my mind was reeling at the hot thoughts Katie was implanting in my head.

“Part of a couple. I was going for him, and never realized he was attached until we got to his place.”

She pulled away and climbed over me, to straddle me before sliding my cock back inside her. It gave me a superb view, as she brushed her hair back over her shoulders, jutted out her chest.

She rode me slowly, but I could feel myself getting closer and closer.

It was when she said: “So we’re really going to do this, right?” that I knew I’d reached the point of no return, at least in the time we had left before I had to go to work.

I said, “We are if you want to.”

She nodded. “Oh, I want to. Can you handle it?”

“Of course.”

“I’m going to go out with other guys if I feel like it — and maybe bring them home?”

“I hope so.”

“You might come home from work to find I’ve been fucked all night long by another man.”

“God, I hope so.”

“Will you freak out when you get into bed with me, and you can still smell the sex? You can still detect him on me? That I’m all messed up because some stranger has been inside me, filling me, stretching me, fucking me?”

And that was enough to set me off, exploding inside her like I’d never come before.

We fell asleep there where we fell, spooned against each other. I found myself thinking that the way she’d been teasing me while we’d made love did suggest she really had researched my whole fantasy. She knew which buttons to press to get me going.

Katie always had been very bright.

This was going to be a lot of fun.

Chapter Thirteen | It begins

But we didn't rush into anything.

For a while, Katie and I simply enjoyed being back together, appreciating each other, patching things up and addressing the issues we'd failed to address when we'd split up.

To begin with, it almost seemed like a new relationship for us both — we were different people, we'd developed during the separation, we had moved on. The absence had made our hearts grow stronger, but our new openness was the huge thing, I think. And in being suddenly able to talk to each other about our fantasies and our desires, it helped ramp up the passion between us.

We did talk about my fantasy, about Katie sleeping with other men. We also talked about some of her fantasies — for example, certain men she wanted, or a certain number of men she wanted at once, or the certain number of men she wanted to have while being watched, at risk of being caught. Sharing fantasies was as good a way to get us both going as anything, and for a long while we didn't see the need to go any further.

Then, a few weeks down the line, as things were settling and we were confident in the concrete bond now between us, we seemed to naturally fall into talking more and more about the idea of Katie seeing other men while we made love, rather than any other particular fantasy. It no longer seemed to be my fantasy alone, or me driving us to consider fulfilling it. It was our fantasy, and Katie was as much turned on by it as I was — and not just for the obvious reason that she would be able to sleep around. She seemed as much interested in the fact that it turned me on, and that in seeing someone else, she would get to fire me up like nothing else.

One night, Katie was out at a bar with her girl friends, and instead of my usual night shift at the newspaper, I actually had to go out to a press screening of a new Alex Garland-directed science fiction movie, *Ex Machina*. Katie had been thrilled at my progress since volunteering reviews at the online magazine down in Wimbledon — and true enough, I'd spun things a little thanks to my having a Daily News email address, but it had

eventually led to an entertainment editor in an actual national newspaper agreeing to use my reviews when there were a few inches going spare.

So on this particular night, I was going to an actual press screening, to write a review that would be read by thousands of people. True, I wasn't being paid a whole lot, but that wasn't the point, I had to start somewhere.

Only, as the movie got into the second reel, Katie sent me a text message that threatened to blunt my focus on the task at hand.

>So I'm in a bar, and there's a guy hitting on me.

After a mere glimpse of the message, I felt my blood begin to rush southward. It even made me shiver a little, although the air conditioning in that Leicester Square theater was also a little on the excessive side.

I smiled. She couldn't have just innocently sent that text, knowing what I might think of it. Was she really beginning to consider making the fantasy real?

I sent a reply back:

>If you were single, would you let him hit on you?

It wasn't long before I received her response:

>Probably. He's quite attractive.

>So what's the problem? Just enjoy it. Keep me updated ;-)

Then, a few moments later:

>Really?

>Really.

My heart thudded so loud, particularly since the movie had turned quietly introspective, that I wondered if another reviewer might lean over to ask me to take it outside.

Then I had another little text from Katie:

>You're the best husband in the world xxx

Somehow, I had to sit out the rest of that movie, and concentrate sufficiently to write something meaningful about it. Thankfully, it was a fairly interesting film, with production values that far outclassed its relatively lowly budget.

As the movie reached its third act, Katie sent a text stating:

>We're going to another bar, just the two of us ;-)

Much as I was enjoying the movie, it was Katie who was now keeping me on the edge of my seat.

Then, as the closing credits began scrolling down the screen in our theater:

>I kissed him.

I sent a text back:

>And?

A minute or two later:

>Sadly, not a great kisser. I don't think he's going to do it for me :-)

I think I should have been disappointed, except that to me, the bigger thing here was that Katie had taken us to the next level — she was ready to consider dating someone else. And I suppose, I had confirmed that I was ready for her to do it.

She sent me another text:

>See you at home, ASAP? I have an itch that needs scratching :-P

I was out of that theater like a shot, clutching my notepad and my movie brochure, but otherwise thinking only of how to get home as quickly as humanly possible.

The sex was magnificent that night, as we both recognized that any day now — or probably, any night now — Katie really would make the fantasy real..

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It's funny — but by the time I was in a position to actually appreciate Katie finding fun and excitement with another man, I felt as though I was some kind of expert.

I'd been apprenticed under the great Henry Robinson, after all. I had bonded with the beautiful Michelle Robinson to the point where when she was with her husband, it felt as though I had been the one allowing her to be with another man.

I had witnessed my lover flirting in bars with strangers, going down on guys in parks, and even going to the homes of other men for sex.

And of course, I had already watched Katie herself being debauched by Grant.

So there was nothing really new in any of this, was there? Katie couldn't terrify me, couldn't shock me, couldn't make me jealous any more, surely?

I was well prepared. When I left Katie's house behind me in Fulham, I was but the learner. Now I was the master.

*

Only, when it actually came time for her to go out there into the wild world, and date another man, I suddenly found that everything had changed. I was a complete mess.

The night before, I couldn't focus on work at all — I was only saved by the fact it was the day after print deadline, when nobody generally did any work because the TV schedules at that stage were so tentative.

When I got home for my daytime sleep shift, I couldn't sleep a wink, and I couldn't afford to take sleeping pills and risk missing Katie before she went out on her date. Pure exhaustion ultimately allowed me a few hours' sleep, but then my array of alarm clocks jolted me out of bed in time for Katie's return from work.

And as I saw her come in through that door, all giddy and excited and glowing and fizzing with energy ahead of her evening with a brand new crush, and a night with a new and untried cock, it seemed to me that for the first time ever I suddenly understood just what Henry had been going through each time Michelle had dated me, or her more recent lovers.

It was unbelievably nerve-racking.

Her first officially sanctioned date under our new arrangement was to be Kit Marsh, a fairly senior surgeon who was on secondment at Katie's hospital for six months, down from the Manchester Royal. He seemed to Katie a happy compromise between a complete stranger, who she might not feel comfortable with on our first little adventure, and a trusted friend, whose trust and friendship might be forever wrecked if she seduced him and it went badly.

I was trying to keep calm all evening, so that she would at no point start to worry that I wasn't coping with this. I wanted her to think I was absolutely fine, that this was just wonderful for me. Oh, it was wonderful, but the anxiety, the powerful fear that something would go wrong, that I would send her out there only to have her return with the kind of man who

would persuade her to get rid of me once and for all... well, he was a senior surgeon. An impressive man, by her account.

I had to rein it in, stamp out the butterflies in my stomach, focus on the positive side, the appreciation of her joyful exuberance.

She demanded my company while she pulled off her work clothes and tried on a range of different clothes. I was ogling her like a teenage boy as she stripped off and jumped into the shower, washing the day's grime from her stunning body, shaving her legs and her sweet pussy right in front of me.

I loved how buzzing she was with anticipation as she chatted about this guy she was about to take out for a first date.

"He's been hitting on me ever since he arrived. Others too, but I guess because I'm blonde he sees me as more of a target..."

"Or because you're more attractive than anyone else."

"I don't know. There's a few hotties on the surgical ward."

I was so full of emotions, it was hard to keep it down.

Watching her sifting through her lingerie drawer, trying on various combinations before opting for reliably sexy black lace, and asking my opinion on each of the options along the way.

"He knows I'm married, I guess he thinks I'm cheating... Okay, how about this one?"

"Looks pretty good."

"...I think he's gone through two or three wives himself... Oh, what d'you think about this? Think he'll like it?"

Noticing how she put her stockings and suspenders on before her little black thong panties, so the straps were underneath that little scrap of material that covered her sex. Easy access for another man...

I'd taken the night off, of course, though the ultimate ambition for our new arrangement was that if I was working nights, she could happily see other guys since we wouldn't get to see each other anyway.

I also had the offer of Henry's company, and even Michelle's company, to help get me through this first night.

"I'll be fine," I'd told them both. "I've already seen her with other guys, haven't I? I'll be fine."

"Okay," Henry had said reluctantly, giving me a prescient look that suggested I didn't quite know what I was talking about yet, "but if you start

to find it hard going, you get on that phone and I'll stick my fingers down my throat, bunk of work sick."

"I'm sure there's no need for that," I said.

But as it came time for Katie to give herself a final look over in the mirror in the living room, and then ask me one last time if I was really, truly, honestly okay with this, I started to feel regret that I hadn't taken Henry up on the offer of his company.

As I told her that I was absolutely fine, that I couldn't wait for her to get out there and have a good time, then come back to me afterward, I was absolutely stunned at just how incredible she looked.

Her burgundy dress fell to mid-thigh level, showing plenty of leg in those sexy black nylon stockings, while also pushing up her chest to flaunt her cleavage. Her honey-gold hair was carefully brushed, parted at the side and tied at the back in a sophisticated loose bun. Her makeup had been applied subtly and yet heavier than usual, particularly around her eyes, which gave such a powerfully seductive effect it made me feel quite light-headed. Her silver jewelry was simple and yet elegant, her earrings drawing attention to her pretty face, her drop pendant sending the eyes helpless down to the temptations of her breasts, and even the matching silver bracelet hinting that her delicate hands might be used for wicked deeds later that night.

She'd never looked this way before for me. She'd never put this much effort into our initial dating or our marriage. And yet, having seen her at the wedding looking gorgeous, but not quite to this level of perfection, I was aware in that moment that actually, she was doing this for me.

The whole evening she'd been teasing me. Driving me wild. And now, she didn't just look as though she was going out on a date with some kind of desperate need to impress a new guy — she could have done that with half the glamour she now projected, and she knew it — she was dating a man for the benefit of us both, to enjoy the physicality of it herself, and to give pleasure to me through her own pleasure and my own twisted kink.

This whole thing was for me more than the guy she was dating.

I found it hard to get a word out as she tucked a strand of hair behind her ear and reminded me that she wasn't entirely sure if she'd be back tonight or not, since there was the chance he might want to take her back to his place.

We'd talked about this, and as much as I would have enjoyed watching her with another guy — I had already done that. This whole experience now

was for her to have the kind of freedom she might enjoy as a single woman — and for me to enjoy the playful glow that status conferred on her — and reclaim her as she shared tales of her thrilling experiences.

I was sure somewhere down the line I'd get to watch her again. Tonight was just a start to her dating.

"I'll try to text you when I can," she said, opening the front door, my heart feeling as though it was attempting to escape through my throat.

"Great."

"If we're coming back here, you'll need to have all the lights off and keep clear of the bedroom," she said as though we hadn't already discussed this.

"Of course."

"You have no idea how much this means to me. How exciting this all is."

"That's why it's so wonderful for me."

"I love you."

"I love you too. More than ever."

Click went the door.

*

Jesus, how did Henry ever stand this? I suppose he and Michelle started a little more slowly than I was with Katie — for a long while, I had simply taken Michelle out on platonic dates, after all. Even so, I knew that the sudden heartache I felt for Katie was exactly what my best friend had been feeling for his wife after he'd sent her to seduce me.

I was suddenly regretting taking the day off. At least at work I might have some chance of distraction.

Being a night worker, I couldn't even really rely on sleep to take away some of that long, long stretch of time waiting for my beloved wife to come home.

I just had to wait.

Strangely enough, it wasn't entirely awful. The pangs were there in my stomach, the butterflies, the fear. But I was tingling all over from start to finish as I thought of her going out to meet her date, of them sharing dinner

while gazing into each others' eyes, both imagining how it might be to make love to the other.

I was checking the clock each half hour, and although there was a little frustration that she wasn't texting me every ten minutes with an update, I felt progressively more and more aroused as time went on, as my certainty grew that Katie and her date must have been enjoying each others' company — and that the likelihood of following through on it was steadily building.

I tried watching movies, I even started skimming the local theater listings to see if I could get out for a screening of something half-decent. I couldn't focus on anything like that, though.

I made myself some dinner — a cheese and ham omelet, nothing too demanding — and aired out the house to ensure no lingering whiffs of cooking detracted from Katie's seduction if the lusty couple decided to come back here.

I wandered around the house, aimlessly looking at things, finding myself drawn particularly to items associated with Katie's separation from me — that somehow seemed to emphasize her liberation, her newfound freedom, the sense of individualism she brought into our newly-formed marriage that seemed so very sexy to me.

Well, I had a lot of time on my hands, and my mind was all over the place.

I looked at the impressive array of lingerie she had procured since our split. The shoes, the bags. The vibrators in the top drawer of her bedside table. The half-empty box of condoms in the bathroom medical cabinet.

I was rock hard thinking about her reasons for buying condoms when she was also on the pill, and why the box might be half-empty. Naughty girl.

A couple hours after their dinner had started, the smartphone lodged firmly in my back pocket buzzed, and I was trying to avoid having a seizure long enough to read the text message she'd sent.

>Dinner was nice. Kit knows a few things about wine! Going to find somewhere to go dancing. Maybe check out 'the goods' ;-)

Well, that was great.

Oh, and there was a selfie sent along with the text, of Katie looking exquisite in that burgundy dress, her cheeks faintly pink from the wine or the building excitement.

I sent her a text back:

>Fantastic, hope you enjoy your dancing, hope 'the goods' live up to expectations ;-)

It felt as though my state of arousal stepped up a gear at the knowledge that there would no longer be a table, a meal and a disapproving crowd of respectable diners around them to stand between them, now they were moving on to a nightclub.

I was semi-hard as I attempted to distract myself with a video game, to no real avail. I was getting killed on Grand Theft Auto.

I went to make up the sofa-bed in the spare bedroom, which looked out over the front of the house, while the master bedroom faced the little garden out back. It was a strange feeling: I don't think I'd even been into the spare room since I'd moved back in with Katie. And yet here I was about to shut myself up inside it, while she brought another man home and fucked him just yards away.

At least, that was the hope.

I prepared my little priest hole with bedding, and with a bottle of mineral water and some snacks in case I found myself shut in there through the night.

She sent a couple of texts while I was preparing my end of the bargain.

>We're at Ronny Scott's — lots of slow jazz numbers to dance to. He's been holding me close... and we kissed a few times. Lots of tingling down below! I'm pretty sure he has a huge one ;-)

Wow, it felt like some kind of neutron bomb detonating inside my stomach. My head reeled.

And my cock was hard as hard could be.

There was no selfie this time, and it seemed to me that she must have tapped out a text message while Kit was going for drinks, or taking a bathroom break himself.

I felt this overwhelming urge to call her, but I didn't know what to say if I did. There was that little part inside me that wanted to beg her to come back, to stop all this, to give me release from all these intense feelings. And yet the rest of me was embracing those feelings, and desperately keen for her to go through with this, to have one of the greatest nights of her life.

I just texted her back:

>That's good — I know how you like the huge ones ;-)

She asked me:

>You're okay, sweetie? Honestly?

And I could do nothing but reassure her:

>Never better. Such a turn-on hearing what a good time you're having.

She had time for an exchange of the I-love-yous, and then I'm guessing she was back into the dancing, leaving me sitting there on a sofa-bed, a little out of breath.

A little later, after I'd taken a fairly lengthy shower in another attempt to relax and use up a little more of my waiting time, I received another text.

>We keep kissing like we're teenagers. Had to move to a shadier part of the dance floor so we're not thrown out :-). Amazing chemistry with him, tingling all over. Panties are so wet, think I might have to take them off.

My prick was straining inside my pants at that, throbbing away like a science experiment. Imagining her on that dance floor, his hands sprawling all over her, pulling her in for a kiss at every given opportunity.

Their "amazing" chemistry tweaking the heartstrings, injecting that sharp acid of jealousy and fear into my stomach, while at the same time swamping my blood vessels with adrenaline and fanning the flames in my rampant erection...

God in Heaven.

I replied:

>Next time you'll have to take spares. Or I can bring you spares, and be like your pit crew :-P

I was actually thinking how great it would be to be out there, watching her flirting and teasing and coming onto her date all evening, dancing with him close, pressing herself up to him — kissing him, if I could stand to see that now, until it was time for her to take him home.

But this was a first step. To control my experience of the date as it was actually unfolding, so that I wasn't overloaded.

I had to wait another hour, wondering what he hell was going on. My wife was being held and kissed by her date while her underwear was soaking wet — how long could it be before they decided to take things somewhere a little more private?

I suddenly worried that she'd mislaid her phone, or that she was so wrapped up with her new man that she was unable to text me and warn me they were coming. I wanted them to come here — that was my other concern, that they would decide to go to his place — but some warning would have been nice.

I went round the house locking up and turning out all the lights, making things appear so that Katie's new lover would imagine her husband to be out of town.

Sat in the dark in that spare bedroom, the only light came from the street and from the screen of my Kindle.

Then, after what seemed like an age, another text:

>Okay to bring Kit home tonight?

My heart thudded loudly at a 100 beats per minute. My hands and feet prickled with pins and needles.

>Sure, lights are out, you're ready to go :-)

Then, a few minutes later:

>We're on our way xxx

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Chapter Fourteen | Judgment Day

I left my door open a little more than a crack so that I might hear them. Was I being a masochist? Undoubtedly. But I could cope. I'd been through it before, I told myself. My heart told me that this was different, though. Last time, we'd been on a break. This time, she was mine, my wife, my beloved, my one and only.

They were on their way. I spent five minutes or so performing a last check of the house — it was tidy, nothing unexpected, nothing to give the game away.

Then I was back in the spare room, waiting. Breathing. Trying not to go crazy, the excitement and anxiety jostling for position inside me just so intense. I knew it would be a good half-hour or so before they could get back from Soho to Clapham in a taxi this time of night, but I couldn't afford to stray outside that spare room if they were faster.

I was so hard, even without touching myself, just from preempting what was about to happen.

The street was a fairly quiet one, set back from main roads. The occasional car went by, each time setting my pulse racing again, as I thought it might be their taxi.

And then there they were. The rattle of a taxi's diesel engine approaching our address, slowing, stopping. The bang of the car door, a soft murmur of conversation — Katie's voice, and that of an unfamiliar male. My hairs stood up on the back of my neck, the skin on my arms broke out into goosebumps. My cock stiffened inside my jeans.

Wow, wow, wow.

I couldn't believe how thick the air seemed as I breathed, how warm and yet how much I was shivering. I lay on that sofa-bed on my side, ears pricked, as still as I'd ever been in my lifetime.

I heard them open the front door, enter the house. The light in the hallway being switched on.

"My humble home," Katie's voice. Easily heard from where I was, thanks to the complete lack of soundproofing in this Victorian house.

“Very nice.”

“Small. Clapham’s so expensive for south of the river.”

“Everywhere in London’s expensive — and small.”

“Hey, I have some wine somewhere...”

I heard them move through to the kitchen, the clink of glasses and a bottle, and though I couldn’t quite distinguish words while they were there toward the back of the house, I heard Katie’s flirtatious laughter — and the low voice of her new lover.

The sound did travel well in this house. I think if you were trying to creep around — of if you had a baby asleep — the way those floorboards creaked and you could hear it crystal clear all over the house would be annoying. But for this voyeur of a husband, it was ideal.

Wine in hand, they returned to the front of the house and the living room, which was directly underneath my spare room. I was breathing so hard I was fearful they might even tell I was up there just above them.

I could hear the creak of the couch as they sat together, the clink of glasses and even the slurp of their sips.

“Mmm... not bad.” Kit, the wine connoisseur, complementing the bottle I had provided for them.

“So where were we before we had to leave that nice warm taxi?” Katie, drawing his attention back to her.

The sound of glasses being placed on the coffee table.

“I think... you were doing your best to feel me up...”

A sexy little giggle from Katie, and I could actually hear them kiss.

“...and I had my hand up here... where I discovered you have no panties on...”

Katie moaned, and it seemed as though the sound vibrated every cell in my body. I could hear the wet sounds of their kisses, and it drove me wild. But it was the sound of Katie’s soft sighs, her quiet moans, her unmistakable sexual pleasure that turned me on like nothing I’d ever experienced before.

I’d felt vague hints at this kind of arousal before — when I had felt some kind of possession of Michelle and then she’d gone back to her husband, for example — but none of that had been anything like I now felt with Katie down there in the arms of another man.

What I’d felt with Michelle and Henry had been like looking at a shadow on the wall of something, rather than the object itself. The jealousy I felt to

know they were kissing each other, and had been for a while at the nightclub, was there in sharp detail. It was something that would send other men into a murderous rage, perhaps, but though powerfully intense, I had long since psychologically coupled the feeling with the erotic feelings of lust for my wife, and the warm altruistic joy of knowing she was wildly enjoying herself.

Was she touching his cock? Did he have his hand between her legs, resuming his touching of her after his discovery that she'd lost her panties at some point at the nightclub?

They were making out for a long while, and I heard the sound of a zip being unfastened. His fly, or her dress?

Katie gasped, and then said: "Oh... it's nice..."

I was guessing she'd unfastened his fly, and was now gazing upon her new lover's manhood. I breathed deeply, tried to keep calm.

And I could hear her sucking on him.

The wet sounds of her lips stretching around him, her mouth enveloping him, and his own heavy breathing, the quiet grunts as she squeezed him in her fingers and bobbed her head up and down over him.

I wanted to see so badly... and yet, just listening to them somehow allowed me to appreciate the fact I could hear them at all.

Somehow the jealousy wasn't so intense at the thought of her taking his big cock inside her mouth, or at least not compared to the experience of her kissing another man. I guess it was less affectionate, purely sexual. It didn't hint that she might be falling for this guy in the way that long periods of romantic kissing might.

Did that mean I should ban her from kissing other man in future? Well, she wasn't a hooker, and I wasn't her pimp. This was about her own independence, her own liberation. I felt the need to be as non prescriptive as possible. I'd just have to get used to the idea of her kissing someone else, mentally separate the act from the loving kisses we shared.

"Come on... upstairs..."

I heard her voice, and then the sound of them getting up from the couch, moving to the hallway and the stairs. Then they were climbing to my floor, and my heart rate picked up even more, if that was possible.

I'd left my door open a crack, and suddenly felt vulnerable — would they see I was in there as they came upstairs?

Concealing the sound as I hauled myself up off the sofa-bed in the heavy clomps of the two of them climbing the stairs, I wedged myself in the corner behind the door, the safest spot in a room offering few hiding places from what I could see. Then I leaned over, edging close to the crack in the door by the hinges.

I stifled a gasp as I saw Katie in the darkness leading an older man up the final few stairs to the landing. She looked great, of course, still in that burgundy dress and stockings, and as she turned her face briefly my way — double-checking, perhaps, that I was there — the look of elation on her face was breathtaking. I nearly came right then and there.

He had dark hair with the hint of silver showing even in the low light. He might have been late 40s, very early 50s. Not quite old enough to be her father, but the age gap was significant, and somehow it made it all seem a little more wicked. A little more like an affair.

“You have a nice place,” he said as he followed her into the master bedroom.

“It’s not exactly Hampstead.”

“No, but you’ll get there. You’re a very talented surgeon.”

I could hear clothes being taken off, and suddenly the urge to see my wife with her new lover was too much to bear. We’d talked about my being there in the house this time — although in future, she might be dating men while I was safely packaged away at work. But though we’d agreed that it would be okay for me to be there in the spare room listening to them, we hadn’t talked about an attempt by me to watch.

Only, Katie now put on some soft music — some kind of soft jazz that perhaps continued the atmosphere from the club they’d been enjoying earlier in the evening — and it was suddenly difficult to hear the subtleties going on in that bedroom.

I felt confident that the darkness in that little house lent me some protection, so I slowly pushed the door open a fraction more, and tentatively peered around it to see what I could see.

What I could see was a wide open door to the bedroom, much of the bed in there, and Katie standing at the foot of the bed looking over the sprawling naked form of a trim older man. He certainly didn’t have the body of an older man, other than a slight dusting of salt and pepper on his chest — had to be a gym regular, though I got the impression it was probably his own gym or a private members’ club rather than the kind of

gym I might go to if I was so inclined. His large cock was standing there at full mast — impressive, I guess, if that was your thing. I suppose it was Katie's thing, but I wasn't feeling inadequate with my more average size, and strangely enough it seemed nice that in granting her dating independence, I was allowing Katie the chance to enjoy a larger cock every now and then.

I couldn't see her new lover from the neck up, but then perhaps that was fortuitous, making me safe to watch so long as it stayed that way.

Katie glanced briefly in my direction, and flashed me the biggest, broadest smile ever. It was full of excitement and lust, of course, but also appreciation and gratitude for a husband would give her this experience. She seemed happy enough for me to watch, if I could get away with it.

Then she allowed her dress to fall to the floor, leaving her standing there looking sensational in a black bra, with black stockings and suspenders, while her lover rolled a condom onto his hardness.

She climbed slowly up his body, enthralled by the knowledge she had two men gazing upon her, besotted.

She was kissing him again, though I couldn't quite see it, it brought back that sharp feeling of hurt that I'd probably never admit to Katie for fear of provoking her guilt. It was hurt, and yet it also gave me pleasure — how to explain that to someone who might never fully understand it? Someone who loved me and did not want me hurt by anything or anyone?

I saw his hand reach down over her bare behind, squeezing her, stroking her. The watch around his wrist, no doubt a Rolex of some kind.

As they kissed, he slipped the catch on her bra, then she sat up to remove it.

My heart was in my throat, my bulging manhood squeezed in my hand as I watch her reach for his hard cock, line it up between her legs, and then take him inside her. Her eyes closed, her mouth opened as she sank onto him, groaning at the sensations as he filled her.

I watched her slowly rise and fall on him, and I could see that thing disappearing inside her.

Incredible. I guess men are highly visual creatures, hence the worldwide popularity of pornography. But this was like watching the most erotic, the most beautiful pornography ever filmed — and starring a woman I adored, both physically and emotionally.

It's hard to describe just how much more intense and thrilling an experience it was, because it was my wife I was watching.

I guess it was a little like the difference between watching any old football team playing against an average side in a fairly meaningless game, versus watching your own favorite team, the team you've been following all your life, and they're playing in the cup final or the Superbowl.

I was riveted. Didn't want to miss any detail. Every sexy little move from Katie pumped adrenaline through my body, every soft sigh and gentle moan made me fizz all over, and every time she uttered some kind of hot, dirty commentary on what was going on, I felt the tickle of jealousy only boost the thrill of the experience. .

"Oh God, I love your big cock..."

I swear she was angling herself so I could watch that great thing sinking inside her, his hands squeezing her butt, pulling her cheeks apart so he could split her.

I could see the lips of her pussy gripping his cock.

She brushed her hair back over her shoulders with both hands, her breasts poised so beautifully over him, but then she was turning, lifting her knee, her leg over and away. Swiveling, before straddling him again but facing away from his head — and toward me.

I saw him now holding his shaft up for her to sink down on once again, only now I watched as he disappeared into that smooth shaven pussy and saw it all from the front, Katie leaning a little forward, away from his face, as she began rocking back and forth on his length once again.

She turned her head a little, and as she bounced on his cock, she was looking straight at me.

Her cheeks flushed, her lips pouting as she panted for breath, her thighs flexing as she bounced on his hard cock, she was gazing at me, as though it was me she was fucking, me making her feel so incredible.

It was so hot, I let the door swing open a little, and sat on the corner of that sofa bed, showing her how hard she was making me. I swear, it made her pick up her pace, while she fucked him, certainly made her smile spread across her pretty face again. Loving making two men so hard at the same time.

"Oh fuck... it's so big inside me... so hard..." she groaned, and it seemed she was saying it to me, not her older man.

“God you’re so tight... so hot...” I heard Kit groan, and I actually enjoyed hearing him appreciating her.

After a while, he sat up, grabbed her bodily as though wanting to reclaim his alpha male credentials, and pulled her down and into a side-by-side spoon position where he could grab her hips, and fuck her from behind, taking control from her.

I could no longer look into her eyes, but could see him entering her, squeezing inside her to make her cry out.

Then he urged her up onto her hands and knees, and onto all fours, and she went willingly.

Silently closing my door again other than the crack I needed to see, I had to be careful to avoid being spotted as the guy knelt behind her and stroked the tip of his cock between her buttocks.

Watching him fucking her like that seemed to connect with that animalistic part of me that drove this whole fantasy — that made me desire my wife more because she was mating with another male.

She was a vixen in heat, shuddering with every thrust he forced into her, and my body was doing everything in its power to prepare me to go to her and reclaim her.

She came like that, or at least that’s what it sounded like. Crying out, blaspheming, screaming like I swear I’d never heard before as her body shook under him.

She offered him an amused, naughty grin as she turned to him afterward, suggesting that she hadn’t quite expected an orgasm like that.

“I’m sorry you can’t stay longer,” she said, lying back against the pillows.

“You have a big day tomorrow,” he said, apparently accepting her wishes for this date to end on a high note. “Not every day you get a quintuple.”

“I’m only assisting on this one.”

“You know how Frank likes to delegate. And you were always his favorite.”

It was strange to hear her talking about work. But it made me feel somehow that this was part of work — that she needed sex to thrive in what she did, and that taking out her frustrations on her co-workers might just be the most natural thing in the world.

As Katie lay there looking up at him, Kit straddled her stomach and now pulled his condom off, sliding his bare cock up between her breasts.

“It’s been nice,” she was almost purring as he stroked his shaft and brushed his tip against the soft, soft skin of her cleavage.

“I was surprised,” he smiled, and Katie’s fingers were curling around his cock, so she could take over pumping him that last stage of the journey. “I never thought you’d be interested.”

She ducked down and kissed the tip of his cock. “Oh, I was always interested. Only I finally decided to stop resisting it.”

She seemed so relaxed when it came to the end, and he was spurting his thick white come all over her breasts, her neck, her chin. As though she’d simply challenged a colleague to a game of squash in the local sports center, and now the game was all over, nice and civilized.

“Well, perhaps we could do it again, some time.”

“That would be lovely.”

I received a little frisson of the old jealousy at that, but how could I oppose the idea of her seeing him again? Although I’d reacted poorly to their kissing, the whole episode really had been about the sex. I got the feeling that as colleagues, they weren’t supposed to be getting involved, not that that had particularly stopped Katie during our separation.

They lay together for a while, recovering, talking about work. I listened to them putting some clothes back on, Kit at least putting all of his back on, and then Katie showed him down to the door.

I was at the window, watching for him to leave. I’m not sure what they were saying to each other on the doorstep, though whatever it was included plenty of Katie flirting and laughing with him from the sounds. A taxi arrived, and I watched him get in, watched it take him all the way down the street and away from us, without the possibility that he might change his mind and come back, demanding to spend more time with Katie.

When I turned, she was sitting there on the edge of the sofa bed, a big question on her face.

“So?”

Chapter Fifteen | Intoxicating

She was wearing her silk bathrobe, one I had given her for Christmas maybe two or three years back. It parted a little to reveal her black lingerie underneath.

What a picture.

Her mussed hair, her flushed cheeks, her smudged make-up, her lipstick smeared.

I cradled her head in my hands, touched my nose to hers. She'd mopped up since receiving his load all over her breasts and her face, but she still had that distinctive smell of sex all about her. Intoxicating.

"How was it for you?" I asked her, stressing the point, perhaps, that for me this was all about her enjoyment.

"It was out-of-this-world amazing. And it wouldn't have been without you..."

Her voice was a touch different from the normal Katie, as though she'd moved into a higher gear. Excited, satisfied, mellow yet bubbly like she'd taken some kind of drug. I loved it, it showed just how amazing this whole thing had been for her.

But there were still doubts in her voice after this first time, mainly as to how I was really taking her infidelity.

"But what did you think?"

"You were incredible."

I moved to kiss her, but she pushed me back briefly.

"You want me to go clean up? Get in the shower?" she asked, concerned, unsure how this was supposed to go down.

"No," I said, "I want you just the way you are."

I touched my mouth to hers, sucking gently on her top lip, breathing in that wicked, heady scent, reconfirming the adultery I'd witnessed with my own eyes, and set my insides alight all over again.

Gently I ran my fingers down her soft neck, and then her upper chest, detecting the slight traces that said another man had come all over her here, despite her quick attempt to clean up.

“He made you come?”

“Twice.”

She'd put her bra back on to see her lover out, but I now knelt before her and slipped one breast out of it, to kiss her nipple, which was soft but then stiffened up as I sucked on her, tasting the first hints of another man's touch.

“You're not totally freaked out?” she whispered, slipping her other breast out of the black lace as though begging for attention.

“Only in a good way,” I smiled.

She looked down, her hand running over her pussy, showing me that she was wearing panties again, and appearing to test her own response as though she didn't quite believe that another man had been servicing her there just minutes previously.

“Show me,” she whispered. “Show me how I made you feel.”

I stood up, unfastened my belt, my fly. Her hands moved to my crotch, one hand pulling open my pants, the other reaching in to grasp my hardness.

“Mmm...” she purred, her fingers enclosing my shaft, pulling it out into the open. “Yummy.”

“Not quite up to your latest standards, I suppose.”

She looked up at me with a protesting pout, “Just because I like steak every now and then, doesn't mean a great burger isn't still my favorite meal.”

I laughed at that, “You just have to dress it up with a few more garnishes, right? A little more sauce...”

“I'll show you sauce...”

Pumping my shaft, she touched the tip of her tongue to the tip of my cock, before looking up at me with a teasing grin. Then she was holding it like a microphone, opening her mouth to wrap her lips around the head of my cock.

Oh, it felt nice, the intense heat of her mouth on the sensitive head of my bulging prick, but what struck me as immensely erotic just then was the feeling that this wasn't just about rewarding me for my giving her the evening's experience. She was enjoying sucking my cock as much as I was, because it was evidence of my desire for her, and my excitement at witnessing her performance with another man.

With my cock as hard as it had ever been, I was proving that this strange but wonderful lifestyle choice of ours was fine with me, that she could quite

happily date other men with my knowledge without being riddled with guilt.

I stroked her hair as she sank down on my length, rose, and sank again. Satisfied with my hardness, with the proof of my genuine response to her dating, she pulled me down for a long kiss, to taste her lips that had been wrapped around two different cocks that night.

“I thought you lost your panties in the nightclub?” I asked her, as she now leaned back, still sitting on the edge of the mattress with her feet on the floor, but her back flat against the bed.

“I didn’t lose them,” she said. “I just took them off for a while.”

I stroked my mouth and nose down over her stomach, and kissed my way along the waistband of her black thong, where that intoxicating smell of sex, of her perfume, of her juices was so very strong.

Kissing around her stomach, my hand strayed over her mound, over her panties, and I found just how wet they were, still.

God, it seemed so taboo. She’d only just finished fucking her date, and here I was indulging in her used form, the traces of her wickedness still plainly apparent.

I drew the front panel of her damp panties down to uncover her smooth hairless pink slit, glistening and puffy, flushed from use. Made my mouth water just to gaze upon it, framed by her stockings, her garter belt, those suspenders.

Had she really taken that man’s prick inside this beautiful pussy?

She moaned softly as I kissed it, enveloping its apex in my hot mouth, inhaling her spicy scent, the hint of their contraception, the lingering trace of a man’s cologne.

My tongue coursed through her slippery folds, lapping up her copious juices, sampling her flavor, which was both familiar and quite unlike what I was used to. The taste of my wife’s used pussy, her naughty kitty. Irresistible.

I wasn’t squeamish that another cock had entered this glorious pussy, I ate her with wild abandon, this exquisite blonde who was so sinful, so sexy.

She knew how I liked to go down on her, and now she knew I definitely did not view her adulterous copulation as distasteful or anything to put me off from enjoying her like that.

I guess she was relieved, she was able to relax while I lapped at her, let go and enjoy it fully, my hot mouth covering her little sensitive bud, my

fingers slipping inside her slick groove to track down her g-spot inside.

She brought one of my hands up to fondle her breasts as her body writhed under me.

After a long while, she seemed desperate for more, and rolled over under me, onto her hands and knees. I held her from behind, removed her bra and stroked it over her face, making her breathe in the smell of sex from that black lace. To appreciate how filthy this all was, my taking of her sullied body, her pre-fucked form.

I pressed my cock briefly up against her behind, but then I was kissing my way down the curve of her back, my fingers hooking into the waistband of her panties to pull it over the gorgeous roundness of her behind, which I could hold in both hands while I ducked to find her soaking pussy once again, this time the unexpected continuation of my oral pursuit causing her to bubble over into a full climax.

She was so very wet, wetter than I'd known her to be, even from the beginning. She tasted so delicious.

Then I was up on my knees again, and it seemed right and appropriate that this would be how I would reclaim her, mounting her like an animal, my bare cock touching lightly against the searing lips of her pussy where earlier that night, another man's sheathed cock had penetrated.

I might have been more normal in size, but while I couldn't help but notice her pussy feeling a little different than it had before stretching to accommodate such a big guy, it was still tight and glorious around me. And I still made her quiver under me, crying out as I filled her, biting her lip as I thrust inside her.

This just wasn't the normal sex experience for me, not the normal marital fuck. It was dirtier, it was messier, more vocal. It was spurred on by real adrenaline.

It was the future, and both of us could see it.

"Oh God... oh God... oh God..."

"You can feel that after the monster you fucked tonight?"

"Jesus yes... don't stop... don't stop..."

"You think you'll see him again? Your friend Kit?"

"Yes... yes... yes..."

"You'll have to be careful if you want to do anything at work."

"Oh he's gonna fuck me... there's a ton of places we can go... he's going to put that huge cock inside me..."

Oh, the excitement that can be caused by a wife simply spouting all manner of blue language.

She rolled over so I could fuck her missionary style, like all good married couples were supposed to, except that I could press my face into her breasts and detect the faint traces of another man's come.

"Oh God I love you, Sean..."

"I love you too."

"I love you so much for letting me have him."

"Any time. Just so long as I get to hear about the details. Maybe watch you now and again..."

The force as I finally came deep inside her was like water breaking through the Hoover Dam. I have never experienced anything like it. The power of that energy flowing through me, the feeling of my cock throbbing deep inside her tight pussy as pulse after pulse of thick come splashed inside her.

I had truly experienced heaven.

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Epilogue

You know that phrase about having your cake and eating it? Well, I feel kind of like I've achieved that.

Maybe, ultimately, it has even been worth all the pain along the way.

Ends justify the means, so to speak.

Henry drives me back home from work in his battered brown Austin with the creaky old black leather seats, since he doesn't do the Tube in the wintertime, all those germs floating around.

We lurk outside in the street a while, and I feel nervous, for some reason, though in a good way. It makes me feel alive.

"You think you'd ever let her play with Grant again?"

"Sure, why not? It's just... you know, she's been craving new cock at the moment, not old favorites."

"It's kind of hot that he's out there, ready, waiting for her."

"I feel like I need to punish him a little first."

We talk, about this or that, about the sharing of our wives, about the ongoing lack of any kind of job satisfaction in the field of journalism, about trivial stuff like what we watched on TV recently.

"Season Two, my friend. The Vice President and his wife have a threesome with the Secret Service guy."

"Hey, spoiler alert. I'm halfway through Season One."

"Oh, it's nothing you're not expecting. But it shows — this is all going mainstream, my friend."

"I'm not sure about that. They're hardly the most sympathetic characters. Society can't handle liberated wives."

"Society is missing out."

We wait with our crappy binoculars, monitoring the front door like fancy dress spoofs of Sam Spade or Philip Marlowe, the street still dark before the winter's dawn appears, the doorways of the terraced houses and the tiny front gardens bathed in the orange glow of the street lamps.

Henry's almost like my sponsor, only he's not there to support me in refraining from the addiction I have, he very much encourages me.

“She still with that anesthetist that waxes his whole body?”

“No, someone new tonight. First-year resident.”

“A younger man, huh? She might be tired.”

Tentatively, the front door opens, disappearing back into the darkness of the house. We both prick up our ears, tweak the focus on our cheap spy glasses to make sure we see the guy in question as he steps out, nervously glancing up and down the street as though concerned about being watched.

“He’s inexperienced. She thinks he’s cute, been after him a while.”

“Yeah? Those are the best. Michelle was after that guy in her yoga class forever, she’s totally fired up now she gets to have him.”

Katie’s latest looks to be in his late twenties, clean-shaven, dark hair, presentable. I get that familiar tightening of my stomach, the flicker of jealousy to look upon him, knowing he’s just bedded my wife. And I feel the tingle in my loins, the thickening of my cock, the shortness of breath to sense my turn has come.

Henry says, “I think tonight might be their first time going all the way, actually.”

“Sweet,” I reply, but I’m not really taking in what he’s saying.

Katie’s new guy is really checking out the street before stepping out of the doorway. Well, she has told him she has a husband. He doesn’t entirely believe her when she says I’m happy for her to play around like this. Can’t understand the concept of an approving husband. He’s sure I’m lurking somewhere, ready to pounce.

I’m not sure what he thinks I’d do to him if I caught him. That we’d get in a fist fight, that I’d damage his valuable surgeon’s hands.

We watch as he edges out onto the street, glancing this way and that, pulling up the collar on his coat to help conceal his identity, or perhaps merely to keep out the chill. His breath is steaming in the crisp air of this December morning. Perhaps we’ll have snow this year. We’ll have to come out from work with hot water bottles, the heater in Henry’s car offering little real joy in winter.

We’re silent as he turns toward us, and then we’re desperately pushing ourselves down in our seats, rolling over in case he does look inside the car, hoping he might take us for itinerants.

“Shhh!”

We’re giggling at how inept our surveillance tactics are. Henry shouldn’t have parked on this side of the street, but beggars can’t be choosers when it

comes to available spaces in London. It wouldn't be too much of a tragedy to be discovered. Katie's new guy would be more frightened of us than we would be of him, but it might scare off a promising new boyfriend for her.

"He's gone."

Henry's first up, and is rolling another joint. I usually don't partake these days, don't want anything getting in the way of reclaiming my beautiful, insatiable wife. Katie doesn't really approve of the wacky backy, anyway.

I haul myself up, twisting in my seat to examine the street behind me, my heart now thumping hard against the wall of my chest in anticipation of what is to come.

Oh, I hope Katie isn't too tired. She's been building me up to this one for a while, dropping me little details about the seduction, all those innocent lunches together, the drinks after work, the flirting, the teasing.

Sucking the guy's cock in a medical supplies room after the end of their shift one night.

"He is, definitely gone."

"Ready?"

"Ready. Hey, you need to get back to Michelle."

"Oh, she's out with her Camden buddies, won't be back for another hour."

A nod between us is all we need, and then I'm opening the car door, which lets out a groan of protest I suddenly fear will wake up the whole street. I don't really care. A quick salute to my comrade in arms before I turn for the hundred yards or so to my own front door, my pulse quickening all the way, my chest filling with fire.

I slot my key into the lock and wonder how blessed Katie's new playmate is in the trouser department. Got to be better than the anesthetist.

When I open the door and step inside, a waft of warm air rushes over me, bringing me the familiar smells of home laced with a hint of the unfamiliar. The traces of another man's cologne, the lingering suspicion of sex in the air. The house is too small to dilute it completely.

The scent stirs up the butterflies inside my stomach, ignites the arousal within my loins.

My Katie has been a naughty girl again.

Of course it's different this time, so much has happened in between, but each time I come home to an insatiable wife, I think of that first time, when she did not have consent, when my marriage seemed to collapse in one fell

swoop. With hindsight, I see that I always liked the idea that the woman who was mine was desired by other men. That was the whole point of my lifelong weakness.

Only, it took Henry and Michelle to show me the full reality of how I felt.

How ultimately sexy is the liberated woman? Wild and free and confident. And when it's someone you love dearly, so much the better.

This time, I climb the stairs thinking how I might have acted if I had already been harboring a fully developed fantasy for sharing my wife. I still think I would have been quite angry at Katie for her cheating, for her deception, but the thrill at finding that her lack of sex had driven her to take another lover would have been powerful for me. I would have felt a lot more conflicted than I did at the time, I think.

As I take the stairs one step at a time, the wicked scent in the air seems to strengthen.

There's a light on upstairs, coming from the bedroom. Just a single bedside lamp. It's enough to illuminate the familiar sexy sight of Katie standing in the doorway waiting for me, hair still a little mussed from the bed, make-up a little smeared though hastily re-applied, a telling flush in her cheeks.

"Hi you," she says softly, her voice cool, confident, yet laced with a hidden yearning.

"Hi yourself."

She's wearing no more than a t-shirt and panties. I've never seen the t-shirt before, it's ill-fitting, and obviously belongs to the man she's just slept with. She knows how something like that gets me.

As I approach her, her sweet perfume thickens, as does the musty organic aroma of sex. I shiver, but don't hesitate, my hands moving to cradle her head, my mouth closing in on hers.

I see in her pretty green eyes a wonderful delight at seeing me, and it warms me so very much. I see the constant surprise that I'm really here, really turned on by what she's just done, really allowing her to do it, and that our bond is perhaps even stronger because it has happened.

She might not fully understand why I feel this way, but she's either moving towards understanding, or simply better able to let it go, enjoy the symptoms of my madness, even if she cannot get to grips with the reasons for it.

Her lips are so warm, so sweet as we kiss, and I feel inside her the kind of passion we lost up until she took Grant to our bed.

Kissing her feels so right, and yet so wrong. There's the sweet beauty of everything that is Katie, and then that slightly unsettling and yet invigorating difference that denotes her consorting with someone else while I have been away.

These lips have kissed another man, this tongue has tasted someone else. This pretty mouth has stretched around the offensive weapon of a rival suitor.

The thrill of that wrongness ripples down my spine like a sip of the finest ice-cold Champagne.

We don't take a short-cut to bed and penetration, a quick route to climax. We stand there breathing each other in, sucking on lips, delving with tongues, hands frantically grabbing and caressing.

We act as though we've been apart from each other for a month, although the reality is that I saw her just 12 hours ago, after I'd just woken up and she'd just returned home from work, and though we did not make love, we shared some tender and highly erotic moments as I helped her prepare for her first date with this new man.

"Your date went well?" I ask quietly in between kissing.

I don't have to ask her to know the answer, of course, having seen the guy leaving our front door only minutes ago, and because I can smell the sex in the air, on my wife, on her mouth.

But I like hearing it from her.

"Very well," her smile is beaming, presenting me with a big row of white teeth that along with the gloss of her re-applied lipstick shines the light from the bedside table at me. "Can't you tell?"

I smile back at her. "Did you get any sleep?"

"Plenty," she said. "We both have to work today, so we were home early from dinner."

"You are responsible," I grin.

"One of us has to be," she said with mock gravity. "Nobody could ever accuse a husband like you of something like that."

She throws her arms around my shoulders, pulling me in for another slow, sensual kiss, as though to reward me for my strangeness as a husband. The undercurrent of the other man's cologne about her makes me shiver.

"But you liked him? You'd see him again?"

“Oh, yes,” she says, pulling me into the room, whirling me around as though we’re dancing in some southern ball, the toast of the town. “He’s no anesthetist, I can tell you.”

She pushes me back onto the bed, and the hungry look on her face almost makes me quiver. In the stronger light of the bedroom, I can see the traces of last night’s lipstick, and it spread on her face makes me imagine that pretty face of hers bobbing up and down on a younger man’s shaft.

“And your suspicions about his... gifts?”

A little smirk as she crawls onto the bed. “Well you know there wouldn’t have been any point keeping him here all night if he wasn’t gifted,” she says.

I can see down the neck of the t-shirt as she crawls up my body, see her shapely breasts hang beneath her, and how hard her nipples are. I don’t ever need to ask if she’s more turned on by her experience with another man, or by my return and subsequent reclamation. It’s a different experience, a different kind of arousal, you can’t compare. To me, it’s enough that she is, quite plainly, intensely turned on when I come back to her to claim her as my wife.

My hands hold her gently just under the ears, pulling her soft golden hair out of her face as we kiss again, and before they start roaming all over her beautifully soft curves — down the arch of her back, over the graceful rise of her behind, around her spectacular cheeks and up her side to find the pleasing orbs bearing her stiff little buds.

She grinds against my hardness, eager for a full reconciliation. In this, perhaps our gender roles of a conventional marital union are reversed: though she is attracted to me physically, she feels an urgency for penetration, for me to be inside her again, to come within her, to confirm once and for all that her sins are washed away, her infidelity was consensual and is now past history, while I myself want to take my time and experience this exquisite, voracious woman fully, appreciating the evidence of her uncontrollable sexuality.

She doesn’t force anything, though, we proceed at my favored pace. I press my face to her cleavage, breathing in the hot air from her body, glorying briefly in the essence that is strictly Katie — not some applied fragrance, or traces of her lover.

“So come on, tell me how it went,” I ask her.

My fondling her breasts spurs her to sit up offer a sleepy-sexy smile that adores my obvious passion for her, and haul her t-shirt up off over her head to reveal her magnificent breasts for my full appreciation and exploration, her golden hair catching the light as it flows everywhere while she's removing the item.

"We had a nice dinner," she says. "I guess it was a little weird because we've been working together for a while. I guess he was a little surprised I asked him out."

"Because a guy's supposed to do the asking out?"

"Because we've always kinda flirted with the idea in front of us that I'm married."

The hint of saltiness on her breasts is testament to a night of passion, and as I take her nipples in my mouth, the musty scent seems to confirm that her lover finished on her chest.

"So he knew going in, that this was more than just... platonic?"

"I told him my husband was out of town for a few days, and I wondered if he wanted to keep me company. He got the message."

I know it's the part of this she likes least — she doesn't feel completely comfortable talking dirty, never has. But it's the price for her sleeping with more than just me, she realizes that.

It's the way we keep this as being something between us, rather than something she does with other people.

But I feel it's a confidence thing, she'll get better. She doesn't yet know how completely hot it is when she says filthy things to me, when she says what she likes, what she wants, when she reveals her fantasies, when she details her experiences.

"Did you tell him I let you play with other guys?"

A nod. "I told him we have an open marriage, seemed simpler that way."

I lie back as we kiss, but then Katie sits up, leans back, pushing her hips forward to urge me to touch her between her legs. I love how insistent she is, and of course, how stunning she looks from that angle. Her neon pink panties with just a string around the waist, soaking wet and not for the first time that night.

I trace curious fingers over her contours, and seek out the dampness of her underwear.

"You're so wet," I say as my fingers slip under her panties to find her slick groove, her lips so oily, her hot flesh soaking.

“That’s what he said,” she smiles, then groans as I pull down the front of her panties and run the pad of my thumb up her slit, and past her sensitive little button.

“Tell me.”

She looks into my eyes, a smoldering look, of lust and uncertainty. Even now, she’s silently asking: you really want to know? This really turns you on?

I slide my thumb inside her, where not so long ago another man filled her. I don’t think it’s my imagination that she’s been stretched a little by her recent experience.

“We came home quite early,” she said, “had some wine. Talked about his dating — I guess as soon as he tells women he’s a surgeon, they’re desperate for a ring on their finger, but he doesn’t feel ready.”

“He wants a little fun first.”

“Uh-huh.”

I hold a finger coated in her juices up to my nose, breathing in the undiluted goodness drawn straight from the source. I slip it inside my mouth, and taste her, confirming the slight synthetic tinge of her lover’s sheath.

“So I told him there’s no chance I want a ring from him. We didn’t waste any time after that.”

She takes the in-for-a-penny, in-for-a-pound mentality now, the kind of attitude I love from her. I’m showing her no fear, no trepidation, no distaste from lying with her after she’s been with another.

Katie lifts one knee over my shoulder, and then the other. I scooch down slightly, my hands encircling her thighs as she eases back to deposit her pussy over my mouth.

She leans back again, watching me as I nuzzle into her pussy, slipping my tongue inside her, pressing my nose against her clit. Such a superlative view up her body, her erect nipples distracting, but not completely from her pretty face.

“You started up here?”

“We started downstairs,” she says, her voice strained, though perhaps it’s because she’s focused on unfastening my fly, retrieving my hardness from the confines of my pants. “Kissing, touching. A little wine. Not much talking.”

“You can talk to each other at work.”

A smile, then she says: "I couldn't stay down there long, though. Not after I felt it."

I feel a little jolt flash through my chest. "So he is big?"

"I told you Janine knows someone who dated him in med school?"

"But you never know when something like that is all hot air and rumors."

"This was no rumor."

She wiggles her hips a little, to stir her pussy against my mouth, and for a moment, she closes her eyes and just rides my face, even letting go of my cock as her breathing deepens. She leans further forward and presses down on me, her hands clamped to my head.

My face swamped by her hot, wet flesh, I feel the trembling mini-climax shooting through her pussy, her thighs, and for a moment or two as I feel my face supporting her whole body, I just have to hold on, survive. I'm thinking, if ever a man died this way, what a way to go.

Then she slows, eases up, though continuing to stroke her sex against my mouth. She leans back, reaches again for my manhood as though checking that everything is still okay, and she's so breathtaking sitting over me like that.

"He didn't do any of this," she said. "This is just for you, I think."

"But you did it for him?"

"Not at first. I had to get him inside me."

"Naughty girl."

She smiles sweetly, as though butter wouldn't melt in her mouth. But those lips sucked on someone else's big hard cock, lapping up his pre-come like ice cream.

And this pussy I'm now cleaning has stretched around that man's cock as well.

Katie pulls away from me and now pulls me up to remove my jacket and my shirt, before kissing me rapturously, rewarding me for her little orgasm. Letting me kiss that mouth that she's just told me sucked on some other man.

"And how was it?"

"Incredible."

I wrestle her onto her back, pull her panties off, can't resist burying myself in her dripping pussy again, I guess I'll never really have enough.

"He was... quite large."

"Bigger than Grant?"

“Bigger than Grant.”

I haul her to the edge of the bed, where it's easier. She doesn't complain, though the old Katie would have told me I'd had enough of that, it was time to move on to the main course. This is the main course for me: this is reclamation, after all. Not the same as normal sex. I have my beautiful wife sitting here on the bed in front of me after spending the night doing all sorts with another man. I have to satisfy my hunger for her now.

She smiles and runs her fingers through my hair as I gorge myself on her juices, one of her legs slunk over my shoulder, the other stretched out to the side, my arms under her thighs, her hips lifting slightly to rock herself against my mouth.

“You were never like this, not even when we first went out,” she says.

“I'm different now.”

“Oh Jesus...”

Something unexpected hits her, and she flops back on the bed to take it, her body seizing, quivering. Whether it's some kind of aftershock, or another little climax, I'm not sure. It takes her completely by surprise. I don't think it's just my tongue fluttering over her clit, my fingers slipping inside her to join the party. I think the whole experience, having the undivided attention of two different men in one night, having her husband return to show his adoration for her like this, it's just overwhelming for her.

The old rules don't apply any more.

She gasps for breath, brushing her hair back with her hands, tousling it as though to cope with the sensations flooding through her.

“How many times did you fuck him?”

She pushes me up, and I rise to my feet, letting her fumble with my belt, drag my pants down my legs.

“Three or four times... I suppose four times.”

She looks at my cock, standing there, comparing it to the others she's had. I guess I could feel intimidated that two of her recent lovers have been bigger than me, but I've never felt insecure about my size.

And really, what would the point be of having my wife live out her sexual fantasies if the guys she's doing it with are no fantasies themselves?

Part of the thrill for me is letting her have the kind of experiences she would not have unless I allowed her to have them. There would be little enjoyment in knowing her experience was underwhelming in any way.

None of the pleasure in any of this comes from hoping her other lovers are somehow worse than me in bed, and that their ineptitude will enhance my own status in Katie's life.

"Disappointed?" I ask her in jest, as she gently strokes my hardness, still peering at it intently.

She smiles, "Oh no. I was just thinking how perfect it is. It's mine, you know?"

"Certainly is."

She guides me back onto the bed and crawls between my legs.

"It's like, you remember when we had that office day out at Silverstone?"

"A bunch of surgeons tearing around a racetrack in Ferraris and Formula Three racecars? Your hospital must have had convulsions over the risk assessment."

A long lick up my shaft, and then a kiss at the tip. She says, "We were driving these cars worth, like, half a million quid. Okay, maybe not quite that, but still. And the speed was unbelievable."

"Of course."

"But at the end of the day I got back into my little Golf, and it was just... home, you know? The handling was great, the seats were so much more comfortable, the suspension didn't give you piles... and it was my car."

She sinks down onto my shaft, and it's her groaning as I'm taken to heaven, not just me.

"So you're saying I'm just a little Volkswagen, and your new guy is some kind of legendary super car?" I say, my tone still jovial, knowing where she's coming from.

"You like this, don't you?" she says, ducking her head down, smiling even as her face is full of my cock, making me feel like the king of the world.

"Of course."

"Well, I couldn't do it for very long with him, and I don't really enjoy it the way I do with you."

"I'll take that," I smile.

I love how her fair hair falls all over my thighs, my cock, the way her eyes are smiling at me even while her lips are busy. The love, the affection she shows me that are at a level above anything she could have with anyone else.

She climbs on board, and I slip the tip of my hardness inside her. We kiss, crushing our bodies together as I squeeze inside her, feeling how she's been temporarily affected by her Ferrari racing, though she's still tight around me, my own hardness filling her up inside.

Her lipstick is a little smeared again from sliding over my shaft, and it only confirms why her earlier application was similarly smeared.

"Careful," she says as my pace underneath her begins to accelerate.

"You fucked him four times," I say, blaming her for her soreness.

"I had to be sure," she smiles. "Who knows when you might get another bump on the head, and all this wife-sharing madness will end?"

I hold her and haul her over, and we're wrestling together, laughing, as though I can somehow prove my sanity by gaining the upper hand over her physically.

Forcing her down underneath me on the edge of the bed again, I stand to ease my hardness back inside her. I do treat her with care, though she's so wet from having the second cock in one night inside her devilish pussy that there's probably no fear of hurting her anyway. God she looks so sexy, her pretty face fresh and flushed, her hair all messed up by perspiration and our rough-and-tumble.

"The last time wasn't really fucking, anyway," she says.

"Is that right?"

"It was more just lying together, talking, and he was inside me."

"What were you talking about?"

"I don't know... our hopes, our dreams. We talked about our romantic history, I suppose. Our fantasies."

"Your fantasies? You don't talk to me about those so much."

"I suppose not. I've been kinda preoccupied of late with yours."

"True. And his fantasy was banging a hot blonde cardiologist, I suppose."

She shrugs. "I am his first older woman. He seemed to think I already changed him."

"I bet you have."

"So now he's interested in trying a threesome."

"A threesome. And you said you'd help him out with that?"

Katie flashes me a wicked smile. "Well I had already told him it was one of my top fantasies."

"And he wants another man present in this threesome, or another woman?"

“Another woman.”

“You have someone in mind?”

My wife reaches for her bedside table, and the smartphone sitting under the lamp. “Already asked her...” she says, smiling as she looks at the screen and reads the text message waiting for her. “And looks like she’s up for it as well.”

“And she’s a friend of yours?”

“A friend of yours, actually. Michelle Robinson,” she offers me a mischievous grin. “Well, you had your fun with her for long enough, didn’t you? It’s about time I did, too.”

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